More Than Best Friends

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Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), She-Ra (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Fluff, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Humor, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Friendship, Shadow Weaver is a bitch, Slow Burn, Glimmer Ships It, So does Bow, clueless, Oblivious, Bow is ace, Glimmer is literally me like a year ago, Bow is trans, Bow has two dads, wow tags are fun, Plot, Breaking the Fourth Wall, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting

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by kerryberry

Summary

When Catra is banished from the Horde, she wants nothing to do with anyone or anything. But then she gets trapped in a magic building with her ex best friend Adora, who just so happens to also be the legendary princess She-Ra, and she realizes that nothing can keep the two apart. They learn about love from the world of princesses and grow closer than ever.

Notes

So recently I've become really really really obsessed with the new She-Ra and have already done fanfic, cosplay, etc (im trash) so here is part one of a catradora story im writing because I live for catradora.

This all takes place at around season 1 episode 10 and on.

See the end of the work for more notes

The Beacon

Catra

"Not only did you happily let She-Ra and the princess known as Glimmer escape but I learned that you've known Adora was She-Ra since the battle at Thaymor." Lord Hordak's voice echoed from the shadows as Shadow Weaver stared Catra down.

"I didn't-"

"Don't lie to us, cadet." Shadow Weaver spat. "This isn't the first time you've broken the rules but it has got to be the worst. We have cameras showing you handing the Sword of She-Ra to Adora and the princess, allowing them to escape." She announced and Catra lowered her gaze.

Hordak stepped out of the darkness. "Your loyalty to the Horde is questionable and you are hereby banished from the Fright Zone."

"What?!" Catra exclaimed, taken aback as she snapped her head up only to be met with King Hordak's sharp glare. She took a step back.

"But-"

"I've had enough of your excuses, Catra!" Shadow Weaver harshly grabbed Catra's arm and began dragging her to the exit.

"It's a misunderstanding! Let me *go!*" She struggled until she was thrown outside, the doors slamming shut behind her.

"Wait!" Catra banged once on the door before sighing in defeat. Her rage clear on her face, she punched the wall and began to walk in the direction of the Whispering Woods.

.

Scorpia

After hearing the news about Catra's banishment, Scorpia was devastated. She had become her closest friend. She was sure that Catra had had a perfectly good reason to give those girls the sword. Completely expelling a person was too harsh a punishment.

Lost in her thoughts, Scorpia hadn't noticed the massive robot trailing her as she paced the halls of the Fright Zone. She turned around with the intent of returning to her sleeping quarters to calm her mind and jumped at the sight of the thing.

"What the... Are you following me?" She asked, not expecting a reply when a voice said, "No?"

Scorpia immediately jumped into a fighting stance. "Who's there?"

A person with long purple hair that seemed... alive? tied into pigtails rolled out of a vent. "Uh, hi!" She waved.

It was a princess. The one known as Entrapta to be specific. Scorpia quickly put her into her custody. As she came in to interrogate her, Scorpia realized that the cuffs containing the princess weren't very effective as she easily freed herself while Scorpia watched. She sighed. "Let the interrogation begin."

.

<u>Adora</u>

"That's it! I can't stay here and be useless! Bow is right; I don't know how to use my powers!"

"I didn't say that!.. Or, not that, exactly." Bow responded to Adora's exclamation.

She had spent an extensive amount of time attempting to heal Glimmer of her glitch she had acquired after being held captive by the Horde.

"The Horde has a lot of things wrong- okay, pretty much, everything, but one thing they were right about is training, and how can I train if I don't know anything about She-Ra?" Adora explained. "I'm going to go somewhere where I can learn," she put her hands on Glimmer's shoulders, addressing her. "Then, I'm gonna fix you, Glimmer."

Glimmer's eyes lit up and she asked Adora how she planned on doing so. All Glimmer wanted at that moment was to get out of having dinner with her mom, the queen, so that she wouldn't find out what her stay at the Fright Zone had done to her.

Adora recalled the beacon that Madame Razz had taken her to. She was sure she'd find answers there.

"Running away! Great idea, and I don't have to go to dinner with my mom!" Glimmer rambled. "I'll get my things-"

"No, I have to do this on my own." And with that, Adora leaped out the window and began her journey to find the beacon.

.

Scorpia

Less than a few minutes of questioning later, the princess Entrapta had moved to side with the Horde. Scorpia had convinced her that her friends were not coming back for her, and showed interest in her work, Entrapta explaining how she had made more progress in hiding here than free back at home. She rambled on about her plans to integrate First One's tech into her studies. Unfortunately, she hadn't been able to find anything new lately.

.

Catra

Night was falling and Catra was lost in the forest. Awesome. Why she had decided to venture into the magic forest in the first place? She didn't know. Continuing to lose hope, she tried to find a

shelter for the night. After tripping over branches and clawing through vines, she ended up in a clearing she'd seen already, her frustration only growing. The woods started to make noises and she immediately understood why they called it "The Whispering Woods". She shuddered until she heard footsteps. A familiar voice was speaking to... the trees? She hid behind a tree and watched Adora sink to her knees, telling the forest that she was weak and afraid.

Suddenly a bright light shone from behind the trees opposite the ones Catra was hiding in. Adora stood up, grabbed her sword that she had discarded on the forest floor and followed the source of the light. Catra climbed the tree she was at with ease and saw Adora walking up to the entrance of a tall building with a bright blue light shooting into the sky. How had she not seen it before?

Once she was out of sight, Catra hopped down and surveyed the area, confused to what it might be.

The entrance to the building began to close and Catra leaped inside. She followed Adora through a long hallway with some sort of symbols on the walls that lit up as she passed them. Eventually, she ended up in a large room made of purple and blue crystals. A runway led to a platform in the center surrounded by sharp looking pillars and more of those symbols snaked along the walls and floor.

Catra hid behind a pillar that supported the room as Adora called out.

"Hello?" Her voice echoed throughout the large building and whispers seemed to respond. "I carry the sword of She-Ra," she pulled the sword off of her back, showing it off, "and I've come here for help. Is anyone there?"

After a moment, a figure appeared behind Adora, startling her. "Greetings administrator." A female voice spoke. "What is your query?"

Adora hesitated, then asked for help to heal her friend. *Glimmer.* Of course. All Adora cared about these days were her new best friends. In Catra's opinion, it was a good thing that Glimmer was cursed. If she was eliminated, Adora'd be crushed. Her plans would fail. Then again, Catra didn't want Adora hurt. Not *really.* Deep inside, she just wished that things would go back to the way they were before, when it was just her and Adora, best friends. She-Ra didn't exist. There was no divide between the Horde and Adora. Catra wouldn't have to pretend to hate her. No, she did hate her. She had to keep telling herself that because she knew that the two would have no more chances together.

Maybe she should just get out of there. Out of that room, out of the woods, and find a place as far away from Adora and She-Ra and the princesses and the Horde and everything. Be the way she was supposed to be: alone.

She was pulled out of her thoughts when she heard Adora's voice again. "For the honor of Grayskull!" Catra peeked around the pillar to see Adora transform into She-Ra with a bright flash of light. She took a moment to admire the princess: long, thick, beautiful blonde hair that always seemed to be captured in a breeze topped off with a golden crown, strong arms that looked wonderful to be held with holding a diamond-like sword, golden trimmed dress complete with a flowing red cape, and a matching set of boots outlining her toned legs.

"How 'bout now?" She said to the glowing figure before her.

"Administrator detected. Welcome, She-Ra."

"One more time," She-Ra said. "What can you tell me about this sword?"

"Subject: the Sword of Protection. Classification: portable Runestone keyed exclusively to administrator She-Ra, Princess of Power."

"How can I use this sword to heal my friend?"

"Query not recognized." Adora groaned and Catra took this chance to explore the room while she was distracted. She heard Adora get more and more frustrated as the projection gave her no answers.

Eventually, Catra came across something that looked interesting. With Adora's back turned, she grabbed the triangular object, surprised when an alarm went off and She-Ra immediately shot at her with her sword.

"Hey, watch it!" Catra yelled.

"Catra? What are you doing here!?" The hologram behind Adora turned from blue to red. "Unauthorized presence detected." The robotic voice said. "Security protocol activated."

The glow in the room became red. "Nononono. Not again!"

"What just happened?" Catra nervously asked.

"This isn't good. You're not supposed to be in here!" Adora retorted back at her.

One by one, doors began to close around them, trapping the two in. Adora grabbed Catra's arm and raced toward an open hall but stopped in her tracks when several sets of red eyes appeared in the dark and giant spider creatures appeared.

"What are those?" Catra demanded.

"Also not good." They ran in a different direction to a door as it dropped shut. Catra watched behind her as the spiders gained on them. What were they going to do?

Then Adora called her name. "We need to run!" Catra spun around to see She-Ra struggling to hold up the heavy door and ducked underneath it after Catra had gotten through.

They continued to dash through the glowing-red halls until reaching a dead end with two directions to choose from. Behind

them, lights began to go out and the girls turned around to see even more spiders coming their way.

"What's going on? Why are those things trying to kill us?!" Catra yelled between breaths.

"They're trying to kill *you.* This place sees you as an invader." She-Ra ran beside her.

"Well, can't you tell them to stop?!"

"No! I can't tell them to stop! Clearly, nothing in here is listening to me!"

They turned a corner and reached a dead end. An actual one. "Adora!" "Stand back!" She grabbed her sword and cut through the rock, making everything even more unstable than it already was.

"What are you doing!" She grabbed Catra's arm, pulling her close, protecting her with a shield that came out of nowhere. It felt nice being that close to Adora again, but only for a second.

Once the dust cleared, it was back to business. She-Ra transformed back into Adora and she turned to Catra. "You shouldn't be here, Catra."

The two went back and forth at each other for a bit, and Catra declined to mention that she was no longer a part of the Horde, maybe because she wanted her to fear her. But doing so felt wrong. She hated having to lie to her best friend of so many years and she hated being enemies, but it seemed nothing could change that now. She didn't want to change it, did she?

Time skip **(a/n: right now I am following season 1 episode 11 but with a look into the character's thoughts that I made up; everything in this time skip is the same as in the episode, I just don't want to write the whole thing down)**

Catra was reliving her second memory that night. Crying in the locker room. Definitely *not* one of her favorite memories in the Horde. She looked back up at the mirror and saw her present self again; she was back in control. She wanted this all to stop. She wished she could just go home, but she couldn't. Never again. There was no way she was telling Adora that though. Once she got out of that place, she'd let Adora think that she returned to the Fright Zone. She didn't want to seem vulnerable.

She turned around and the room glitched. Backing away, she heard the same voice from before: "Unauthorized presence detected. Security protocol activated." There was something in the mirror, something bad.

One of the spider creatures climbed through the mirror and bound Catra with a green substance. She couldn't move. She screamed.

"Catra!" And then Adora was there. Adora was always there, whenever she needed her.

Oh, God, Adora. Why did you leave home?

Catra reached out her hand and she was being pulled towards her.

Adora, don't you let go, not again.

And then she was just out of reach, closed off behind glass as Catra was dragged into the dark.

"Adora!"

Help me.

Please.

.

<u>Adora</u>

There was no doubt about it. Adora still wanted to be close with Catra and now that she was in danger, there was nothing else on Adora's mind than her. She never wanted to leave her and she almost wished she never left in the first place. Almost. She was still glad to have met Glimmer and Bow and the other princesses and she wanted to keep that. She was also glad she finally realized the manipulative motives of the Horde and wished that Catra cared enough about her to understand how much this meant to her.

As she ran through the maze of still glowing-red halls Adora assessed herself. What was she to Catra? They were best friends about as close as you could get for all their lives. But that was until she'd left to be a princess. Left to be something that for her whole life she'd sworn to never ally with. How did this even happen?

Her thoughts were forgotten when she heard Catra's voice ahead of her. From what she could tell, she had freed herself and was now fighting the giant killer spider robot with her bare hands. Impressive.

No time to dwell on it though. She leaped into the air, sword lifted high and jammed it right into the spider's head. Adora sighed and hopped of the dead creature. "Are you okay?" She asked Catra, genuinely worried.

She looked angry for some reason. "I had it." She replied, her voice sharp.

"Sure you did." *That came out wrong.* Adora rested her hand on Catra's shoulder.

"We need to make sure we stay together from now on-"

"Will you stop telling me what to do?" Catra snapped, hesitated, and shoved Adora's hand away, avoiding eye contact. "I'm sick of this stupid place. Let's just get out of here."

Adora frowned and followed her to a set of cliffs. "What is your problem? I was trying to save you!"

"For the last time, I don't need you to save me. I've been doing just fine on my own. No thanks to you." She turned away and Adora grabbed her hand. It was rough from constantly training at the Horde, just like she remembered it. She knew that she had to bring Catra back into her life, she wouldn't be able to stand it anymore otherwise.

"I'm sorry for leaving. I couldn't go back to the Fright Zone. Not after I saw what the Horde was really doing. But I never wanted to leave you." Adora explained, trying as hard as possible to keep her voice soft and to keep her grip on Catra's hand. She never wanted to let go. "You could come with me, you could join the Rebellion. I know you're not a bad person Catra. You don't belong with the Horde." They looked into each other's eyes, Adora admiring Catra's multicolored eyes like she had many times before. She waited patiently for a response but none came because the sound of a door opening distracted the both of them.

Catra crossed her arms. "Let's just get this over with." She said as another memory began to replay.

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<u>Catra</u>

To say she was considering Adora's suggestion was an understatement. Catra wanted nothing more than to be with Adora again, to find a place to call home, but she couldn't. She didn't know why; there was nothing stopping her from rebelling against the ones who tossed her out like trash. But yet, she couldn't bring herself to accept it.

"What's it like being the world's slowest person?" She heard her past self say and watched through the old painful memory.

Another Time Skip

Before she knew it, Catra had just finished another argument with Adora, this one affecting her so much, she couldn't take it. She ran away after telling her that she didn't want her to come back, this being the reason she gave her back the sword in the Fright Zone. It wasn't true but she couldn't help but get away from Adora, more old memories shoving themselves in her head. It was too much, she just wanted to go home.

Just when she was about to break down, one last memory replayed in its entirety. It was Adora promising her that they would be there for each other, no matter what.

She couldn't just walk away. She couldn't do that to Adora. They had made a promise, and when Catra was in trouble, Adora was always there. She wouldn't fail her now.

Catra ran back to where Adora was and saw her struggling to fight off the spider bots without She-Ra. The last thing she saw was Adora being knocked off a cliff when she finally brought herself back to reality. She had to save Adora. It was the one thing she could do after all the times that she had been there for Catra.

She began to fight off all the monsters the same way she had tried to earlier, but this time, she had a weapon: her perseverance was stronger than ever and all the creatures were broken with ease.

She walked over to where Adora was hanging.

"Hey, Adora."

Adora smiled as she was pulled up to safety. "Thank you, Catra." She said and hugged her.

"Fine." Catra whispered into her ear. Adora pulled away, confused. "I'll join your stupid rebellion."

The look on Adora's face was enough to let Catra remember why they were best friends. She realized just how much she had missed her after all.

Just then, the world around them began to disappear. Adora stepped back, not remembering about the cliff that she had just almost fallen off of and lost her balance. Catra grabbed her hand to stop her from falling but it was too late and Adora ended up pulling her down with her.

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Adora

Falling off a cliff with your best friend. Again. Not the worst way to die, right? But *was* Catra her best friend? Adora doubted everything had been resolved. Catra did do a lot of terrible things: she continued an attack on an innocent town, she captured Adora's best friends and held them prisoner, ultimately causing her to end up in this place anyway... among other things. So were they even friends at all? Or enemies? Frenemies?

As they plunged down the seemingly bottomless pit, more memories between the two resurfaced and flashed before them. Catra's hand gripped Adora's. Was this the end?

They'd been falling for thirty minutes (a/n: anyone get the reference?) when suddenly Adora didn't feel Catra's hand anymore. She'd vanished.

"Catra!"

And then she landed. Feet first, no pain, but still no Catra.

"Catra!"

"Hello, Adora, you've come at last." A voice sounded from behind her. Adora spun around, startled. It was another hologram but this one looked familiar. It was the woman she'd seen when first touching the sword. It was,

"Light Hope. I can't believe I'm actually seeing you." She said. "Well I've seen you... heh, in my brain, I think.

"But this is real! Is this real? Wait am I dead? I fell..." Adora scanned the room she was standing in. Catra was nowhere to be seen. She looked up at Light Hope. "Where's Catra?... Sorry I'm freaking out." She cleared her throat.

"I'm Adora."

"Yes, I know."

Well, duh, of course she knows who you are. Stupid.

"I have been waiting for you since you were an infant." Light Hope continued. "But I could not reach you. And I could not protect you from the Horde. I watched you grow up from afar."

Creepy much?

Once introductions were finished, Adora went straight to business. First, she asked for information about the First Ones, the people who first inhabited Etheria. Learning more about She-Ra, it was discovered that Adora was the first person to carry the sword in a thousand years.

Her two most important questions were *one:* "How do I heal my friend?" and *two:* "Where's Catra?"

The answer to the second question was vague. "You'll see her soon." Light Hope had said.

"What does that mean?"

She ignored the question. "Glimmer's connection with her runestone was disrupted."

"Can I fix it?" Adora asked, mentally sighing. She figured she'd find Catra later herself. She hoped she was okay. Right now, her main focus was learning how to heal Glimmer.

"You will be able to do many things with training."

"Great, so how long will this training take? Like a day or-"

"Years."

"Years?" Adora questioned, shocked. "Glimmer doesn't have years! She's hurt because of me! I messed up. I got Glimmer and Bow captured and Entrapta-" she didn't dare say it. "It's- It's my fault. I have to fix it."

The image of Light Hope flickered before she answered.

"Yes. Your mission is to fix the planet."

Adora was trying to get answers but this didn't cut it. Light Hope was refusing to tell her how to save Glimmer or where Catra had disappeared to. Meanwhile, the Horde was probably planning *something* against the princesses who's alliance was broken anyway. She needed to do something, anything, that would help, no matter how small.

"My mission is to help my friends. That's why I came here!"

"You are She-Ra. Your purpose is to protect all of Etheria. You cannot help only your friends."

Adora was getting kind of frustrated. "Why can't I do both?"

"Adora," Light Hope placed her hand on Adora's shoulder though it just fazed through. "You do not yet realize the power you have." She continued. "You are distracted by your attractions. There was one before you who could not let go. Her name, was Mara." And then Light Hope went on to explain more history about She-Ra and how the line was broken by this Mara girl, the girl that Madame Razz kept referring to.

Wait, if Madame Razz knew Mara, and that was a thousand years ago, geez, how old is she?

Anyway, apparently Mara had been overwhelmed by power that she couldn't control and gave into her fear, nearly destroying Etheria in the process.

"Adora, I have waited for a thousand years," Light Hope said, "alone." Adora started feeling bad. "I did not know if I would ever see another She-Ra."

Adora, after hearing this, hoped that she could make Light Hope proud of the She-Ra she had and would continue to become.

"You must stay here and train; learn to be the She-Ra that Mara could not be."

It was very tempting. Stay underground and train, come back to Bright Moon and the Rebellion as the She-Ra everyone expected her to be.

"I will. I'll- I'll do whatever you want. I'll come back and train and learn about everything. But I have to heal Glimmer first. I can save the planet and save her."

.

<u>Bow</u>

"Shouldn't she be" *Glitch* "back by now?"

Glimmer was pacing her room, worried about Adora. Understandably. Bow was too.

"She said she was" *Glitch* "trying to get training to" *Glitch* "fix me! How long is that going to take- Ow!" She stubbed her toe on a chair that was in her way. "And what kind of *monster* puts a chair here?" She was just getting more and more frustrated.

Bow stood up. "Okay, I'm worried too, but taking it out on the furniture isn't going to help." He said, grabbing Glimmer's shoulders and sitting her down. She just stood right back up again.

"We can't sit here and hope she comes back eventually." She inquired, turning to Bow. "We have to do something."

"Like what?"

Suddenly there was a knock on the door. Glimmer opened it to see a royal guard standing outside.

"Princess, there's, uh, something here to see you."

"Don't you mean someone?"

"No, I mean some*thing.*"

Bow and Glimmer followed the guard out to see their horse majestically pacing toward them.

"Our horse!" Bow exclaimed.

"I am my own horse. Call me... SWIFT WIND." The horse stood on its hind legs, stretching out large colorful wings.

Wait.

Did our horse just speak?

Bow and Glimmer blinked and jumped into each other's arms, screaming. Bow pointed with an amazed look in his eyes while Glimmer stared at it in awe.

"Our horse can talk!" Bow's voice cracked and he gasped, clinging to Glimmer again.

"Yeah, yeah, I can speak my mind now, pretty crazy. So, I'm thinking-"

"He's a talking horse!"

"As we established." Both Bow and Glimmer were freaking out.

"He has *wings!*" Glimmer finally managed to say.

"Okay." The horse looked done with their reactions. "I'll give you a moment to freak out, and then we need to talk."

Bow and Glimmer stood still, gasping until Swift Wind spoke again.

"Great! I think Adora needs our help." He said. "Since Adora transformed me, I've been able to feel where she is at all times." He looked at his reflection in the window. "It's like instinct. But now I feel a pull, as if I'm being summoned to her side."

Bow walked up and admired his wings.

"As part of Adora's herd," he snapped his head around, "I need your help. Will you come?" Glimmer glitched again. "Of course. Lead the way."

"But Glimmer, you're glitching."

"Is what got us into this. Adora left to save me. Now it's time for us to save her. You in?"

Bow smiled. "Always." He said. "But I don't think your mom is going to like us leaving so soon after our last mission." He followed Glimmer to her door. "She doesn't need to know." The princess said, already gripping the door handle. "We'll sneak out and be back before my mom even realizes we're gone." She opened the door and there stood Queen Angella, her fist up as if she were about to knock.

Glimmer shouted in surprize, glitching again. "Mom! What are you doing here?" She asked innocently.

"Coming to see why my guard was escorting a horse into your room."

Swift Wind jumped up next to her. "I like to think of myself more as a role model for all horse kind."

Silence.

"I mean uh, what talking horse? What's happening?" He said and gave her space again. She smiled and turned back to Glimmer.

"You should get going if you want to track down Adora." She hinted.

"You're not going to stop us?"

"Glimmer, I told you I regretted giving up after your father died. I will not consign you to the same regret."

Both smiled, Angella pressing her forehead to Glimmer's. Bow watched happily. Their mother-daughter relationship was his favorite.

The Queen stood up straight, addressing Glimmer like a soldier. "Commander Glimmer, I order you to continue your mission to find Adora," Glimmer smiled, "and bring her back home."

Glimmer saluted. "Right away, Your Majesty." She turned back to Bow and Swift Wind. "Come on!"

Bow followed suit and saluted to the Queen before marching out and noticed the horse do the same.

"And when we're back," Bow heard Swift Wind say and ran back to push him back to where Glimmer was, smiling.

"Please be careful," was the last thing he heard before exiting.

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Scorpia

"Uh, Entrapta? I got your note." Scorpia opened the door to 'Entrapta's Lab' and looked around, seeing only Emily standing by a bunch of screens and wires.

A vent flew off the wall near the floor and the purple haired princess climbed out.

"Scorpia! Wonderful! I wanted to show you something that I found."

She walked over to the screens and pulled up some data that she had obtained.

"Look at this. Etheria's not just a planet!" She ranted. Scorpia didn't understand all that much of what she was showing her but looked impressed anyway.

"Whatever the First Ones did to it, it went deep." She looked overly excited.

"And what does that mean?"

Entrapta turned to her. "You're asking me about my theories? I've waited *years* for someone to ask me about my theories! Hang on, I made a model!" She grabbed Scorpia's claw with her hair and dragged her to another room.

Here, Entrapta had set up an entire prototype of Etheria. It was a large sphere with several green lights sticking out of it.

"Behold, Etheria. The First Ones didn't just settle on the surface of Etheria, their technology runs throughout the planets core."

She walked around her model several times as she spoke.

"The whole planet!" She leaned in close. "It's *all* First One's tech."

"And what are these supposed to be?" Scorpia pointed to the green lanterns that were placed across the figure.

"Runestones. From the data I've managed to extract, the regulate the planet through the princesses. They're directly connected to each other and to the planet's power grid in a delicate balance. If I can get my hands on one of these, the possibilities are endless!"

"Runestone? What- you mean like the Black Garnet? 'Cause heheh, we have the Black Garnet." Scorpia bragged.

"The Black Garnet?" Entrapta was getting excited. "*You* have a runestone? The Fright Zone has a runestone?!"

"Uh, duh, it was my family's." *Obviously.* "But when the Horde landed, we gave it to Hordak, who then gave it to Shadow Weaver, who, y'know, you tell a friend, he tells a friend it's like- it's kinda one of those things."

Entrapta leaped onto Scorpia, nearly knocking her over.

"Where is it?! Can I see it?! Can I touch it?!"

She had an extremely wild look in her eyes.

Time Skip **(a/n: okay so i know it was catra that got rid of shadow weaver but like she's not there so like something else went down and shadow weaver is gone. I really dont feel like explaining all of it)**

Shadow Weaver was now no longer a threat and Scorpia and Entrapta had the Black Garnet to themselves.

"Entrapta, if you would." Scorpia permitted and Entrapta excitedly flung her hair around and raced over to the computer that was attached to the machines they had hooked up to the runestone.

"Alright everyone. Let's get weird!" She said, grinning. Scorpia watched her press buttons and adjust knobs until a red light began to emit from the Black Garnet. She gasped as she saw natural shadows begin to be sucked away as if there was light shining on every single angle of the room. The light bulbs shattered and the shadows rose to the ceiling until an explosion sounded and a beam of dark red light shone into the grey clouds above. As soon as this happened, red lightning struck from the source and everything started to spread.

It had begun.

.

Glimmer

Something had happened. Giant beasts that occupied the Whispering Woods were now racing away from it. From what? They didn't know.

"What was that about?" Glimmer asked. They watched Swift Wind step forward.

"I feel something." He hesitated. "We should run. No, we need to get Adora, then run."

"Swift Wind, what is it?" Bow interjected.

"A bad thing. Hurry!" He whimpered and began walking faster.

As they walked Glimmer noticed herself getting cold which was unusual for the Whispering Woods because the weather was always appropriate for her outfit. Bow noticed too.

"Is it just me or is it really cold?" Bow announced. Glimmer made a face until she saw a white spec of something enter her field of vision. Suddenly it started to snow excessively.

"It's... snowing?"

"That's impossible." Bow said. "It *never* snows in the Whispering Woods."

An explosion sound rang through the forest and a high wind blizzard began to blow. It was so windy that Bow and Glimmer had trouble catching up to Swift Wind.

Glimmer went up close to the horse so that he could hear her. "What's happening?"

"The bad thing!"

Red lightning struck in the sky above them. "We can't stay here!" Bow shouted. "Swift Wind, do you sense Adora?"

His horn lit up as he lowered his head. "There! She's over there!" He nodded toward a large beam of blue light rising into the sky.

The three made their way to the source of the light as fast as they could through the heavy storm. Once they reached the tall blue building, a locked door with First One's writing on it stood locked in their way. Bow and Glimmer struggled to open it with no success. Glimmer let out a sound of frustration.

"This would be a great time for my powers to come back!" She yelled to no one in particular.

"Wait, wait! I know this! Hang on, I think I can..." Swift Wind lined his head up perpendicular to the center if the door. As soon as he did, the writing lit up and an entrance opened up on the ground, allowing them access.

Just as they ran inside, the glow in the hallway turned red and Swift Wind directed them to a room where Adora was lying on a large inclined crystal.

"Adora!" Glimmer and Bow said simultaneously. "Were here! Wake up!"

They all ran over to her. She was asleep, her sword laying right next to her. Glimmer thought she saw something from behind a pillar across from her but didn't have time to think about it because Bow said, "Uhh, Glimmer?" He pointed to the path that they had just walked through, showing at least eight sets of eight eyes moving towards them.

Swift Wind was trying to reach Adora while Glimmer held her safe and Bow fought off the monsters.

Hope was beginning to be lost.

.

<u>Entrapta</u>

The experiment was a success. With access to the Fright Zone's runestone, the Black Garnet, Entrapta had all the First One's tech she needed. Entrapta spun in circles around the room that held the Black Garnet, logging her progress.

"This experiment has been more effective than I could ever have dreamed. This proves my hypothesis correct! With the Black Garnet functioning at 200 percent power, the precarious equilibrium that governs all of Etheria's natural functions has been thrown into complete chaos! No doubt as a result of the other elemental runestones-"

Scorpia stopped the princess's spinning. "Translate please?"

"By making the Black Garnet more powerful, we've sapped power from the other princess's runestones, upsetting the balance and making the weather go screwy."

All of a sudden, all the power in the room went out and the machines shut down.

"What's happening?" Scorpia asked.

"No, no, no!" Entrapta exclaimed. "We blew the circuits! I didn't even think that was possible! You guys have top notch technology but the electricity system can't handle this kind of work!"

She groaned. "Damn it!"

"Well can you fix it?"

"No! Everything's fried! Fixing it would take weeks, and I think the Garnet's power has depleted."

She sunk down and sat on her hair, then jumped up.

"But! That was *incredible*! Now that I can have access to this runestone whenever I want, I can continue experimenting until I get things right!" She giggled. "Just imagine what this can do if I

can find even more information on the First Ones!" She grinned and rushed out of the room.

She needed to find another disc to extract information from. She already had suspected a signal was being emitted from the Whispering Woods and went to look further into it.

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Glimmer

Glimmer sat with Adora in her arms. Still nothing from her or Swift Wind as Bow continued to attempt to fight off the spider creatures.

Suddenly, Adora opened her eyes. Glimmer felt her stir. "Adora! You're back!" She hugged her and Bow shouted at them. "Adora! Spiders!" His voice cracked.

She immediately stood up and started towards the beasts. "For the honor of Grayskull!" She transformed and defeated them with ease. Bow and Glimmer jumped on her, excited to see her back in action again.

Once they had let go, Glimmer turned to She-Ra.

"Adora." She said. "We need to go, the Horde has done something bad!" Adora nodded but hesitated.

"Wait, Catra!" She looked around her.

"Catra?! Isn't that our enemy?!" Glimmer shouted, urging Adora to come quickly.

"No, she's on our side now. Catra?!"

Glimmer saw the feline Horde soldier appear from the shadows. She peeked out slowly and began to walk toward Adora. Adora smiled.

"Adora, she's from the Horde!"

"I know, but she's with us now! I trust her."

"Ugh, no time! Let's go!"

Catras face showed shock and confusion suddenly. She pointed at Swift Wind. "Wait, is that a-"

"Talking horse, yes. Hop on!"

"What's a horse-"

"Come *on*!" Glimmer urged.

They flew out, expecting a horrendous blizzard complete with red lightning and strong winds.

But,

As they rushed out, the weather was normal: blue skies, warm, soft breeze. It was as if nothing had happened at all. But they knew it did, because right in front if them was a fallen tree, and another several feet to their left.

"What the-" Glimmer let out.

Swift Wind lowered the four to the ground.

"What's going on?" Adora asked and dismounted her flying horse friend, the others following suit.

"The bad thing," Swift Wind said. "It's not happening anymore. I don't sense anything at all."

"How is that even possible?" Glimmer exclaimed.

"Something must have went wrong in... whatever they were doing." Adora suggested. She reverted back to her normal form.

Swift Wind jumped in. "Well let's not dwell on it! This is good."

"Swift Wind's right." Bow said. "Now can we talk about why there's a Horde soldier standing next to me?" Catra scoffed.

"Right! Adora, can I talk to you for a minute?" She dragged her around the corner of the building. "Watch. Her." Glimmer directed Bow. Catra rolled her eyes and crossed her arms over her chest. Her tail swung around a bit.

Glimmer turned back to Adora. "Hi, I'm really glad you're safe!" She smiled. "But why is our enemy following you around?!" She whisper-yelled.

Adora groaned. "I told you, she's on our side now."

"*She's from the Horde.*"

"*I'm* from the Horde."

"Yeah, but you're *She-Ra.* Catra's not secretly a princess, is she?"

"She is on our side."

"How do you know that? She could betray us."

"I know *her*, okay? We were best friends back at the Fright Zone. She wouldn't do that."

"Oh yeah? Did you know her when she led an attack on Thaymor? What about when she *kidnapped* me and Bow?" She didn't give Adora a chance to respond and glitched again.

They didn't realize that Bow and Catra could hear every word they were saying. "This could be a spy mission from the Horde-"

"I'm not part of the Horde!" Catra interrupted from behind Adora.

Silence. Every eye was on her. "I was... banished."

"You were *what*?!"

"We still don't know if she's telling the truth, Adora." Glimmer whispered to her. Adora ignored her, gesturing for Catra to go on.

She sighed. "Shadow Weaver found out that I let you and your princess friend escape," Glimmer pouted, "and she and Lord Hordak decided to *finally* get rid of me."

Glimmer placed her hands on her hips and watched Catra suspiciously. "Why *did* you let us go?"

"Because I couldn't *stand* looking at yours or Adora's face any longer."

"Ugh, and why are we letting her stay with us again?"

"I know right? Maybe I should just leave. You're a *princess*." Catra made a disgusted face.

"Catra! I'm a princess!" Adora said and Catra scoffed.

"No you're not, that stupid sword just makes you look like one. And I never said I wasn't referring to leaving you too. I told you, *I don't like you.* Princess or not."

"Okay, kitty-" "*Don't* call me that!" "Can we all just calm down?" Bow interjected.

"You said you'd join the rebellion." Adora reminded her. "We're bringing you to Bright Moon."

"I only joined your dumb rebellion because I have nowhere else to go."

"Okay- Can we just go home?" Glimmer proposed.

"That sounds great."

"Wait, Glimmer. Before we go anywhere, I think I can fix you. I- Light Hope didn't give me an exact answer, but I want to try."

Adora remembered the reason she had gone in there in the first place.

Glimmer didn't know who this Light Hope was but assumed it wasn't anything bad."Uhm, okay, give it a go."

"For the honor of Grayskull!" Adora transformed back into She-Ra, looking majestic as usual and lifted her sword in the air, her eyes closed.

A golden light began to emit from the crystal on She-Ra's sword, nearly blinding Glimmer, Bow, and Catra. A ring of light spread throughout the Whispering Woods and when it died down, the fallen trees had been reverted to their original state and Glimmer was back to her normal self.

"No way!" Bow exclaimed. "Glimmer, you're sparkling again!"

She stood still and braced herself in case her powers weren't completely back and then disappeared and reappeared. No glitching. No pain. "Yes!"

"Now let's go home." Adora said and changed back into her normal self.

They decided to walk rather than fly and began their trek to Bright Moon with a new ally in their grasps.

What's in a Princess?

Chapter Notes

> I just want to say that some of the ideas used in this are not mine. Like, Glimmer and Catra bonding over not being good enough for their mother figures, and the theory that Catra may be a lost princess. I'm not sure who originally came up with those but it sure as hell wasn't me. Soooo yeah. Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

Out of all the things Catra had thought would happen after being expelled from the Horde, walking to a kingdom with a bunch of princesses and a talking… horse was it? was not one of them.

For a while, Catra had just stayed behind the group, following with a frown while the rest talked amongst themselves.

As she watched the group of friends chat up a storm, she noticed just how close the three had gotten. It made her angry. Adora used to have that same kind of relationship with Catra. What happened?

Suddenly Glimmer turned around to face her harshly. Catra let out an involuntary hiss.

"Whoa," Glimmer put her hands up, "sorry. But something's been bugging me."

Catra crossed her arms and smirked. "Is it that I'm from the Horde?"

"No- well… anyway it's just- why weren't the spider things in the beacon attacking you? You couldn't just have hid from them, they'd find you anywhere.

“I returned the disc I stole to its place and they left me alone. Once I realized Adora wasn't going to wake up anytime soon, I figured I'd be nice for once and give the place its stuff back.”

“Then why were they attacking *us* ?”

“No idea. Maybe they don't like *princesses* .”

“Not this again! Catra, cut it out. Can't we all just be friends?” Adora cut in

“Absolutely *not* .” Catra confirmed. “Y'know what? I'm not even sure I want to be part of this rebellion if this is how princesses are.”

Glimmer looked really mad. She started walking in Catra's direction ignoring the calls from her friends to stop. Catra couldn't care less, no *princess* could possibly win in a fight against her.

As soon as Catra was in arms reach of Glimmer, rather than attacking, she grabbed her arm and suddenly they were in the sky, falling at high speed. “Whoa, wait!” Catra flailed but there was nothing to stop her descent. She looked around, Glimmer wasn't falling with her, she had teleported back to the ground and from high up, she could see Adora yelling at her. Catra didn't even realize she was screaming until she reached the top of the tallest trees and her voice was echoing back to her. The ground was closing in fast and there was no way she was going to be alright when she landed.

She braced herself for impact when she felt a hand on her arm and then she was back on the ground, safe and unharmed. She put her hands on her knees and leaned forward, breathing fast.

“Insult me like that again and next time I'll let you hit the ground.”

“Glimmer! What is wrong with you? Catra, are you okay?” Neither responded.

“I was the same way when we first met, remember? Why are you treating Catra so much worse than you did me?”

Catra saw a light flashing in the corner of her eye and started stepping toward it. Glimmer and Adora continued arguing.

“The last time Catra and I met, we were fighting on opposite sides. At least you didn't come specifically to attack us, you just wanted your sword.”

Catra walked further away from them.

“She's different-”

“Doesn't seem all that different to me.”

She was still within earshot but tuned their conversation out. In front of her was yet another ruin. She looked around for a second but it seemed no one else noticed. How? The light was really bright.

She ventured further until she couldn't hear the group anymore and saw that the door to the ruin was open and she walked inside. It didn’t look all that different from the one she'd been in previously: blue crystal-like walls filled with those strange symbols, a large image of She-Ra covered a large portion of one wall, crystal pillars stretched high to the tall ceiling.

Once she reached a certain point in the room, a holographic figure appeared, just like one had for Adora. Catra didn't dare touch anything. She definitely did not want to get trapped in that hellhole again. Alone this time.

Not wanting to be in there for too long, Catra started walking toward the exit, only to find it closed shut.

“You have got to be kidding me.” She said aloud and tried to find something that would open it with no success. She began banging on the door, hoping someone outside would hear her.

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Bow

Adora and Glimmer were arguing and Bow really wished they'd stop. But nothing he said went through to them. He didn't think they even heard him at all.

“Once she sees how nice everyone is at Bright Moon rather than the Fright Zone, she'll definitely act differently.”

“But you don't know that. Maybe she learned a thing or two from your *Shadow Weaver* or whatever and is a total bitch!”

“Glimmer! Language!” Bow said, being ignored once again.

He started giving up and looked around, only to realize that Catra had disappeared.

“Guys.”

“You don't understand, she's not like that, she'll change!”

“Guys!”

Glimmer stopped mid sentence and both girls looked at him.

He gestured around him. “Catra's gone.”

“What?!” Adora exclaimed, looking in all directions.

Glimmer sighed. “I guess we have to go find her now.”

“She could be anywhere.” Adora said. “I'll go north, Glimmer you go south, Bow and Swift Wind can go east and west.”

“Do you really think it's a good idea to split up in these woods? Can't we just let her find her own way?”

“No, Glimmer, I want her with us.” Adora insisted and began walking away.

“Wait, Adora!” Glimmer shouted but she was already gone.

“I'll go get her.” Bow offered and followed Adora into a different part of the woods. “I'll find you! I have my tracker!” He ran after Adora and left Glimmer standing with Swift Wind.

“Adora, wait up!” Bow said as he caught up with her.

She sighed. “Hey, Bow.”

“Can I walk with you?”

“Sure.”

They walked in silence a bit, Bow not wanting to upset her more than she already was.

Eventually Adora spoke. “I can't believe Catra just left like that.”

“She didn't seem too happy to be here.”

“I know, but she said she'd join the rebellion. She's not really one to change her mind.”

“Why do you trust her so much?”

“We've been friends our whole lives, ever since Shadow Weaver brought us to the Horde.”

“You were both raised by Shadow Weaver? Wouldn't that make you kind of sisters?”

“Not really, or, at least we never thought that way. We were just best friends. We'd do everything together and could depend on each other no matter what. It was a promise we made a long time ago. It was just us, always. Wherever she went, I went and vice versa. We were inseparable. She had her own bed but chose to sleep at the foot of mine because we couldn’t stand to be apart for even a moment. She’s the best person I ever knew.” Adora had

stopped walking and sat down on a rock. Bow sat next to her as she talked.

"I always thought it'd stay like that forever but then in the blink of an eye, we're mortal enemies. I still wish we were that close because I still really care about her, but, I don't think she feels the same. I just want to have her back."

"Sounds like you're in love." Bow said, taking in what she had said.

Adora looked confused. "What does that mean?"

Bow stood up and ran his fingers through his hair. "Are you kidding?" Her face stayed blank. "Wow, your life is so sad, how are you still alive?"

Adora stayed quiet and moved her eyes to the left, then back at Bow.

Bow helped her up and they started walking again. "Okay, so you know Spinnerella and Netossa, right?"

She nodded. "Yeah, what about them?"

"They're married."

"Yeah, Glimmer told me that." She paused. "I… don't know what that means either." She added quietly.

Bow's mind was blown and he groaned. "We need to give you life lessons when we get back, pronto. You'll find out what that stuff means then because I'm no good at explaining but! From what you said, you are *definitely* in love with Catra."

"I still don't know what that means." Adora whispered. "You will! Eventually." Bow replied and the two continued their search for Adora's feline friend.

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Glimmer

Bow and Adora were long gone and Swift Wind went in his assigned direction after letting her know that if he didn't find anything, he'd go back to 'kicking down stable doors,' leaving Glimmer standing in the middle of the Whispering Woods, alone. She was still very frustrated and groaned, teleporting about five feet to her right, then began to trudge into a darker part of the forest.

"Gotta go find Adora's friend, who we have no idea if we can even trust." She spoke aloud, teleporting a couple meters apart at each point. She dragged herself through the dark woods, continuing to complain to herself.

Glimmer sighed, tired of wandering for countless minutes without finding anything of use. She groaned again and teleported about a kilometer forward. "Why do I have to-"

Standing right in front of her was another blue First One's ruin. She smirked. "I have time for a little adventure."

She stepped up to the closed door of the building and teleported inside. It looked fairly similar to the one they found Adora in that same day. As she walked, she started hearing metallic noises and grunts from a person resonating from behind a door to her left.

"Hello?" She said as she teleported through the door. What she saw was Catra fighting off the same spiders from before with only her hands and claws.

"Catra!" She looked over at the sound of the call. "What?"

"What are you doing here?"

"What do you think?" Catra said, finishing another creature. "I got locked in and they started attacking."

That sentence threw her off her focus and she was hit by a spider's leg and was launched across the room.

“Catra!” Glimmer teleported over to her and saw that she was unconscious. She grabbed her arm and teleported back out to the woods.

She laid Catra down on the grass and sat on a nearby rock, impatiently waiting for her to wake up. She shot a ball of sparkle in her direction that landed a couple inches away from her head.

“I should probably stop that. Adora won’t like it.” She said to herself, mockingly.

Glimmer sighed and stood up, pacing back and forth until she heard Catra stir.

“Finally.” She teleported over so that she was squatting next to her. She flicked her forehead. “Wake up.” She said nonchalantly.

Catra inhaled deeply. “What’s happening?”

“You were flung across an ancient First One’s ruin by a giant spider.”

“Oh.”

“Yep.”

Silence rang out for a few moments until Catra spoke again.

“Wait, a *what’s* ruin?”

“A First One’s ruin- Wait. Now you’re gonna tell me you don’t know what that is. God the Horde is useless.

“The First Ones were the first people to settle on Etheria. They have a bunch of advanced technology that I’m sure the Horde would love to get their hands on. But! It seems they don’t know about it, so I think we’re safe for now.” She smacked her head suddenly. “Why did I tell you that? I *don’t trust you* .”
Catra chuckled. “The feeling’s mutual.”

Glimmer sighed. “Come on, we gotta go meet up with the others.”

Catra didn’t move when Glimmer started walking. “Why? We just agreed that we don’t trust each other.” She crossed her arms. *Man, she does that a lot.*

“Because Adora’s my friend and she wants you to come to Bright Moon with us.” Glimmer explained reluctantly, still getting over the argument they had only minutes before.

Even though she didn’t express it all that much, Glimmer could tell that Catra still cared about her and Adora’s relationship and wanted to preserve it if possible. Glimmer wanted Adora to be happy and bringing Catra to the Rebellion would do just that. She was also curious of Catra’s background because she knew there was a princess in the past that had similar cat-like features. Was Catra in fact a lost princess herself?

Glimmer was lost in her thoughts when she realized she didn’t have the slightest idea where they had been walking. She didn’t tell Catra this though. Instead, she started asking questions about Adora.

“So what’s with you and Adora anyway? She never really told us much.”

Catra scoffed. “Figures.” She paused. “She left me. She made a promise that we’d always be there for each other and then she just… left.”

“But you understand why she left, right? That the Horde is dangerous?” Glimmer was attempting to see what side Catra was truly on.

She sighed. “No comment.”

Glimmer mentally facepalmed. “Well- what did they teach you about princesses?”

“That you’re a dangerous threat to everyone on Etheria. That you’re violent instigators who don’t even know how to control your powers.” Catra said harshly.

“Y’know that is exactly what Adora said; word for word. Did you guys have to memorize that or something? Like for a vocab quiz?”

Catra snorted, but didn’t answer.

They continued walking through the trees until they came up to a clearing that looked very familiar. They’d passed through it several minutes ago.

“This looks awfully familiar.” Catra verbalized her thoughts. “Are you sure we’re going the right way?”

“Uh, yeah!” Glimmer assured, then went back to the subject from earlier. “How long have you known Adora?”

For this, Catra actually seemed glad to answer. “Since- as long as I can remember. We were both orphans and were both somewhat raised by Shadow Weaver so we were always close, though Shadow Weaver always favored Adora, possibly because she knew she was She-Ra and wanted her to stay on the side of the Horde.” She laughed softly to herself. “They would absolutely love to have She-Ra for themselves.”

Catra seemed happy when talking about Adora. She smiled whenever she recalled a good memory of the two and Glimmer could hardly believe this was the same person they were trying to defeat only a few days prior.

“So has Shadow Weaver ever been nice?”

“Hah, no. Not to me, at least.

“She always made it seem like Adora was so much better than I was. It did wonders for my self esteem. And then I always tried to make myself better but it just wasn’t good enough.”

Glimmer hummed in response. She knew the feeling all to well. All her life she wanted to impress her mother. She only recently found out that her mom felt similarly about herself because she got her husband killed. Still, all Glimmer really wanted was to help out the kingdom; she was the queen's daughter after all.

"I understand that. I've never really felt good enough for my mother either."

"Heh, really? You make it seem like your princess life is as perfect as it can be."

"It's really not. I think we might have a lot more in common than you might think." Glimmer stated. "Do you know anything about your heritage? I'm only curious because I used to know a princess that kind of looked like you."

"Me? *A princess* ? Never." She scoffed.

"I'm not saying you're a princess." Glimmer defended. "I'm just wondering: do you know your real parents at all?"

"Nope, the first memories I have are at the Horde and no one ever mentioned my family that I may or may not have had. It's only ever been Shadow Weaver, Hordak, and Adora." Catra explained.

"Well, if it relates, my father died when I was still a baby so I didn't really have a father figure in my life."

Catra mhm'ed but didn't reply.

"So was Adora like a sister to you?"

"Not really." She answered after a moment. "It's- well, we never really thought of it like that. We were just… friends."

"So you were really close then."

"Not close enough for her to *not* leave us for a bunch of princesses." She snapped.

Glimmer awkwardly stepped away from Catra. "But she left for a good reason, the same reason you're here now."

"You see, the thing is, I didn't want to leave. I planned on staying there for the rest of my life." She looked uncomfortable. "I- uh…" She sighed and continued to walk in silence.

Glimmer also stopped talking to try and examine her surroundings to see if she had a single clue where they had ended up. Catra noticed.

"Do you have any idea where we are?" She demanded.

"Nope!" Glimmer honestly announced. "But, it's okay! Bow will find us. I just need to do a bunch of short-range teleporting so that we show up on Bow's tracker pad. And we should stay in one place instead of wandering."

Catra took this opportunity to hop onto a nearby rock, squatting and waving her tail while licking the top of her hand.

Wow, she really is a cat. Glimmer thought as she watched her, then teleported herself a few feet at a time all in the same general area.

"Y'know you're not so bad." Catra noted, distracting Glimmer from her concentration, causing her to disappear and reappear a few feet in the air, falling on her butt.

"Huh?"

Catra readjusted her position so that she was facing her. "I can see why Adora likes you so much." Catra looked at the ground. "Kind of." She added.

Glimmer half-smiled and continued using her magic to alert Bow of their location.

.

Adora

"Soooooo, you ever gonna explain what you said earlier?" Adora asked Bow after several minutes of unsuccessful Catra hunting.

Before he could respond, his tracker pad started making a lot of noise, startling both of them.

Bow came back to his senses and pulled it out, seeing two red dots blinking not too far from where they were.

"That must be Glimmer!" He exclaimed. "Either she's in trouble, or she found Catra."

He pointed to another red dot far away on the opposite side of the screen. "That must be Swift Wind so that," he pointed to the dot right next to Glimmer, "must be Catra.

"But this detects magic. Why is she on it?"

"Well she's not exactly human." Adora pointed out. Being part cat would be a reason to have magic, right?

"True." Bow stated. "Let's go!" They started in the direction of the blinking red dots on the pad.

It only took them about 5 minutes to start hearing their voices.

"Why don't you give Adora another chance?" Glimmer was saying.

A sigh. "You wouldn't understand. It's- Would you forgive Bow if he left you for the Horde for whatever reason?"

Glimmer hesitated. "I… would." She said. "Eventually. And so should you. I get if it takes a bit of time but don't completely shove the idea out of your head."

Catra didn't say anything for a few moments. Bow and Adora came up to a collection of trees that Glimmer and Catra were

behind in a clearing. Bow moved to interrupt them but Adora put a hand up to stop him. Bow looked at her questioningly to which she whispered that she wanted to listen.

"Maybe, but… I don't know." Catra finally replied, her tail swung up to her waist and she grabbed onto it with both hands and looked down.

"I trust Adora, and, I think you do too so I think you need to give her another chance." Glimmer said as she walked up to Catra and put a hand on her shoulder.

That's when Adora stomped into the clearing. Bow followed her and tried to make it seem like they hadn't been eavesdropping on their conversation. "Uh- Glimmer! We found you!"

"Adora! Bow!" Glimmer exclaimed and ran over and gave the two a hug. Catra dropped her tail and crossed her arms, looking away.

Adora ignored Glimmer and looked over at Catra. "Catra! Why did you run off like that?"

"Because *you* wouldn't shut up." She responded.

Adora didn't care to continue arguing. She just sighed and said, "Let's go."

"Adora, is something wrong?" Glimmer asked, noticing Adora's odd behaviour.

"No. I'm fine." She answered a bit too quickly and before anyone could say anything else, she started to walk in the direction of Bright Moon.

"Okaaaay." Glimmer followed her, Catra at her side while Bow hurried to catch up to Adora.

He nudged her arm. "You're jealous, aren't you?" He asked, smiling.

Adora turned to him immediately. “Huh? No. Jealous? Of what?” She whispered back. Bow gestured behind them. “Catra? Why’d I be jealous of Catra?”

“Not Catra.”

“Glimmer? No. Absolutely not.”

Bow laughed. “I think you are. You’re jealous that she’s closer to Catra than you are at this moment, or at least, that’s what it seems like.”

Meanwhile, Catra and Glimmer were having a quiet conversation of their own behind them. Bow heard something about how everyone in Bright Moon is a princess. Catra responded with a observation that Bow is not a princess and he decided to tune into their exchange.

“That’s true.” He said and both girls looked up at him. He smiled. “But, I used to be a princess.”

“What does that mean?” Catra asked.

“I didn’t like being a princess so I decided to be a *master archer* ! And also a dude.”

Catra looked impressed. “That’s a thing you can just do? Geez, you princesses really are a phenomenon.”

“It’s not *just* a princess thing. You can be a guy if you wanted to.” Glimmer explained.

“Nah, I’m good.” Catra said and Adora spoke up.

“Wait, you used to be a *girl* ? Why didn’t I know this?”

“You never asked. Plus I don’t like to be defined by my past.”

“Oh, okay.” Adora dropped the topic and continued walking in silence. She seemed upset.

“Are you sure you’re alright?” Bow asked.

“Yeah, ‘m fine.” And with that she sped up and started walking ahead of them on her own.

.

Catra

She's upset because of me.

I want to care, but I can't.

Instead of following her first instinct that she’d learned after years of being as close as can be at the Horde, Catra stayed behind Adora and the rest of the group as they made their way through the woods.

Time Skip

After about half an hour of walking, a bright light was seen through the dark forest and they rounded a corner to see a brilliant castle. It was golden and surrounded by tall cliffs on one side and clear blue water on the other. A bridge trailed from the castle entrance that lead to a large egg-shaped glowing crystal. Further along the bridge was a path down to the water and across to the land they were currently standing on. There was a view of several moons hiding behind pink clouds on the horizon.

This must be Bright Moon.

Adora was already halfway across the bridge as the rest of the group started walking.

Glimmer sighed at this. “I gotta go talk to her.” She said quietly and teleported up to where she was walking.

Any normal person wouldn’t be able to hear their conversation but Catra’s ears were conditioned to hear further away because she was feline.

“Adora, what’s wrong?” Glimmer said.

Adora sighed. “Honestly, I don’t know.”

Glimmer touched her arm. “You’ll get through it, whatever it is. Bow and I are always here for you.”

“But Catra’s not.”

“Listen, I know this will completely contradict everything that I was saying earlier but I think Catra will warm up to you again. I talked to her after finding her in the woods-”

“I know.” Adora hissed then calmed herself down. “Sorry… Thanks Glimmer.”

She changed the topic. “So what’s gonna happen with Catra?”

Glimmer contemplated this. “I think my mom is going to do some kind of questioning- nothing bad though- and then do some background checks or something.”

Adora nodded and they stopped talking. Catra continued to walk behind Bow until they reached the entrance of the castle. Adora and Glimmer were waiting for them and invited them in. Glimmer didn’t seem as suspicious of Catra as she was at the start.

“Adora, you can go hang out in your room if you want. Bow, too. I don’t think my mom will let you guys sit in for this, but I don’t know.”

Adora didn’t say anything and walked in the direction of her room, Catra assumed. Bow gave Glimmer a thumbs up and then a peace sign and ran after her.

Glimmer led Catra through a bright and grand hallway that opened up to a throne room where the Queen of Bright Moon sat. Around the room were various guards and when they entered the Queen stood up.

“Commander Glimmer.” She said with an accent

“Your Majesty.” Glimmer replied and bowed.

“What’s this?” The Queen asked, gesturing at Catra.

“This is Adora’s friend, Catra.”

“Friend from the *Horde* ?”

“Yes.” Glimmer said. Catra stayed silent.

The Queen groaned and walked up to Glimmer, putting her hands on her shoulders. “You need to stop bringing random Horde soldiers here without containing them.”

“Oh, c’mon Mom,” *Mom?* “She’s nice, like Adora, I’m sure of it.”

Wait, the Queen is Glimmer’s mother?

“I’ll have to see. Catra, I’d like to ask you some questions. Is that okay?” Glimmer’s mom turned her attention to Catra.

“Uh, sure.” Catra responded, preparing for the worst, but it never came. For the next hour or so, simple questions were asked of her and finally, “Alright, you can stay.”

Catra tried to smile and Glimmer dragged her out after thanking her mom. “Let’s go on a tour!”

.

<u>Glimmer</u>

It hadn’t been that long since she last had to give a tour of the castle to someone. Only recently, Adora had to be shown around and Glimmer had been reminded how big the place actually was.

When she was younger, the castle had seemed infinite and she was often surprised how they had ended up at certain rooms or doors. Getting to her mom's room was the only route she truly

had memorized since it used to be only a couple doors down from hers. When Glimmer was just a little girl and was just beginning to befriend Bow, who was called Aura at the time, she was very impressed by his ability to navigate the woods and the castle so easily. Even still, to just walk around instead of teleporting made the palace seem a lot bigger than usual.

As they left the throne room, Glimmer led Catra to the most important places like the dining and lounge areas and other specific rooms that might be useful. After about an hour of just walking around, Glimmer attempting to explain the princess lifestyle to Catra, she finally made it to the bedrooms. They approached one of the empty guest rooms that Glimmer had told someone to set up some things suited for someone like Catra or Adora.

"So this is where all the bedrooms are. Mine is down there, Adora's is there…" She pointed out a couple of tall doors in the hallway they stood in. Glimmer came to a stop behind the room meant for Catra.

"And this," the door opened to reveal a boring bedroom with the same bed Glimmer had given to Adora after learning she was used to sleeping on such an uncomfortable mattress. She figured since Catra was also raised in the Horde, she wouldn't want a huge fluffy bed the people of Bright Moon were used to. "This can be your room!"

Catra swept her eyes across the room and pursed her lips. "Uh, I've never had… a room to myself before." She murmured. "I used to sleep with Adora back at the Fright Zone."

"You did *what* ?!"

"I slept with her?... In the same bed? Is that frowned upon here or something?" She took a step back.

"Sleep? Is that all you did?"

Catra blinked. "Yeah, what else would we do?"

Oh, of course. Catra and Adora don't know what 'sleeping with someone' means. Adora didn't even know what an aunt was for Christ sake!

"Oh, okay, that's fine then." Glimmer smiled and dropped it. "Adora never really got used to having her own room either. I'll set this bed up in hers."

Catra's ears folded down a bit. "Is there anywhere else I can go?"

"Nope!" Glimmer said, which was a lie. She wanted Adora and Catra to make up and putting them in the same room together for hours seemed like the best idea. "It's here or Adora's."

"What about your room?"

"No space." *Lies.*

Catra hesitated. "...Fine." She muttered as the end of her tail waved slightly and her ears fell again.

"Awesome!" Glimmer grabbed Catra's arm and teleported over to the outside of Adora's room and prepared to tell her the news. She hoped she wasn't as depressed as earlier and that the fact that Catra was gonna stay in her room would make her feel like Catra wasn't lost from her. Glimmer could tell that Catra still didn't trust any of them the way Adora had when they had first met which was understandable. In any other situation they'd be fighting to the death. Again.

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<u>Adora</u>

It had gotten dark and Adora was sitting in her room, lost in thought when there was a knock on her door.

"Come in."

The door opened and Glimmer walked inside.

“Glimmer! You know you can just teleport in here. I don’t mind.”

“I respect people’s privacy.” She said and curtseyed. “Anyways.” She disappeared for a second and reappeared with a bed identical to Adora’s.

“What’s that?”

“Catra’s bed!” Glimmer giggled.

“She can stay?!” Adora jumped to her feet and tackled Glimmer with a hug.

“Yep, you seem to be feeling better.” She said and Adora smiled. “My mom agreed after confirming that she had actually been kicked out of the Horde and asking a couple of questions.”

A couple of questions took two hours?

“How do you confirm something like that?”

“My mom has her ways.” Glimmer laughed. “Catra, you can come in now!” She sang.

Catra stepped into the room hesitantly only to be immediately hug attacked by Adora. Catra shoved her away.

“Get *off* !” She yelled and took a step back. “We are *not* friends.”

Adora was hurt again. “Then what are we?”

“We’re *just* sharing a room.” She grumbled. “It’s late, I’m going to sleep.” Catra pushed her bed as far away from Adora’s as possible and layed down, facing the wall.

“I guess this is my cue to leave. G’night guys.” Glimmer muttered and disappeared, leaving Adora standing in the middle of the room, in the dark, staring at nothing.

.

Catra

As much as she hated having to fight with Adora, her mind was conditioned to it. After all that time being on opposing sides, Catra had taught herself to dislike the girl she had been so close to her entire life. She knew she didn't have to keep acting this way but something was holding her back. She didn't know how to let Adora know that she did miss her and she did like her.

It was probably around two o'clock in the morning when Catra finally fell asleep.

"Force Captain Catra!" Shadow Weaver's voice echoed and Catra bolted upright but she was nowhere to be seen. "You have failed your mission. Again." All the light in the room replaced itself with shadow. "Insolent child." Catra turned around and saw Shadow Weaver raising darkness around her. "I should've gotten rid of you a long time ago." Catra glance towards Adora's bed but she couldn't make out anything in the pitch-blackness. She directed her eyes back to Shadow Weaver was and Adora stood next to her smirking. "I never liked you Catra. I only felt pity. I am the only one who deserves the position of Force Captain. I am special, you are not." Catra backed away from the two until she was trapped against the wall behind her. "Look, you finally got what you wanted. You went to Bright Moon so I had to leave. I can't stand being around you. And now I'm back at the Fright Zone, where I'm supposed to be. I will destroy you. She-Ra belongs to the Horde now." She pulled her sword out. "It's over, Catra. Catra. Catra? Catra!"

Catra's eyes flew open and Adora's face was about two inches away from hers. Catra mewed in surprise and inched backwards, hissing softly.

"Catra, it's okay, it was just a nightmare." Catra tucked her knees to her chest and wrapped her tail around her ankles. She dropped her head between her knees and breathed heavily.

Just a nightmare? I don't get those often.

Adora petted Catra's hair while mumbling soothingly. What happened the evening before was forgotten. It felt like home. "Can I sleep in your bed tonight?" She asked quietly, not lifting her head.

"'Course, Kitten. C'mon." Adora held her hand and led her to her bed, Catra avoiding looking directly at her. Once Adora had gotten herself situated, Catra curled herself up at the foot of the bed and felt Adora's legs resting against her back. She was home. She fell asleep within minutes.

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<u>Bow</u>

"Bow! Wake up!!" Glimmer shouted, pulling Bow out of his dreams. He jumped out of bed, fists up.

"What happened? Who do I needa fight?" Glimmer yelped and jumped back, putting her hands up to stop him.

"Nothing!" She yelled. "But, I just saw the *cutest thing ever* !!!" Bow hadn't seen her so happy since the Princess Alliance was still together. What could possibly make her like this?

"What is it?" Bow asked and Glimme snatched his hand and teleported both of them to the outside of Adora's room. She smiled wide and slowly pushed the door open.

"Awwwww." Bow's eyes brightened. "How *adora* ble." **(a/n: sorry)** Adora was sleeping in her bed curled in a fetal position while Catra had managed to roll herself into an even smaller ball and was resting between Adora's chest and knees. One of Adora's hands was outside the blankets and wrapped around Catra's frame. He could hear her purring slightly as she slept.

Bow had just stood there smiling like an idiot for like five minutes when suddenly Catra stirred and seemed to wake up. Bow shut the door so that Catra wouldn't see him but he could still peek inside. He wanted to see her reaction based on how she was

acting before. Would the habits she'd only recently made affect the way she felt, or would all the things Adora had said about her show through?

As he watched through a small crack in the door, her saw Catra's multi-colored eyes open and she glanced over at Adora and smiled. Bow mentally fist pumped and saw her adjust her position by stepping in a small circle and lying down again curled up in a small ball; a true cat-like action. She seemed to be glad to be next to Adora again.

To be completely honest, Bow highkey shipped it and he was pretty sure that Glimmer did too. If only he could figure out how to properly explain love to Adora. He could only imagine what it would be like for Adora to fight against an enemy not led by her best friend. Those two fighting alongside each other would definitely be an advantage to team rebellion because they had trust between them and their teamwork would probably be very strong.

Bow hadn't even realized Glimmer wasn't by his side until she whisper-called his name from around a corner.

"Bow! What are you still doing there?"

"Huh? Oh, Glimmer. Sorry, I'm trying to prove a point."

"And what point is that?"

"When we were in the woods, Adora talked to me about Catra and from what she was saying, I was sure she was totally head over heels for her, based on, like, my dads and stuff, but then I find out she doesn't know what love is. At all! And me being totally ace, I had no idea how to explain it!"

"Hmm," Glimmer paused, thinking. "That's totally understandable for Adora. I was talking with Catra last night and she told me she slept with Adora and my mind immediately went… there, and she had no idea what I was talking about."

"I thought I could talk to Spinnerella and Netossa about it? Unless you know anything…" Bow suggested.

"Well my last relationship was kinda a mess so don't ask me." Glimmer laughed. "C'mon let's get breakfast." They started in the direction of the kitchen.

.

Adora

That night after being woken up by Catra having a rough nightmare was pretty peaceful. Adora fell asleep with Catra at her feet and it almost felt like she was back at the Fright Zone. It did freak her out a little bit when she woke up because her instinctive fear was that her leaving the Horde and meeting Bow and Glimmer and the other princesses and fighting against the Horde and being She-Ra in general, was all a really crazy elaborate dream.

But when she opened her eyes and saw pink and sunshine instead of grey, monotonous bed sheets she knew that it wasn't. Soon all the memories from the past 24 hours came rushing into her head: Glimmer's glitch, the beacon, meeting up with Catra, falling off a cliff, Light Hope's information about She-Ra. Adora still knew she had to consider actually going back there to train but now with Catra back, that didn't seem like the best idea.

She let herself back into reality and saw Catra had moved up the bed and was curled up right next to her. She was fast asleep and Adora wanted breakfast, so she carefully and quietly escaped from the bed and tip-toed out of her bedroom.

Once she met up with Glimmer and Bow, she was immediately suspicious. They seemed to be scheming something but Adora didn't bother to ask. When Glimmer saw Adora near the table, she leaned away and smiled at her innocently. 'Innocently.' Adora ignored it.

“Good morning, Adora.” Bow said brightly. “Sleep well?” He and Glimmer batted their eyes at her.

“Okay, what’s this about?”

“Oh, nothing.” Glimmer said, making it obvious that it wasn’t nothing. “Where’s Catra?”

“Still sleeping… why? What’s up with you two?” Adora didn’t have a single clue why they’d be acting like this.

“Oh, come on. You and Catra sleeping together is so cute!”

Adora was confused. “...Why? That’s how it always is?” She said. “Wait, you were watching me sleep? That’s- that’s kinda creepy, not gonna lie.”

Glimmer sighed. “You know what, never mind. I didn’t say anything.” She looked at Bow who only shrugged.

“You guys are weird.” Adora observed and sat down across from them, munching into the breakfast that was prepared for her.

Chapter End Notes

> So Bow is canonically trans and has two dads, those have been confirmed (I think) but I decided to also make him ace, just cause i really can't see him in a proper relationship with anyone. I'm also basing the way Glimmer is on the way I was like a year ago because i feel like we're very similar. (but i've changed a bit)

Curiosity

Chapter Notes

> sorry this is coming out so late, I've had the world's busiest week; I had midterms and a ton of homework so I've had zero time to write but here it is

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bow

As Bow, Glimmer, and Adora sat and calmly ate their breakfast, Glimmer kept sneaking questions about Catra to Adora.

“So tell me, what’s with the mask Catra always wears?” Glimmer asked. This had to be the twentieth question about Catra in the last five minutes. Adora seemed to be getting annoyed.

“What’s with all the questions?”

“I’m just curious, you never really talked about her all that much considering you were so close.”

Adora hesitated. “Well-”

“Adora’s right.” Bow cut in. “You’re asking a bit too many questions, Glimmer. Why don’t we talk about something else?” He suggested. He knew Glimmer really wanted to save Catra and Adora’s relationship and wasn’t surprised when she sighed and looked up at him.

“Like what?” She asked through gritted teeth. Adora didn’t appear to notice.

"How about Adora tells us what happened yesterday in that First One’s ruin? It’s been on my mind for a while. What took you so long in there?”

Glimmer shrugged. “Oh, yeah, Adora how did you even find Catra?” Bow mentally facepalmed. He was trying to change the subject but Glimmer just brought it right back to Catra.

Adora adjusted herself in her chair. “Well, I went to go find a way to heal you, Glimmer, as you know, and it took me a bit but eventually I found that place. At first I didn’t really get any answers when all of a sudden, an alarm goes off and I turn around and Catra’s there.” She explained. “I don’t know why- I should probably ask- but she followed me. I would’ve heard the door open again if she came in on her own.”

“Adora, remember, normal people can’t read First One’s writing and open secret doors.”

“Right, so she followed me and I didn’t notice for a little until, y’know how you set off something in the ruin we ran into when we first met?” She gestured to Glimmer. “That happened again and then everything started closing off and then those spiders showed up-”

“I really don’t like those spiders.” Bow said and shivered.

“Understandably.” Adora responded, then continued. “So we ran for a while until we lost them and then the whole place started tapping into our brains so we had to completely relive a bunch old memories between us.” She rambled on and on.

“And then I almost fell off a cliff but Catra saved me but then we both ended up falling off the cliff-”

“Whoa whoa, slow down.” Glimmer cut her off. “A cliff? In the ruin?”

“It was like an illusion made by all the tech.”

Glimmer looked totally mind-blown. Bow understood the feeling. They had just started really getting to see the First One’s tech up close recently because of She-Ra. It really was incredible.

“I don’t really know anything about it; She-Ra’s really not as powerful as everyone says she is. All I have is this sword.” Adora went on.

“Are you kidding?” Glimmer exclaimed. “‘That sword’ has a whole functioning portable runestone in it. I say that’s pretty amazing.”

“Seconded.” Bow added and Adora smiled at the ground.

“Anyway, continue! I’m getting really into this story.” Glimmer but her chin in her hands and leaned closer to Adora across the table.

“Seconded!” Bow said again.

Adora chuckled. “Okay, so we fell off the cliff, right?” Glimmer nodded. “Then I finally met Light Hope and she said-”

“Wait wait wait.” Glimmer interrupted again. “Sorry, but uh, who’s Light Hope again?”

“Oh, she’s ‘Etheria’s facilitator’ created by the First Ones. She has a conscious and stuff.”

Both Bow and Glimmer hummed in acknowledgement. Again, pretty freaking cool; the First Ones made a whole AI that’s been sitting in the bottom of that old building for centuries and it still works.

“So she told me a lot about the history of Etheria, stuff I’d never learn in school, and then even more about the past She-Ra’s.” Adora returned to her original point. “I didn’t know any of this I don’t know about you guys, but apparently, there hasn’t been a She-Ra for a thousand years because the last one broke the line. Her name was Mara and Light Hope said that she held too close to her attractions and eventually gave into fear and stranded the whole planet in this random galaxy. Now I have no idea how any of *that* works but she said I could go back and train but I had to leave behind *my* attractions. That means you guys. I can’t do that.” Suddenly Adora seemed really distressed. She put her head in her hands. “What if I mess the whole planet up because I’m too

selfish and can’t leave my friends? I’m- I’m not cut out for She-Ra. I just- I’m sorry.” Adora stood up and rushed out.

“Adora!” Bow called after her and he and Glimmer followed her to a dark corner that she sat in, her head resting between her tucked knees. “Adora, are you okay?” Bow asked as he gently put a hand on her shoulder.

She raised her head slightly and sniffled. “Yeah- I’m sorry, this is ridiculous, I-I don’t know why I’m like this.” She set her chin on top of her arms, her gaze focused on a shadow behind them.

“Adora, let me tell you, you are the most badass She-Ra ever.” Bow said and playfully punched her arm. He didn’t like seeing her upset.

“Yeah, and you don’t need to worry about us, we’re always right beside you, ready to fight!”

“We’re gonna win in the end, y’know. We must be strong!”

Adora giggled softly. “Thanks guys.” She sighed and Bow and Glimmer leaned into her on either side.

“When I finished talking to Light Hope, she said ‘The Horde is hurting us’,” Adora resumed the conversation from earlier, “and then Swift Wind came to- wait, where even is Swift Wind?”

“He went to go ‘kick down stable doors.’” Glimmer murmured. Bow looked over to her on the opposite side of Adora. She seemed really sleepy.

“Hey, Glimmer, do you want to go back to sleep? Maybe recharge? You look awfully tired.”

She yawned. “Yeah, I think that might be best."

“C’mon, we’ll walk you to your room.” Bow said and stood up, helping both Glimmer and Adora up too.

“Did you sleep at all last night?” Bow asked as they walked in the direction of the bedrooms.

Glimmer hummed. “Nope!” She chortled. “My mind kept me awake all night, but the thing is, I don’t remember what I was thinking about.”

Adora glanced concerningly over at her and cleared her throat. “Uhm, I think I’m gonna go back to my room too. See ya.” She turned a corner to a hallway that led to her- and Catra’s- room. Bow continued to walk with Glimmer to her room and watched as she fell asleep in her bed almost instantly. He decided a nice stroll in the woods outside of the castle would do him good.

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<u>Adora</u>

Instead of going to her room, Adora decided to wander the halls of the castle distantly but no matter how much she wanted to stay away, she found herself next to the door to her room every time.

After forcing herself to turn away from it several times, she finally let herself enter the room, only to find that Catra had completely destroyed her bed. The sheets were ripped to shreds and the frame of the bed was exposed. Catra hadn’t noticed the door opening and was clawing at the mattress as if it was a scratching post.

“Catra!” Adora said and she jumped up, throwing a shred of sheet to the side and putting her hands behind her back innocently, standing in attention. “What are you doing?”

She relaxed and hopped back on the ripped mattress in a half-squatting-half-sitting position with one knee bent at her side and the other sitting upright and her arm rested on it. Her other hand was supporting her weight behind her.

"I gotta sharpen my claws on something.” She said nonchalantly and leaned back on her hand.

“Catra, that’s your bed, you can’t sleep on *that*.”

“I know, I’m sleeping on your bed.”

Adora was taken aback. “You…… are?”

“Yeah.” She said, as if it were obvious. Suddenly there was a knock on the door. Adora turned around and opened it to see a guard standing outside.

“Queen Angella has called a meeting. Your presence is mandatory.”

Adora glanced back at Catra who shrugged and looked to the side. Adora followed the guard out and started over to the huge meeting room and Glimmer appeared beside her as she walked. Adora flinched slightly at her appearance and Glimmer stretched her arms up and yawned.

“Hey Adora.” She said mid-yawn. Right, she had just gone back to sleep. She must have been woken up again. Poor girl, she just needed her beauty sleep.

“What do you think this meeting’s about?” Adora whispered to Glimmer.

“I don’t know. The weekly meeting was just two days ago so this must be to discuss something else important.”

As she finished her sentence, the two reached the entrance of the assembly room and a guard was holding the door open for them. Bow was already sitting in his chair and so were the other two princesses, Spinnerella and Netossa. Adora and Glimmer took their seats and the queen entered and sat down herself.

She explained that she had scheduled this meeting to talk about recent events regarding the Horde. Apparently, the strange weather changes that Glimmer had mentioned that occured the previous day had been noticed by Bright Moon and they had managed to trace their origins to the Horde. Because Bow,

Glimmer, and Adora had been out at the time, Angella wanted to know if they knew anything about it.

Glimmer described a huge blood-red pillar of light that had been emitting from the Horde's direction and a strange blizzard in the Whispering Woods. Of course Adora didn't know anything about it since she had been inside the First One's ruin during the entire event but the one thing she was asked was how she had healed Glimmer of her glitch. Adora had almost forgotten about that and was surprised that this wasn't asked earlier.

"Um, I learned a lot of things about the First Ones from a person named Light Hope and I tried one more thing to get rid of the curse that was placed on Glimmer and it, well, it worked."

"Would you be able to do the same thing again if by chance something similar happens again?"

"It won't happen again, mom!" Glimmer interrupted.

Adora hesitated but the Queen's look pressured her to respond. "I'm… not sure. It might have been just… luck?"

Glimmer's mother nodded and continued speaking. She spoke about the Horde possibly becoming more dangerous and that the fact that a new member of Bright Moon's rebellion was a powerful Captain from the Fright Zone was troubling. To make sure that she wasn't in any contact with the Horde, Queen Angella placed a quarantine on Catra and said she wasn't allowed to leave the castle.

"What? No, mom, that isn't necessary. The Horde exiled her, she would never be in contact with them." Glimmer argued.

"Yeah, Glimmer's right, uh, with respect, I think a better idea would be to let her leave and see *if* anything happens." Bow added.

"And risk an attack on Bright Moon? Bow, Glimmer, I understand that you two and especially Adora have become acquaintances

with this girl, but I don’t want to take any chances for you, or anyone in this kingdom, to get hurt.”

Adora stayed silent. She didn’t agree nor disagree with the Queen. What she was saying made some sense since Catra had so recently been an enemy of the rebellion and she didn’t have as good a reason as Adora did to suddenly become one hundred percent against her the place she had lived at for so long. However, Adora knew Catra. If she had any other choice, she wouldn’t ally with Adora or her friends for anything in her life. And Shadow Weaver had always been harsh to her, so it would be understandable that she would want to fight back and get revenge against her and Hordak, especially after they cast her out.

Before she knew it, the meeting had ended and the decision to keep Catra inside until further notice was appointed.

The next few days, nothing happened and their days went on as normal for the “Best Friend Squad”. The only thing that concerned Adora was that Catra had never left her room for anything; not to eat, to socialize, anything. This was a very noticable difference from how Catra had been all her life at the Fright Zone to how she was acting now. Based on Adora’s past with Catra, she assumed that Catra would have wanted to explore and be out and about, maybe jump around under the tall ceilings, unseen in the shadows if she didn’t want to interact with anyone. But she didn’t do even that. She always stayed away from the door and if anyone else but Adora ever came in, she’d almost hide from them. The only times she would communicate with Adora was in the nights when she was curled up at the foot of her bed, peacefully and fast asleep. She didn't have any nightmares these next few nights and the evenings and mornings were just about back to the way they were at the Fright Zone; they made simple small talk though when Adora asked why Catra refused to leave her room, she'd change the subject or insist that she was tired and wanted to go to bed. It was nice, though, to have her by her side again. It made her nights a lot more comfortable.

Adora spent most her days with Glimmer and Bow in the Castle of Bright Moon, mostly just talking amongst themselves or playing games. Occasionally, there'd be a distress call from a small nearby kingdom that had been invaded by the Horde and She-Ra would be sent to deal with it but that wasn't anything out of the ordinary.

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Glimmer

Nothing. Absolutely nothing had happened. The past week was extremely boring. Sure, they had to shut down one or two Horde camps but that was a common occurrence. And after meeting Adora, witnessing the first She-Ra in a thousand years, getting permission to rebuild the Princess Alliance, actually rebuilding the Princess Alliance, Princess Prom, *getting kidnapped and held captive in the Fright Zone,* getting cursed, meeting a talking horse, and have a ex-Horde soldier join the rebellion, all in the last month, normal was a bit *too* normal. Glimmer didn't like it. She also didn't like that they had obtained a powerful Rebellion fighter who wouldn't do anything. Glimmer knew Catra was strong from previous battles and she would be a massive asset to the Rebellion's cause. But, she did not leave her room. Ever. Glimmer was intent on changing that.

"Adora!" She exclaimed as the blond entered the dining area for breakfast that day. "I have a great idea!"

Adora raised an eyebrow and smiled. "What is it?"

"What if we take Catra, to Mystacor!"

"Glimmer, she's not allowed to leave yet."

"I can convince my mom today, I promise." Glimmer bounced on the balls of her feet.

"Why do *you* want Catra to leave her room so much?"

“New rebel who's our age! You've been friends with her for years! She needs to get out and about!"

“Okay, but I don't think she'll want to go considering she hasn't tried to talk or interact with anyone or anything.”

“We can deal with that *after* I convince my mom to let us go.”

Adora crossed her arms and smirked. “I highly doubt that. But, go ahead and try.”

“Yay!” Bow walked up behind her as she beamed.

“Hi, Adora.” He said. “Hi Glimmer, what's with you?” He noticed her dramatic excitement.

“We're taking Catra to Mystacor!”

“Really? Your mom is letting her leave?”

“No!” Glimmer said and Bow cocked his head. “Not yet! But she will!”

Bow mimicked Adora's pose from earlier. “How can you be so sure?”

Glimmer straightened her position proudly. “I've convinced her to let me do things a lot worse than this in the past.” Bow grimaced but didn't ask her to elaborate.

Time Skip

Glimmer had gone to talk to her mom while Bow and Adora went to sit outside and enjoy the nice weather. Glimmer had used tricks and skills her mom always fell for to let her know how much she, Adora, and Bow wanted to take Catra to Mystacor.

She explained that Catra seemed miserable and locked herself in her room 24/7 and it would really benefit all of them to go on a relaxing trip to Mystacor to trial Catra's loyalty to the Rebellion.

What she didn't tell her was that another main reason she wanted to go was to get Adora and Catra to get even closer. She knew they slept in the same bed, but that didn't seem to affect their relationship in any way. Mystacor was filled with couples and it would be an awesome influence on the two if what Bow and Glimmer thought was true: Adora was in love with Catra and vice versa.

It took about fifteen minutes but finally, the Queen agreed to allow Catra on a vacation with the three friends. “Fine Glimmer, but you must keep an eye on her at all times. If anything happens while you are gone, she will be the first to blame unless you have solid evidence that says otherwise.”

“Yes! Thank you mom!” She teleported to her side and kissed her on the cheek. “This'll be good, I promise!”

She thanked her mom again and then immediately teleported to where Adora and Bow were sitting outside to tell them the news. Both jumped slightly at her arrival but relaxed once they realized it was just her.

“We have permission!” She exclaimed and Bow fist pumped and Adora looked almost shocked.

“Yeah, Mystacor!” Bow shouted and Adora laughed.

Now came the hard part: getting Catra to agree to go. But Glimmer knew they'd get her there somehow, even if they had to drag her out.

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<u>Catra</u>

Surrounded by princesses. Not the way Catra had particularly wanted to spend her life. When Adora had told her she wasn’t allowed to leave, she was upset, though she was always pretty good at hiding her emotions, for the most part. When she had first gotten that room to stay in, she was impressed by the size of

the window; she could jump out and explore the forest, something she never actually got the chance to do. But she couldn't. Catra didn't want to get banished from another place that she could learn to call home, despite how uncomfortable she still was around princess folk. So she stayed in her room, away from everyone and everything. Except for Adora. Adora was different. Sure, she was the *legendary She-Ra,* but when she wasn't, she was exactly the same Adora from the Horde. She still had the same sense of humor, the same eyes, the same determination, the same strength, the same smile. She never failed to brighten the mood of anyone around her, though Catra would never admit that, especially not now.

A knock on the door pulled her out of her thoughts. *Strange.* Adora never knocked.

"Adora?"

"Yeah, and Bow and Glimmer."

Catra grunted and walked over to the door. As soon as it opened, the smallest princess grabbed her arm and dragged her over the line that separated the room from the hallway. Catra shrieked and shoved her away, jumping back and landing on her feet and one hand.

"Glimmer!" Adora exclaimed and Glimmer shrugged.

"Worth a try." She muttered as Adora entered the room and stood in front of Catra who had straightened her position. Adora grabbed both of Catra's hands and looked her straight in the eye. Catra didn't bother to push her away.

"Catra, you've been permitted to leave so we are going to take you to a place called Mystacor."

"What? Uh, no, I'm *not* going somewhere with even more princesses than there are here." She snapped and stepped away from her. "I've seen that place. I watched Shadow Weaver torture

you with her magic as she watched you and your friends prance about over there. I'd rather *not.* "

"Catra, please." Adora pleaded. "I've been worrying about you; you haven't stepped out of your room, you've only eaten the small amounts of food that I bring you, and, you seem… paranoid all the time."

"We want you to have your own freedom." Glimmer added from the doorway and Catra shot her a look.

"You know what, can I talk to her alone?" Adora said to Glimmer and Bow who nodded and let her be.

Now it was just Adora and Catra standing alone in the sun lit room. A ray of light from the large circular window shone on the two. Adora moved away from it and sat down on the bed, gesturing for Catra to do the same. She reluctantly shuffled over and sat beside Adora.

Adora took her hand again and leaned in closer to her. "Catra, can you please tell me what's wrong? You don't seem to want to interact with anything in this place."

Catra sighed and averted her eyes from Adora's gaze.

"I- just- princesses. All our lives we were taught that they were bloodthirsty monsters that threatened the whole planet. And now suddenly you want me to believe they're not? I've seen; they are different but, I just… don't feel comfortable, around them."

"Well, maybe if you try to get to know them more, you'd feel more comfortable. I know Glimmer is dying to be friends with you, she never stops asking about you. I think you should give this vacation a try." Adora put her hand to Catra's cheek and brought her eyes to look into hers.

Suddenly Catra heard something like a gasping noise from the direction of the door. Adora seemed to hear it too and both turned

their heads towards the door, Adora's hand falling. The door was open just a crack and Catra was sure that Adora had shut it.

Adora stood up and left Catra sitting on the bed. Suddenly she felt cold. Adora swung open the door to see nothing but a couple of stray sparkles floating in the air. *Glimmer* . Adora closed the door and placed back to Catra. “I think Glimmer's spying on us.” She whispered.

“What's her problem?” Catra responded.

“I'm sure it's nothing. She probably just wants to hear your voice. Like I said, she's very curious about you.” Catra opened her mouth to say something and Adora shushed her.

“I'll be able to hear if she comes back.”

Sure enough, not even twenty seconds later, a soft twinkle and a thud was heard from outside their room. If they had still been talking, they wouldn't have heard it. Adora quietly stepped back to the door and pulled it open and the small princess toppled into the room as if she were leaning on the door.

“Oh, hi, Adora.” She said innocently and Adora raised an eyebrow.

“What were you doing?”

Glimmer smiled fakely. “Nothing! Ha ha, but, the more important question is,” she stood up and turned to Catra, “will you go to Mystacor with us?”

Adora glanced back at Catra, her eyes pleading. How could she say no to that?

“Ughhhhhh, fine.” Catra said, crossing her arms over her chest. Her tail flicked once.

“Sweet!” Glimmer grabbed both Adora and Catra's arm and teleported to the front entrance of the castle. As soon as they reappeared, Catra yelped. She was *not* used to that.

Bow was already there. “C'mon, let's go!” Glimmer exclaimed.

“Wait!” Adora said and Glimmer stopped in her tracks. “Catra, you should probably get rid of… that.” She pointed to the Horde Force Captain pin that was still fastened to her belt. She snatched it and threw it as far away as she could. She couldn't believe she was still wearing it. She always wore the same thing so she must have not noticed it. She didn't want to have anything to do with the Horde after they treated her so poorly. She despised the fact that her habits reflected the things she learned at the Fright Zone but she couldn't seem to change her attitude.

The three looked satisfied and started on their journey to the kingdom of Mystacor.

They first had to walk through the Whispering Woods which was an adventure in itself. Luckily, Bow and Glimmer seemed to bow exactly where they were going. Adora and Catra followed behind them. They didn't talk all that much as they made their way through the forest.

Soon they reached a cliff that overlooked what seemed like a thousand foot drop. “Great, did you get us lost?” Catra said miserably.

“Nope!” Bow and Glimmer ran towards the edge of the cliff and Adora followed, dragging Catra behind her.

“What are we doing?!” Catra exclaimed and tried to tug away from Adora but her grip was too strong. Bow and Glimmer leaped off the cliff and Adora followed directly behind them. Catra shrieked until she saw a platform raising underneath them. It was a flying rock with green grass and plants covering the surface. They landed safely but Catra was still shaken by the experience.

“Don't *do* that!” Catra elbowed Adora who just laughed.

The hunk of rock was floating through and above fluffy pink clouds. The sun was right overhead and the warmth was incredibly satisfying. Soon, the cliff began to near another flying

rock. It resembled the one they were standing on but was at least twenty times its size. It was surrounded by some bubble and as they passed through it, a beautiful and enormous castle stood on the grass.

Around it, water flowed all over. Golden arches that led to flourishing green pathways were noteworthy and royal gardens surrounded the castle like a moat of flowers. The lighting gave everything a purple tint and there was nothing visible on any side of it for miles.

Their transport stone collided with the kingdom and the four of them hopped off onto the sturdy ground.

“Glimmer! Back again so soon!” A voice said and Catra turned to see a woman with black hair with a golden halo-like tiara rushing in their direction.

Glimmer looked uncomfortable. “Hi, Aunt Casta.” She said, and smiled though it seemed forced.

‘Aunt Casta’ gasped when she saw Catra. What was it? Was she still wearing something related to the Horde?

“Glimmer! I see you've brought another new friend!”

Glimmer forced another grin. “Yep! This is Catra.”

Catra didn't change her glare. She wanted anyone and everyone to see that she did *not* want to be there.

“Cheery one, aren't ya.” Casta said and laughed. She started to walk away and the rest followed, Catra rolling her eyes.

This'll be fun.

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<u>Entrapta</u>

“Entrapta, I'm going out for a bit.” Scorpia called to her, interrupting her studies.

“Alright, I'll keep working.” Entrapta said, continuing to type as she spoke. “If I find anything important while you're gone, I'll send Emily to find you.” Her hair molded into a thumbs up and then a wave and then Scorpia was gone. She didn't particularly care where she was going, all she really cared about was all the new information she was digging up.

The past few days were not successful. The Black Garnet was not powerful enough after Shadow Weaver had stopped looking after it and after it drained all the power in that section of the Fright Zone. Entrapta could not seem to figure out how to repair it. It seemed almost permanently damaged and there was nothing she could do about it. She needed more information.

She had almost located a new data crystal; it was somewhere in the Whispering Woods, but she wasn't positive of where exactly. She continued to narrow it's position until she traced it to one general area. With Scorpia gone, Entrapta would have to search for it herself.

She knew that it would most likely be in a building filled with delicious First One's technology so she sent out a signal to cut off all First One's tech within a two mile radius from functioning properly, including the constantly shifting Whispering Woods. This way she'd be allowed to enter.

She left the moment she was sure of the information. Her tracker led her through the woods to a giant First One's ruin. Its blue glow was faded and the secret trap door in the ground in front of the building was dropped open. Footprints led to and away from the structure. Someone had been there recently.

Entrapta hummed as she used her hair to maneuver herself around fallen rocks and broken doorways until she reached a large room lit with some sort of natural lighting. There were colorful crystal walls and a pathway leading to a platform in the center of

the room. An image of She-Ra was built into the wall furthest from her. Etherian words covered the walls and floors around her. If only she could translate them.

She turned to her right and saw a broken crystal motherboard. It looked as if something had shot through it with a beam of some sort. Laying on top of the thick shard was a small triangular disc: the data crystal.

Entrapta let out a single cheer and snatched the disc with a pigtail shaped like a hand. While she had the chance, she decided to go exploring through the powered down ruin.

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Adora

Mystacor truly was beautiful. Adora didn't get the chance to experience it at its full potential because the last time she was here, Shadow Weaver had been following her. She had assumed that Shadow Weaver had gotten over Adora. If she hadn't, she would have kept Catra at the Horde since she knew that Catra would do anything to get her back. Their relationship was that strong and Adora knew it. She wasn't quite sure if Catra realized though.

As Adora followed Bow, Glimmer and Castaspella, with Catra tagging along behind them, Adora saw once again a large group of people performing gorgeous magical arts in the lovely weather. It was so cheerful. Before she came there the first time, Glimmer had said it was home to all of Etheria's sorcerers and that proved to be true because everyone had some kind of aura around them radiating power and warmth. Adora hadn't been carefree enough to notice these things the last time.

They entered the castle and Adora immediately cringed at the memory of her destroying some precious architecture in fear of Shadow Weaver. She hoped no one else remembered. Inside, everything was crystal and shining; you could practically hear the

walls and other objects shimmering. She hoped Catra liked it; it was definitely a major change from the dark and musty atmosphere at the Fright Zone.

Adora followed Glimmer to a room she hadn’t seen before that had two large glittery sofas and several comfortably looking chairs with a small fountain in the center.

“Welcome to the lounge!” Glimmer sang, raising her arms up and spinning once. “Not many people actually go here since there’s so many other places but I figured we could start here. I think Adora and Catra could use some relaxation that isn’t too extravagant.”

Catra’s tail flinched. “Does this mean I can sleep?” She sounded annoyed and bored.

“Sure, go ahead.” Glimmer said and Catra immediately jumped onto the couch and circled a few times on all fours until laying down curled up in a ball on the left-most cushion.

Adora suddenly realized how tired she was. Not being completely alert because of a shadow spying on her made her understand what a long and exhausting trek the path from Bright Moon to Mystacor was. “Honestly, I’m pretty tired too.” She yawned and sat down next to Catra and layed down in a more stretched position on the opposite side of the sofa. She might have heard two sets of footsteps leaving the room before she fell into a comfortable sleep.

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<u>Scorpia</u>

Scorpia was an all around friendly person. Sure, she had made a new friend, Entrapta (the two made up the ‘Super Pal Duo’) but Scorpia thought it would be fantastic to have her best friend Catra on in their squad. So she went on a mission to visit Catra. But the unfortunate thing was that she hadn't the slightest clue where she would be.

As a Force Captain, Scorpia was allowed to venture into the Whispering Woods at any time as long as she had a valid excuse. She assumed friendship wasn't a good enough reason for Lord Hordak so she said she was searching for some technology for Entrapta.

When Catra left, she was sent out of the doors leading to the Whispering Woods so that was her first seeking spot.

About a half hour of walking mindlessly in a straight line, Scorpia felt some kind of energy pulse and suddenly everything seemed less dark and spooky. She didn't think much of it and continued to walk. She didn't understand how anyone could find anything in that forest because it was so large and confusing.

Scorpia assumed that if she continued walking forward, she'd eventually end up on the other side, although in school they were told that the woods were magic and could move when you weren't looking. But nothing she passed by seemed remotely familiar to her. She was making progress.

Time Skip

Two hours had passed and Scorpia spotted a clearing that was greener and brighter than the rest of the forest. Must be a sign.

She stepped up toward it and found it was not merely a clearing at all. It was entire massive kingdom. If Scorpia had found this place, Catra must have too.

She must be here. I can feel it.

The kingdom was centered around a giant castle sitting on the side of a cliff with water rushing down either side of it. It would be far too obvious for Scorpia to walk straight up to the front gates on the given pathway so she walked around the outskirts of the large lake that surrounded the city to find a different entrance.

She moved a couple of steps to her right until she saw a large open window on the second floor of the castle. Inside, it looked

like a bedroom from what she could see. There was purple walls with spherical lights dropping below a bed hanging high from the ceiling. And it was vacant. The perfect entry point.

Scorpia made sure no one was watching and quickly swam across the water border encircling the mountain. Conveniently, a rope hung from the windowsill establishing the idea that this entrance is used by other people.

Once she got inside, she examined the room closely. A photograph on a shelf showed the Princess Glimmer and her friend Bow. So this is where she lived. Perhaps this was Bright Moon? Even if she didn't find Catra, knowing the location of Bright Moon was this easily accessible would be a huge advantage against the Rebellion.

Scorpia walked as quietly as she could to the door and opened it a crack. She peered out and saw several guards dressed in white, blue, and purple robes and a sturdy helmet on their heads. Each held a staff with a U-shaped pendant on top. Not the greatest idea to go out there.

Quietly shutting the door, Scorpia pondered where she might find Catra. It didn't seem like she would be able to explore this castle any more. She admired the room's design some more before deciding to leave but as she stepped toward the window, she slipped on a stray clothing article that was left on the floor. With no time to regain her balance she came crashing down, shaking the entire room in the process, knocking over several loose objects on the shelves.

Crap!

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<u>Catra</u>

Catra stirred awake and tried to roll herself over before realized a large solid object wasn't allowing her to. Catra sat up and saw Adora's head resting next to her thigh. She looked so calm and

peaceful that Catra didn't bother to move herself anymore and relaxed on the couch cushion.

A few minutes passed and Glimmer and Bow entered into the lounge. Glimmer's eyes lit up when she saw Catra awake and shouted, “Great! You guys are awake!”

Catra attempted to shush her but it was too late. Adora had woken up. She sat herself up and rubbed at her face. Her hair was half undone and tragically messed up and her left cheek had an imprint of the cushion on it.

“What's this couch made of? That was the best sleep I've gotten in weeks.” She said and Catra couldn't help but stare at the disheveled girl. “I think relaxation suits me, whaddya think?” She giggled. What a nice sound.

Ugh.

This place was making Catra sentimental.

She rested her elbow on the arm of the couch and held her head, gazing on the opposite direction while Bow, Glimmer, and Adora laughed and chatted. Catra lost track of time so it could have been minutes, seconds, hours until she felt a tap on her shoulder.

“Catra, you okay?” Adora asked. She mhm'ed. “Well, we're going to the steam grotto if you want to come.”

“I think I'll pass.” Catra responded slyly.

“No,” Glimmer cut in, “you have to come.” She grabbed her arm and dragged her into a standing position off the couch. Catra groaned and followed them to another part of the giant castle.

Adora walked in step by her side. “Sorry about her.” She said. “Glimmer's just really enthusiastic about you agreeing to come. Plus I think it'll be a good idea for is to all stay together. Wouldn't want you getting lost.” Adora explained quietly as they passed through another shimmering hallway.

Another two minutes of walking later, they arrived at what looked like some Gucci locker room.

“Okay, we have to change.” Glimmer pulled out some white bandage-looking short outfits.

“I'm sorry, we have to *what?* ” Catra asked and crossed her arms.

“You have to change clothes. You can't go into the steam grotto wearing that.” Glimmer explained.

“Yeah, no one told me what a ‘steam grotto’ is and I am *not* going if I have to change.” She pouted.

Adora put a hand on her shoulder. “It's alright, Catra. This is the only thing that calmed me down last time, can you please give it a try?” She held out a set of clothes for her.

Catra sighed and rolled her eyes. She hesitated. “...Fine.” She snatched the outfit from Adora and walked into one of the many stalls. There was a full body mirror on the wall.

Great, I have to watch myself get dressed?

She undressed herself and looked at her body in the mirror. She had a smaller than average but strong frame with tabby stripes lining her arms, legs, and core. Her tail extended from right underneath her lower back and her ears folded out from behind her mask. She discarded the mask. It had been a gift from Shadow Weaver a few years back. There was no reason for her to receive a gift but Catra ended up liking it, so she never took it off. Now, looking at herself properly for the first time in months, she realized how much she truly despised it. The mask reminded her too much of Shadow Weaver, of the Fright Zone, of home, one she’d never be going back to. The woman who raised her kicked her out like she was garbage and she didn’t want anything to do with her or the Horde any longer. She picked up the mask from the floor and snapped it in half over her knee and quickly put on the clothes she was given, finishing it off with a white robe.

She stepped out from behind the curtain she was hidden behind and saw that Adora, Glimmer, and Bow were already dressed and waiting. Adora’s eyes widened as soon as she saw Catra. She ran up to her. “You-you took the mask off!” She seemed absolutely bewildered. It made some sense; Catra had been wearing that 24/7 for the last three and a half years, it had basically become a part of her head.

Catra shook it off and pressed the two broken pieces into Adora’s palm and paced over towards Glimmer and Bow who started walking towards a large entrance to a steam-filled room. Adora stayed still for a moment before running to catch up with them.

God I hope this isn't horrible.

Chapter End Notes

so this chapter was originally supposed to be a lot longer than it is but I decided to cut it in half so I hope it's not too boring ? I tried to add as much Catra redemption as possible. Anyways hope you enjoy

~A

Reconnections

Chapter Notes

> hello again, I think I've decided my time limit between these chapters will be three weeks since my previous qoal of two weeks has failed twice??? anyways heres the new chapter. sorry in advance if entrapta is extremely out of character, I was kind of rushing through this chapter but i hope you enjoy nonetheless.
>
> one of the ideas presented in this chapter is not mine so i credited my inspiration in the end notes yeet

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer

Glimmer led Bow, Catra, and Adora into the steam grotto. She could feel the warmth already soothing every cell in her body. The relaxing sensation was interrupted by a grunt of discontentment from behind her.

"No no no. It's water? Hell no." Catra expressed and jumped back hiding behind Adora.

"Well, yeah, that's where steam comes from-" Bow answered but was interrupted by Catra complaining again.

"No shit, Sherlock, but no one told me that we were going *in* the water."

Right. Cats don't normally like water, do they?

Glimmer saw Adora step forwards and turn to Catra. "Catra, it's alright. This isn't like an ordinary bath. I *know* you don't like that, but these pools are filled with… uh," she turned to Glimmer for help. "magical healing minerals." She finished Adora's sentence.

“It doesn’t even feel like water-like, the water at the Fright Zone was always cold, this is just… pure warmth. Just try it, please.” She started to pull Catra into the dim room. She struggled but eventually gave in. One step into the sauna, she whimpered and jumped onto Adora’s shoulder and back.

“Ehhh, the floor’s wet.”

Adora was startled for a moment and winced slightly from Catra’s claws digging into her skin but soon relaxed. She looked up at her. “Catra, this isn’t the first time you’ve been wet.” She said. Glimmer snorted, God, how immature. Adora just glanced at her, confused and continued.

“C’mon, Catra,” she giggled as she spoke, “it’s fine.” She picked Catra up by the shoulders and placed her back into a standing position on the floor and Catra drew her arms up and stood on one leg, discomfort manifested on her face. She carefully touched her right big toe to the ground, followed by her heel shortly after.

“See, it’s just water, you’ve been in it before.” Adora explained and Catra crossed her arms.

“Never said I was okay with it.”

Adora sighed and rolled her eyes and grabbed Catra’s arm, leading her to one of the several hot tubs. Catra seemed to get used the water under her feet after a couple more steps. When they were a few feet from their chosen pool, Glimmer and Bow threw off their robes and hopped right in.

When Adora removed her robe, Glimmer couldn't help but notice how Catra eyed her from head to toe briefly. She smirked from the comfort of the warm water.

Catra hesitated, but took hers off too. And, what do you know, she had more of those stripes on her calves and sides.

Adora's facial expression twitched. “You look good, Catra.” She said casually.

Catra just rolled her eyes to the side and crossed her arms.

Adora stepped into the pool and helped Catra in, the same way Glimmer had for her. When Catra made contact with the water, her tail stiffened and her ears perked up, relaxing after a moment, though still seeming tense as she lowered herself further.

Glimmer took the time to examine the two's behavior around each other. Adora seemed very calm and caring. Her voice was always soft when speaking and her touch was always gentle, despite growing up in a place that taught her to fight and be rough with others. Catra on the other hand, was always alert and ready to attack at the slightest mishap. She was always tense and angry, though not as much when she was with Adora. It must have been because of their history. Glimmer recalled Adora mentioning that they had to relive memories between them while in that ruin and she wondered what kind of past they had specifically. Maybe Adora would be more open to talking about it when Catra came to be more friendly towards princesses and the such.

Lost in thought, Glimmer hadn't noticed the silence that had developed around her. Catra and Adora had fallen asleep. Again. Adora's head had fallen onto Catra's shoulder and Catra's rested on the top of Adora's.

Glimmer turned to Bow to get his attention to them but he was sleeping, too. This place really was a sleep haven. Glimmer watched as Adora snuggled into Catra until giving in to her tiredness as well.

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<u>Catra</u>

“C'yra of D'riluth III.”

Catra opened her eyes to the sound of a woman's voice only to see more darkness. She was once again in the “Infinite Darkness Room”, but this time there was no red shining orb or Adora's sword to light the way.

She looked around for any kind of exit, or the source of the voice when it spoke again from behind her

“Or… Catra, is that what they call you now?”

Catra spun around to see a dark figure of a person in the shadows.

“Who are you?” She tried to take a step forward but the distance between them did not decrease. She marched forward but nothing changed. Catra sighed and the woman continued.

“C'yra, you must-”

“What is ‘C'yra’?” Catra interrupted. “And you ignored my question; who are you?”

“C'yra is your name.”

“No, it's not.” *Is it?* Catra knew she was an orphan found as a baby and her earliest memories were with the name ‘Catra’. Perhaps this woman was telling the truth?

“Yes, it is, though, would you prefer Catra?”

“Yes, I would, actually.” She said and crossed her arms. She tried to focus as much as she could on the figure before her but her eyes would not adjust to the blackness. The only distinguishable feature of the person was her eyes. They practically glowed, as if someone was shining a light at them. Both were blue, the same shade and shape of Catra's right.

Catra cleared her throat. “Now-”

“Catra, you must follow my instructions very closely.” The voice said and Catra groaned. She clenched her jaw.

“Oh yeah? And what's that?”

“You must return to Castle Bright Moon immediately. There is somebody there, waiting for you.”

“Yeah, the Queen, who, I may say, *doesn't trust me.* ”

“You must trust her first in order to be trusted.” The woman said. “You must trust all princesses, for your own safety, I am telling you this.”

“Hmm, I’ll think about it.” She said sarcastically. “Now, can you please tell me who you are?” Catra insisted. The woman took a single step forward, revealing a few more features of her. She could faintly see the outline of a tail and pointy ears along with a large mop of dark hair on her head.

“I am your mother.”

“My… mother?” Catra took a step closer but once again, the distance between them did not change. Catra figured that after all the things that happened recently, this person could be telling the truth. Thus, Catra was angry. What kind of mother would let her child go with an evil sorceress like Shadow Weaver?

“Yes, I-”

“Why did you give me up? Why did you let me go with Shadow Weaver?” Catra interrupted, her voice breaking.

“We had no choice. We knew that at some point you’d find yourself back with your people.”

“Princesses? My people? Absolutely not.”

“But C’yra, you are not what you think you are. Your heritage is complicated. This was one of the reasons you could not say with us.”

“Sure. So what are you doing here now?” Catra’s voice shook slightly.

“I am giving you an important message.”

“Why you? Anyone could have. Anyone!”

Suddenly a chill fell upon Catra. The dark seemed to get even darker. It felt like spirits were flying around her when she saw a hint of red.

“Anyone?” Shadow Weaver appeared from the empty space and lunged straight towards her.

Catra's eyes flew open and she jumped up and saw she was still in the steam grotto.

Adora was disturbed from her sleep and sat up groggily but quickly. “Catra, you okay?” She said and placed a hand on her shoulder.

Catra shoved her off. “I'm fine, Adora.” She said a little too harshly.

“Did you have another nightmare?”

“No- just forget it.” Catra looked away from Adora and reflected on what she had heard in that dream. Was it a dream? To be safe, Catra decided it was best for them to leave as soon as possible.

Was this woman- my mother- was she trying to tell me that I’m a princess? Catra didn’t completely understand but was pulled out of her thoughts by footsteps sounding from behind her and Adora.

“Alright, lovebirds, it's time to leave.”

Catra whipped her head around to Glimmer standing behind them. “Who're you calling lovebirds?”

Glimmer cringed and took a step back.

“Uhhh.” Adora seemed confused.

“Hahah, she thinks we're in love, what a *joke* .” Catra said and nudged Adora who frowned.

“I, uh, I don't know what that means.”

“Wha- Really? You know what, I'm *not* going to explain it to you.” Catra got out as fast as possible, shook water off herself, and headed toward the locker room from earlier while Adora watched with furrowed eyebrows.

Love. Love was something that Catra didn't fully understand yet but she knew there was no place for it in her life. Especially in Adora’s case. She left her alone, betrayed her. No way, they were in love, not a chance.

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<u>Adora</u>

Adora felt she was left out of something. It couldn't possibly be her fault that she didn't know what love was. But, Catra had the same upbringing, so, why did she understand and Adora did not?

She remembered the first time she heard that word. It was Princess Prom. Catra had made friends with Entrapta and said it before she pulled Entrapta away to remind her where her place in the war was.

“‘Is this what love feels like?’” She had said. Adora didn't understand it then and she didn't understand it now. She felt awfully stupid for being the only one who didn't know what these things meant.

The next time she heard it was only a few days after. Swift Wind had mentioned it while convincing her to leave the beacon and help her friends. He dubbed them “the people she loved.” Could it be the people she cherished? The people she knew? It could really mean anything.

Adora was brought back to reality by Glimmer tapping on her shoulder. “Adora, let's go change, I promised my mom that we'd only be gone a day.”

Adora nodded. “Right, yeah.”

Time Skip

The sun was just beginning to set when they reached the Whispering Woods. It made the forest give off larger shadows than usual. Catra walked ahead while Glimmer, Bow, and Adora dragged behind. Adora decided not to bring up her confusions about ‘love’ as Catra seemed to freak out a bit last time. She'd wait until they got back to Bright Moon.

“Come on, guys, could you walk any slower?” Catra called back.

“Catra, you don't even know where you're going.” Adora pointed out and Catra turned around, walking backwards in the same direction.

“I *always* know where I'm going.” She boasted as she nearly ran into a tree.

“Why are you so eager to get back? I thought you liked the woods.” Bow said.

“No reason, you guys are just slow.” She said, her back turned to them as she walked forwards again. She didn’t speak much after that and eventually Glimmer moved up to lead the group through the confusing forest. At some point Catra had climbed a tree and continued to follow them from above by hopping from branch to branch, something Adora had gotten used to after all the times she had done the same on the many poles and bars throughout the Fright Zone.

Soon they began to near Bright Moon and Adora started to recognize the things around her. One final stretch of woods later, they arrived at the entrance to the long bridge leading to the front doors of the castle. Something was off, though. Bright Moon

seemed on high alert. Guards stood at every entrance and along the outskirts of the water.

“What's with all the guards?” Bow verbalized Adora's thoughts. Glimmer's face contorted and she teleported up to one of them. Adora couldn't hear what they were saying but Glimmer looked shocked. She teleported back and stared at Adora and Bow with wide eyes. “They captured a Horde Princess! She snuck into my room!”

“A Horde Princess? That's very oxymoronic. What do you mean ‘princess’?” Adora said but before anyone could reply, she and Catra locked eyes and spoke in unison.

“Scorpia.”

Both hadn't known she was a princess until recently and Adora had it confirmed when she saw her amongst all the different silhouettes Light Hope had shown her back in the beacon.

All four began to quickly make their way to the doors and ran to the makeshift dungeon that was hardly ever used.

The scorpion princess was sitting accompanied by a single guard. Catra addressed her first.

“Scorpia? What are you doing here?”

“Kitty!” She exclaimed, smiling despite being held in magic chains. “I came to see you!”

“Are you *insane?* ” Catra took a step closer to her.

“I mean, quite possibly.”

Bow stepped up beside Catra. “You nearly destroyed the Kingdom of Snows.” He jabbed his pointer finger at her.

“I know, right?”

“You stabbed me with your tail!” Glimmer announced.

“That I did.”

Scorpia didn't seem to have any reaction to the negative remarks being thrown at her. Adora didn't bother to join it. They all went back and forth at each other until footsteps were heard from the stairs behind them. It was Queen Angella.

“Glimmer, what did I tell you?” She said as soon as she saw her daughter among the group.

“This wasn't Catra, she doesn't know anything about it.”

“You did not disclose information of our whereabouts to this Horde Princess or any other person?” This was directed at Catra who stood at attention facing her.

“No, ma'am.” She said respectfully.

Ma'am? Respectfully? Who is this person and what has she done with my Catra?

The Queen stared at her for a few moments before turning to her Royal Guard. “Has she said anything?”

“No, Your Majesty.”

She sighed and Catra elbowed Adora. “Can we try to recruit her for the Princess Alliance?” She whispered.

“I don't know, it doesn't seem like she's listening to anyone.” Adora replied, slightly confused at why Catra's attitude had changed so quickly.

“She'll listen to me.” Catra said. “We were ‘best friends’.”

Best friends, huh?

“I think that's a good idea.” Glimmer jumped in to their conversation. “Mom, can Catra try and get Scorpia to join the

Rebellion?”

Queen Angella thought about it but agreed eventually. The single guard volunteered to watch over them as they spoke and Catra went to a room to talk privately with Scorpia.

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Catra

Catra was alone with Scorpia who leaned in and spoke just out of earshot of the nearby guard.

“Catra, I'm not actually contained. We can go back to the Fright Zone. The Super Pal Duo suffers without you.” Scorpia whispered.

“Scorpia, I can't. *One,* I'm banished, *two,* I-I don't want to go back.” This was something she'd never admit to Adora. After that dream about her mother and its message coming true: “There is somebody there, waiting for you,”; she almost wanted to follow the rest of her instructions. “Trust all princesses,” she had said. Did that include Scorpia? Was she supposed to recruit her to the Princess Alliance?

Scorpia frowned. “Okay fine, I'll just go then-

“No wait-”

“Please speak louder.” The guard said, noting the way they were whispering.

Catra sighed. “Why don't you join the Princess Alliance?” She said at a normal volume. “I'm sure you already know that the Horde manipulates people and, well, you're a princess, and the people here are nice. They'll be different from the past princesses.”

Scorpia pursed her lips and inhaled. “Well, I don't know, Catra.”

“Princesses really aren't so bad, you should know, *you're a princess* . They're all super nice, just like you are.” Catra

explained. “You'll fit in perfectly here. I do,” *which is kinda a lie,* “and I'm *not* a princess. You and Adora are, so it'll make no difference.”

Scorpia moved her eyes to the right, and then back at Catra again. She hesitated. “...Super Pal Duo reinforced?”

Catra smiled. “Hell yeah.” She said. “I'll go get them to let you out.”

The guard stepped up to her and put an arm up to stop her. “Whoa, whoa, whoa, not so fast. The Queen must talk to her first.”

“Alright, yeah.”

Catra rejoined the rest of the team while the Queen went into the room with Scorpia after being updated on what happened. Now all they could do was wait.

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<u>Entrapta</u>

Entrapta had found so many interesting information about the First Ones in her exploration of the beacon though none of it told her how to fix a broken runestone.

“Fright Zone Log, day 29. I'm still attempting to reinforce the Black Garnet so that I can get positive results. I retrieved a new data crystal that could potentially help me to do this. The crystal is in perfect condition.” She pressed a few buttons on her computer. “However, the information I've managed to extract is… useless!” Entrapta shaped her hair into a fist and hammered the table, causing several items to fall over. Emily jumped at the sudden loud noise.

“Sorry,” she continued speaking into her own recorder: “Everything on this crystal are bits of information that I already

know, and there's nothing on here relating to repairing a powered-down runestone!

"If I want to retry this experiment to prove my hypothesis correct, I'll have to search for a different runestone." She paused. "Why do I happen to be the only princess without her own runestone as a resource for magic?

"Hmm, it says here, the nearest runestone to the Fright Zone is… The Heart-Blossom. Plumeria." Entrapta jumped out of her seat and switched off her recorder. "C'mon Emily! We're off!"

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Scorpia

Scorpia refused to reveal the plans of the Horde. When the Queen asked about the weather disruption caused by the Horde, Scorpia lied and said it was merely a runestone malfunction, which was true. Kind of. It malfunctioned at the end…

Anyways, Scorpia had understood what Catra had said, and though she still had a soft spot for the Fright Zone, the first place that treated her like she was family, as a princess, she wanted to give the life she was originally supposed to have a chance.

Catra seemed to have mingled with the princess of Bright Moon and the archer, along with Adora, who seemed happier than ever to be with Catra again. Though Scorpia didn't know Catra as well when Adora was still a member of the Horde, the one thing anyone knew was that those two were inseparable. Now that she thought of it, Scorpia thought it strange that Catra didn't join Adora sooner.

Soon enough, Scorpia was let free with a warning to the others to keep an eye on her. There really wasn't any need. Scorpia had made peace with becoming a Rebellion force and living out as a princess. Plus she was able to stay with Catra. She couldn't help but feel like she'd forgotten something, though.

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Entrapta

Entrapta and Emily arrived at Plumeria only 20 minutes after departing the Fright Zone and the place was surprisingly empty. Everyone was out.

To be safe, she directed Emily to stay hidden away as she walked up to the giant tree housing the large pink runestone. The Heart-Blossom.

Entrapta giggled to herself and examined the bright stone closely, running a pigtail in the shape of a hand over it, the other half of her hair holding onto the recorder.

She switched the recording on and inhaled but stopped with her mouth open when she saw something in the reflection of the runestone. It was a statue made out of plants that were dotted with different colored flowers.

It was a statue of Entrapta.

She turned slowly and eyed the tall figure from head to toe. Taking a step closer she saw a pedestal inscribed with *"In Memory of Princess Entrapta of Dryll."*

In memory of…

They thought she was dead. They didn't leave her behind, they thought she had died.

Entrapta took a step back and stared at the statue with wide eyes. She could not take her eyes off it as she switched the recorder back on.

"Plumeria Log… Day 1, Hour 1… I have made… a terrible mistake…" A single tear ran down her face.

She molded her hair into a seat behind her and sat down, her sight never straying from the large figure. She had dropped the recorder and it laid on the grass beside her. It could have been seconds, minutes of staring when there was a voice from behind her.

“En-Entrapta..?”

Entrapta turned her head around, shock still frozen on her face and saw the flower princess of Plumeria. Perfuma. She was standing alone, both hands holding onto her hair. The two locked eyes for several seconds, tears streaming down both of their faces until Entrapta finally spoke. “...I'm sorry.”

Another few moments of silence passed and Perfuma took a step forward before speeding to a sprint to practically tackle Entrapta with a hug.

“You-you…”

“It was a misunderstanding.” Entrapta wrapped her arms and hair around the taller princess.

Before they had all went to rescue the Glimmer and Bow from the Fright Zone, Perfuma and Entrapta had spent some time together when Entrapta wasn't working. Sure, she was upset when she and the rest of the Princess Alliance ‘left her behind’, and she was fairly happy working at the Horde because of their powerful technology, but, if they didn't leave without her on purpose, Entrapta didn't want to do the same to them. She could hardly believe that she was about to steal the center of Perfuma's land and the source of all her powers.

Perfuma pulled away from Entrapta, her hands lingering on her shoulders. “How did you-? The door closed-? There was fire…”

“I'll explain everything, I just have to go find someone first.” Entrapta, herself noticing how different she acted around Perfuma; she didn't care as much about technology and her research when she was with her.

“But-”

“I'll be back!” She said, picking up her recorder as she jogged towards Emily who was still hidden in the woods. She petted her robot and instructed her to track Scorpia down. She had to at least find her before finding the rest of the princesses who thought she was gone.

“Woods Log, day 2. Emily and I are leaving the Fright Zone for good. We'll miss all the advancements in the technology but my friends are more important.”

Entrapta, after seeing how devastated Perfuma was at her ‘death’, knew that she needed to clear up the mess she'd made by staying with the Horde for nearly a month. Her first mission would be to find Scorpia to tell her she was leaving, and her final destination would be the Kingdom of Bright Moon to reunite with Bow, Adora, and Glimmer.

She began her trek through the woods, Emily guiding her by following the tracker Entrapta had secretly placed on Scorpia when they had first met.

“Edit to Log. We seem to be traveling in circles. I've seen this exact rock with an x carved into it at least twice. Fascinating. The tracking device must not be working in the shifting terrain of the Whispering Woods.” She updated her status to her frequent log. They didn't seem to be making a lot of progress as they moved forward. This might take a while.

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<u>Glimmer</u>

The Princess Scorpia was on their side now. She constantly tried to hug or get close to Catra who was *not* having it. Glimmer and Bow were walking ahead of the three previous members of the Horde on their way to give Scorpia her own room. The one Catra had declined was still open and ready for someone else to inhabit, minus the bed, which Catra had taken to hers and Adora's room.

Scorpia seemed a lot different than Catra or Adora however, so Glimmer wasn't sure what kind of room she'd want.

When they arrived at the room, Glimmer out on the best fake smile she could and turned around. “So, Scorpia, this can be your room.” Glimmer still didn't like Scorpia all that much but because she was able to forgive Catra, she should at least try to be nice until they get to know her more.

The scorpion princess brought her large claws up towards her face and rushed forward with a grin. “Oh, cool, this much space all to myself! I think I'll like this.” She exclaimed and stepped in, immediately trying to reorganize things.

“Uhm, I’ll leave you be.” Glimmer said and turned on her heel. “Adora, Bow, wanna come to my room for a bit?”

“What about me?” Catra demanded

“Can you stay with Scorpia?” Glimmer suggested and without waiting for a response, she grabbed Bow and Adora's arms and teleported the two into her room.

“Glimmer, are you okay?” Bow asked when they appeared in the bedroom.

Glimmer breathed out a long sigh. “I don't like Scorpia.” She replied, crossing her arms and making her way to the cushioned bench by her window to sit down.

“I never even met her.” Adora said. “I mean, I knew she was a Force Captain but I'd never really saw her or spoke to her. Then when I left she suddenly started working with Catra. She's kinda weird.”

“That's an understatement.” Glimmer sat with Adora standing before her. Bow took a seat next to her.

“Why don't we talk about something else? Oh! How about we try to explain the thing to Adora?”

“The thing? What thing?” Adora said suspiciously. Glimmer suddenly jumped up. “Yes! Great idea. Uhhhhh…”

“What are you guys doing?” Adora said, only to be shushed by Glimmer.

“Adora, it's time for me to attempt to teach you about love which you somehow don't know anything about!” Glimmer exclaimed, her arms stretched out with jazz hands.

“Oh, this, um, alright.” Adora agreed, though it almost sounded like a question. Glimmer guided her by the shoulders and sat her down on the bench.

“Bow, can you look up the official definition in the dictionary?”

“Do you have one?”

“Yeah…” Glimmer scanned the room with her eyes and spun around, not seeing any kind of book anywhere except for her diary. “No.”

“Why don’t you have a dictionary in your room?”

“Why *would* I have a dictionary in my room?” Glimmer retorted and grumbled before putting on a sweet facade. “Hold on, I’ll be right back.” She teleported to the castle library, somewhere she hadn’t been to in months and found a whole dictionary, flipping to a page where the word ‘love’ was defined. She pointed to it with her finger to save her spot on the page and teleported back to her bedroom where Bow and Adora still sat.

“Okay.” She exhaled. “Love: an intense feeling of deep affection. So-”

“It's basically when you really like someone.” Bow cut in.

Adora nodded slightly. “So like, I really like you guys, does that mean I... love you?”

“It could, yes! That's platonic love!” Glimmer explained.

Adora’s eyes widened in shock. “There's different types?”

“Yeah but-”

“So when you say I love Catra, well I do really like Catra so yeah, I guess I love her?”

“No, that's different.” Glimmer said.

“What do you mean?”

Glimmer groaned. “Why is this so difficult? I don't remember having a considerable amount trouble figuring this out when I was younger.” She looked to Bow for help.

“Okay, there’s actually eight different categories of love.” Adora looked surprised again but Bow continued. “There’s eros, agape, philia, mania, ludus, storge, pragma, and philautia, but to make things more simple,” Bow noticed Adora’s suffering and confusion, “we’ll just focus on eros, pragma, and philia, which can more easily be placed in two other categories: romantic and platonic.”

“Wait, hold on. Why do you know so much about this? You said you didn’t know how to explain stuff.” Glimmer interrupted.

“I really don’t.”

“Bullshit.” Bow gave Glimmer a look of disapproval for her language. “Sorry, but seriously, where did *you* learn this stuff?”

“I did a bunch of research when I was trying to figure out why the heck *I* didn’t like anyone.”

Adora made a look equivalent to several question marks used at once **(Adora: ????).**

“I'm aromantic so I don't feel romantic love but I love Glimmer and you, obviously, platonically.”

Adora shook her head. “Wait wait this doesn't make any sense. You just said that there's different types if love and now you can also choose whether you have it or not?” Her facial expression concluded that she didn’t understand a word either of them had said.

Glimmer attempted to explain again. “You don't *have* love- well- I guess- what I mean is, you feel love.”

“And it's not a choice, I was born like this.” Bow explained. Glimmer knew that several years in the past, shortly after Bow began his gender transition, he figured out that he was aromantic asexual, though it was easier to just say ‘ace’ when he was speaking.

“Okay, uh, what’s the difference between romantic and… the other one?” Adora asked, obviously trying to make any kind of sense in their explanations.

“Well, romantic is when- hold on a sec.” Glimmer flipped through the pages of the dictionary again, searching for the letter ‘R’. “Conducive to or characterized by the expression of love. Well that’s not helpful!”

Adora lowered her gaze and frowned. “Sorry I don’t know anything…” She said quietly.

“Nonono, you’re fine, I just really suck at this.” Glimmer exclaimed and sighed. “Well, I *can* explain platonic love. That’s just friendship. We all love each other platonically, I would assume. Romantic love goes way deeper than that. It’s like,” she wiggled her fingers, “intimate.”

Adora pursed her lips and shook her head slightly. Glimmer’s shoulders drooped and she sighed again. “Okay,” she exhaled, “we’ll come back to this.”

“Let’s go for a walk.” Bow suggested and placed a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder, who smiled.

“That sounds nice. Should we bring Catra and Scorpia?”

“Only if you want.” Adora replied.

“You know what, sure, I should probably get to know Scorpia a little more if she’s going to be a part of the Princess Alliance.”

The three departed Glimmer’s bedroom and began traveling down the hall to the room where Scorpia and Catra were.

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Scorpia

“Remember when we were on a boat together? That was the best day ever.” Scorpia was saying as she decorated a shelf with small toy figures she’d found lying around.

She heard Catra sigh from behind her when there was a knock on the door. “Hello?”

“It’s us, can we come in?” Glimmer’s voice said and Catra went to the door and opened it. She whispered something that sounded kind of like “help me” to the princess and her friends who entered the room and looked around at the progress Scorpia had made in renovating the room for herself.

She thought of what the last month would have been like if Catra hadn’t been expelled from the Horde. Ah, all the memories they’d’ve made. Former Force Captain Adora was about to say something when Scorpia suddenly gasped and jumped. “I just remember what I forgot!”

Adora was mid-breath with a finger up and lowered it, the four all presenting the same face of confusion. Scorpia laughed. “Of course! I left my friend at the Horde, can we go get her? She’s a princess too.”

“There’s *another* princess at the Horde? Why didn’t I know this?” Catra asked.

“Yeah, but she showed up after you left so you didn’t miss anything. She’s my closest friend since Catra was banished.” She explained casually to the group.

“Who is it?” Bow inquired.

“Well, it’s Entrapta, you guys left her behind so I hope it’s alright if I bring her back here-”

“Wait, Entrapta? Entrapta of Dryll?” Adora questioned, suddenly seeming tense. Scorpia sensed the same feeling in Glimmer and Bow, too.

“Uh, yeah? Unless there’s another Entrapta.”

“But… Entrapta’s *dead.* ” Glimmer said slowly.

“Nope,” Scorpia replied, “very much alive and well.”

All three were silent for a moment until there was another knock on the door. Bow opened it from behind him to see one of the Castle Guards standing outside. “Princesses, a Horde robot has been spotted in the Whispering Woods near castle Bright Moon. Does it belong to you, Princess Scorpia?” The group followed the guard outside to see a spherical robot pacing in the forest, nearly tripping over a root in the ground.

Another two princesses were outside as well, one shooting a magic net at the robot and the other clinging to her arm.

“Oh, that’s Emily!” Scorpia said, pointing at it. “Entrapta said she’d send her to find me if she found anything new.” Suddenly, the small frame of a person came running out from behind a tree, attempting to remove the glowing net. *Entrapta.* Why did she come? She wasn’t one to abandon her work for anything.

Scorpia turned to her left to see Adora, Glimmer, and Bow all paralyzed with disbelief as they watched the technology-loving princess cut the robot free. She was speaking into her recorder as per usual, loudly enough for Scorpia to hear.

“I think I’ve located Bright Moon. As soon as I arrived here, however, the tracker sensed that Scorpia was also in this location. Strange. What would she be doing here?

“Someone tossed a net at Emily, probably because she has the Horde symbol on her, note to self: remove that branding after you’ve found the princesses.”

Glimmer, who stood in between Adora and Bow grabbed each of their hands and disappeared with them reappearing several feet in front of Entrapta. Scorpia began to make her way to them as well.

“Entrapta?” Scorpia heard Glimmer say. “But… you… died.”

The three stood there not bothering to let go of each other’s hands as they continued to stare at Entrapta.

“You guys! Wonderful!” She said and raised her hair up in the shape of two arms and went in for a hug as Scorpia and Catra walked up beside them.

“But-” Adora started but didn’t finish as she sunk into the hug. Catra eyed the group distastefully.

“It was a horrible misunderstanding. I thought you guys simply left me behind, when you actually thought I was dead. I stayed at the Fright Zone for some time because of their technology until just today I went to Plumeria and realized my mistake.” Entrapta explained after pulling away.

Bow hadn’t said a word since Entrapta appeared in the woods. She explained how she had been protected from the fire by Emily who had opened and dragged her inside before the flames could touch her. Then she had climbed into the vents and hid there, waiting for someone to come back for her.

“But no one did. So when Scorpia found me, she and Hordak allowed me to continue my studies and experiment on the various technologies available in the Horde and with their runestone. I hypothesized that the runestone could be fiddled with to provide

explosive power and could potentially be used as a weapon so Scorpia, Emily, and I wired it up and-”

“Wait. Is that what caused it to snow in the Whispering Woods?”

Entrapta gasped and brought both hair and hands up to her face balled in fists out of excitement. “It snowed in the Whispering Woods? Fascinating! I knew there were climate issues all over the planet but that's amazing. And horrible. Something like that could cause the entirety of the woods to freeze over. Only very powerful magic could reverse the effects of that.”

“She-Ra'd be able to, I'm sure.” Glimmer said confidently.

“More importantly, you're not gonna be weaponizing anymore runestones, right? We can't risk something like that. It'd allow whole armies from the Horde to locate Bright Moon and attack.” Adora added and the smallest princess smiled and nodded.

“Oh, Scorpia! What are you doing here?” Entrapta said suddenly, turning towards her and Catra who stood to the left of the other three.

“I'm a rebel now.”

“Huh, cool.” Entrapta said, not questioning further. “I need to go back to Plumeria and talk to Perfuma, wanna come? I'm sure you guys see her all the time considering she's part of the Princess Alliance.”

Bow pursed his lips and finally spoke. “Actually… no. The Princess Alliance fell apart after you…”

There was a moment of silence before Adora spoke up. “We can rebuild it. Again. Now that we have Entrapta back, they'll understand that we are better together. We also have two new additions to the Princess Alliance to help out.”

Catra raised her hand and interrupted. “I'm not a princess though.”

Glimmer leaned toward her. “You're sure about that.”

Catra hesitated. “I- yes, of course! I am *not* a princess. Never.” She said harshly as her tail stiffened.

The group had managed to form a kind of circle, everyone facing each other. “So,” Adora said and placed her hand in the center of the circle, palm down, “whaddya say? Princess Alliance?” One by one, each person placed their hand on top of Adora’s, Catra being last, looking down and smiling at the ground.

“For Etheria!” Adora shouted, the group repeating and bringing their arms up in a cheer. This’d be interesting.

Chapter End Notes

> wassup so a lot happened in this chapter and i decided to add pertrapta as a side ship because they would be soooo cute,,, ahem the idea of entrapta finding out what happened was based on a super cool comic i saw on interwebs by @/ivorinee (on instagram idk about other social medias) so like go check that out. also i used information from 80s she ra about catra to kind of give her a back story and i think ill expand on the whole catras a princess thing or whatever anyways i promise there will be more catradora next chapter, this one was just me making all the things that i wish would happen happen soooo yeah
>
> ~A

She-Ra?

Chapter Notes

> hullo its been exactly three weeks so im still on schedule ¯_(ツ)_/¯ anyways i hope you enjoy this chapter - fore warning: theres a bit of angst because of an idea that i randomly had like 2 weeks ago so yeah

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Adora led the group through the forest as She-Ra, just because she felt more confident that way, determined to bring the team back together again. After this long a time with the Rebellion, Adora had practically memorized the routes through the Whispering Woods to get to different places. Plumeria was in the same direction as the Fright Zone and despite the magic if the woods moving things around, the path was generally the same.

They had passed the four specific trees that never seemed to change and Adora knew they were getting close. Catra was once again travelling along the tree branches above them while Bow, Glimmer, Scorpia, and Entrapta were following behind Adora on the ground. Instead of using her legs however, Entrapta was floating above the dirt and walking with her hair as her feet. Nothing out of the ordinary.

After about five more minutes, Adora saw the pink, flourishing kingdom peeking out from behind a giant tree root and the cart Adora had lifted upon their arrival the first time. But something wasn't right. Plumeria wasn't filled with laughter and joy as it was the last time. From where she was, Adora and the group could hear people screaming and metallic crashing and explosions. Catra had seen before any of them. “It's the Horde!” She called down from her perch on a branch high in a tree above them.

She jumped down and rejoined the crowd of princesses and Bow as they raced over to the kingdom. Sure enough, the Horde was back, but this time, they weren't simply poisoning their trees; they were attacking. Plumerians were fighting back, the same way they had before, but it didn't seem enough; the army sent this time was much larger and more powerful than the ones at the camp. Adora spotted Perfuma shooting a line of green vines and flowers at a group of soldiers trying to block her from getting to the Heart-Blossom. Behind them was another group-Adora could identify them as Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio-who were attempting to get past the tree's protective layer to get ahold of the runestone. They wanted to take it.

Perfuma shot a hole in the blockade and sent Adora's old team flying across the field, putting up a thick wall around the Heart-Blossom for extra protection. When she was done, she turned around and saw Adora and the others standing there trying to choose who to fight first.

One thing the Horde didn't know about a princess was that her power was infinitely powerful when she was in her own land. **(a/n: yes, I know this is probably inaccurate since Glimmer had a bunch of problems while she was at Bright Moon, but like if she wasn't cursed for the final battle, it would have been easier??? Just go with it)** They didn't have a chance. The rest of the community however, might need some help.

Glimmer and Bow had began to fight off troops around them with the help of the Plumerian people. Entrapta had gone over to Perfuma to help her out and Scorpia had started wrestling with another large Horde soldier. Adora could hear him muttering about traitors.

Adora had transformed back out of surprise and she and Catra were about to join them when they both saw something they thought they'd never see. Shadow Weaver, in the flesh, had showed up with the army of Horde soldiers; was leading them. Both froze in their spots, staring at the sorceress in awe and fear.

Just at that moment, Shadow Weaver noticed their presence, left alone whatever poor souls she was torturing and darted straight at them, the eyes in her mask thinning.

Catra and Adora jumped to either side to avoid her charging right into them and stood facing her back as she started to absorb all the light around her.

What? She can't do that, she never has before, Adora thought and began to raise her sword in the air. "For the Honor of-"

"No!" Shadow Weaver whipped around and shot a spear of darkness at the Sword of Protection knocking it out of Adora's hands and launching it towards the sorceress who enclosed it in a dark cloud.

"Upgraded your powers, huh?" Catra said, noticing the same thing that Adora did moments before. She pounced at Shadow Weaver, clawing at her mask and attempting to get through the sword's prison of shadow but it was too strong.

Adora couldn't do anything. She was *nothing* without the sword. Completely useless. She stood still and watched blankly as Shadow Weaver threw Catra across the field, her not moving after hitting the ground, and stayed still while her 'mother figure' floated over to her, trapping her in her own prison of blackness. All of the light was sucked out of her surroundings and Adora dropped to her knees. Everything happened so fast. She didn't even get a chance to help; all she did was stand there. They didn't even need She-Ra, she could leave again and never come back and they'd be fine.

Adora couldn't breathe. With the light, the air seemed to be disappearing too. She couldn't hear anything on the outside, the shadows were spinning like a storm around her and eventually fell to the ground, unable to move at all. She had completely given up. It was useless to fight back. A single tear escaped her left eye as she lay on the ground before losing all consciousness entirely.

.

Glimmer

Glimmer was fighting off several Horde soldiers with the help of Bow when she noticed something in her peripheral vision. Darkness. Something was just sucking the life out of everything somewhere on her right.

She took a chance and turned her head, only to be immediately thrown backwards. But she had seen. It was Shadow Weaver. Glimmer teleported towards her, and Adora and Catra who were standing near her, Catra fighting and Adora's sword missing.

In the split second that Glimmer had disappeared, Shadow Weaver had flung Catra into a tree and enclosed Adora in a giant tornado of pure shadow.

"Adora!" Glimmer attempted to teleport inside the prison but something was blocking her from doing so. Instead, she turned toward Shadow Weaver but before she could do anything, she disappeared along with Adora and her magic prison. From what Adora had told her, that was not something she was able to do.

Upon her exit, the Horde army retreated and left Plumeria alone. Glimmer's guess was that they had come to lure Bright Moon; to draw She-Ra to the heart of the battle and capture her for themselves. Yes, she was a powerful weapon that didn't make her any less than a person. Even calling her a weapon seemed too harsh.

Glimmer and Bow chased after them but they were already too far ahead. Adora was gone. Catra lay unconscious in the grass. Entrapta and Perfuma were hugging while Scorpia began to walk in Catra's direction. Glimmer grabbed Bow's arm and teleported over to them.

Catra lay sprawled out on the ground. One of her arms was bent in an unnatural direction and a trail of disturbed earth trailed at her feet. She must have hit the ground *hard.*

“Catra.” Glimmer tried, carefully shaking her. After a few more attempts, Catra's eyes snapped open and she sat up, nearly knocking her head with Glimmer who was leaning over her.

“Where's Ador- Ah!” She yelped, having put her weight on her broken arm. She drew is up and grabbed it with her other hand, her eyes desperately scanning the scene for Adora. But she wasn't there.

“Hey,” Scorpia said, “careful!”

Catra met Glimmer's eyes and asked the same question again. “Where's Adora?”

“She'll be fine, we'll go get her tomorrow-”

“Tomorrow?” Catra snapped. “Do you have any idea what Shadow Weaver could do before tomorrow?”

“I trust that she can keep herself safe until then. For now, we need to go back to Bright Moon. You're a mess.” Glimmer suggested and Catra jumped to her feet.

“Adora has been kidnapped by the person who will do anything to get her back on their side again. Do you *not* remember what she did last time?” Catra groaned and ran her right hand through her bangs. “This is all my fault.” She said matter-of-factly. “Why does this keep *happening* ?”

“Well, technically, the first time, you, uh, kidnapped us…” Bow interjected.

“ *Shut up!* ” Catra kicked at him but he dodged. Then the feline girl sighed and started walking in the direction of Bright Moon, still holding onto her injured arm.

Glimmer, Bow, and Scorpia stood still for a moment.

“Well? Come on, let's *go* .” Catra said without turning around and the rest of the group, minus Entrapta and Perfuma, who seemed

to have disappeared together, began making their way back to the kingdom.

Time Skip

Bright Moon was right around the bend and Catra hadn't spoken another word the whole trip. She must have been devastated; she'd lost her best friend (though Glimmer hoped they'd be more than that) for the second time within three months.

They arrived and Glimmer took Catra to her mom to heal her arm and since it was late, she just went to bed, Bow following and going to sleep as well.

Adora would fend for herself until the next morning, Glimmer was sure of it. *Everything will be fine,* was the last thing that crossed her mind before she drifted off to sleep

.

Catra

Tomorrow. No way.

Catra was *not* waiting another minute for Shadow Weaver to have Adora in her grasps. Had Glimmer forgotten how quickly Shadow Weaver had done something to Adora among capturing her? She would have lost her memory if Glimmer hadn’t managed to escape.

Catra was sent to her room after the Queen had somehow fixed her broken arm. She was immortal, of course she could mend broken things relating to someone’s body. She walked back to her room and sat on her bed, pondering what she was going to do and finally decided that she needed to rescue Adora. Now.

She hopped out the window and jumped among the trees, a vantage point where she could see her destination, any moving landscapes wouldn’t stop her. It must have been around eleven at night and Adora had been at the Fright Zone since around six.

Catra's gut had told her that something would go wrong if she didn't leave right then and there.

Because of Catra's familiarity with the Horde, she was able to sneak in without any problems and no one to notice her presence. She figured the first place to look for Adora would be the Black Garnet Chamber since Shadow Weaver never seemed to leave that place. Catra stayed close to the high ceilings and moved along the various bars and pipes and pillars that were hidden in the shadows. It was night so everybody had been sent to their barracks and were asleep, or close to it. Fright Zone curfew for cadets was 10:30pm, no exceptions. The only people out and about were the guards and active soldiers.

Everything was going according to plan and Catra had made it to the chamber without being caught. Sure enough, Adora was in the same place she was last time, unconscious on the iron table. Shadow Weaver, however, wasn't there, from what Catra could see from outside the room.

She quietly maneuvered to peek into the chamber and there was still no sight of Shadow Weaver. The cold aura that came with her presence was absent too. The coast was clear.

She walked in over to Adora, determined to get her out of there as soon as possible when she suddenly felt a chill down her spine, her tail stiffening as she spun around. Shadow Weaver had entered.

"Foolish of you to come here alone." Her voice boomed as she floated in, shadows and sparks of red following her trail. "So nice to have you back." She said menacingly.

"Who says I'm alone?" Catra lied, hoping to buy some more time but to no success. Shadow Weaver ignored her question and started towards the Black Garnet upon seeing Adora's restraints almost undone. She aimed a shard of shadow at Catra and filled the room up with it, shattering the screens on the wall as it snaked up to the ceiling. Catra jumped out of the way, barely

missing the beam with her feet. Shadow Weaver continued forward until reaching the garnet.

"You will not take what is mine!" She exclaimed, placing her hands on the stone and drawing strength from it. A moment passed and she was shot back, creating a ball of darkness crackling with red lightning around her. She sucked the energy into one blast and sent it throughout the sanctum, Adora's body being frozen in place with Shadow Weaver's paralyzing power. Another blast was shot at Catra again, a prison of shadow attempting to grab her but Catra dodged.

"Adora isn't yours!" Catra exclaimed. "Adora doesn't belong to anyone!" She continued leaping among pipes and pillars, avoiding Shadow Weaver's continuous attacks.

Shadow Weaver ignored her statement. "That's right, run away! It's the only thing you've ever been good at!" Catra jumped and hid behind a pillar which was destroyed by a beam of lightning a second later. Catra dodged a falling heap of metal and ended up in the corner of the room. She spotted Adora's sword leaning against a crate and grabbed it, raising it with her left arm. "For the Honor of Grayskull?" She tried. When nothing happened, Shadow Weaver sent another strike in her direction, causing her to jump out of the way, dropping the sword in the process. "Eh, worth a shot."

Shadow Weaver leaned close to the ground, concentrating on her aim. "You've always been a disappointment. You've learned nothing from me!" She yelled. She ran lines of electricity through the floor towards Catra who leaped onto a pipe, then overtop the crackling energy. She *had* this. All her life she was getting ready for this moment.

"Oh, no. I've learned *everything* from you." She said as she landed, immediately jumping out of the way of another attempt of containing her with a shadowy grasp. Continuing to dodge each attack, she explained her views. "How to predict when you strike, how to dodge, *how to resist,* " she hid behind the control monitor.

“You thought you were punishing me all these years? Wrong.” Catra climbed up the side of the Black Garnet with superb agility, Shadow Weaver had lost sight of her, looking around until spotting her squatting atop the runestone.

“You were training me for this day!” Catra hopped down towards Shadow Weaver’s vulnerable position, claws out, preparing to strike. The sorceress was helpless as Catra ripped at her mask, destroying the stone shining in her mask, which split down the middle.

“Nooo!” She cried out as the shadows overwhelming the space around her receded down the walls, filling the chamber with the glowing red light of the Black Garnet again.

“No… Come back. Come back to me, come back to me…” She tried to gather the broken pieces of the stone before grunting and collapsing.

Shadow Weaver lay limp on the floor. Catra hadn’t just destroyed her link to the Black Garnet, she must have destroyed the very thing that was keeping her alive; some sort of life support. She wasn’t dead, but she’d be unable to do much of anything for the next while.

Her powers were definitely more powerful, that was for sure. Lord Hordak must have done something to increase the abilities of the Black Garnet, though it seemed weakened. What would’ve happened if she had it to its full potential?

Catra left her and jogged over to Adora, rushing to get her free.

They had to get Adora back to Bright Moon ASAP so they could consider offensive and defensive options against the Horde who was getting more powerful by the minute. What was Hordak doing?

Adora hadn't opened her eyes once during the entirety of Catra and Shadow Weaver's fight.

Is she…? No.

Catra was desperately trying to get Adora to wake up. She had to be alright, she *had* to.

The unconscious girl stirred a bit as Catra finished unbinding her from the leaning table she had been strapped to. Catra stood up as fast as lightning. “Adora? Adora!”

Adora opened her eyes slowly, confusion showing until her gaze softened at the sight of Catra. She looked around, seeing the Black Garnet and Shadow Weaver’s limp body lying on the ground next to it and went back to confusion again. “Catra? What’s going on?” She asked and sat up.

“Oh, thank God you’re okay.” Catra breathed out. “We need to go, *now* .”

“What, why?”

“I’m not supposed to be here.”

Adora raised a questioning eyebrow.

“Glimmer wanted to wait till tomorrow to get you but I had a gut feeling that something bad was happening so I-”

“Glimmer? Who’s Glimmer?” Adora said and Catra’s heart dropped to her stomach, her face paling.

“Glimmer? Bow? Entrapta?” Catra tried to knock some sense into her, but none of the names seemed to ring any bells.

“No no no no *no!* ” Catra anxiously let out. “This is *bad* .”

Adora swung her legs over the side of the table and stood up. “What? What’s happening?”

Catra stepped up to her, concerned eyes looking into confused ones. “You remember me, right?”

“What- yeah, of course. What is going on here?”

Suddenly there was a crash and yelling heard in the hallway behind them. Footsteps running toward them.They knew Catra was here.

“I’ll explain everything, later, but we need to get out of here! *Right now!* ” Adora still didn’t know what the deal was but Catra grabbed her hand tightly and started dragging her to an exit. Before they reached it however, she spotted the Sword of Protection lying on the floor in the corner the Black Garnet chamber, glowing blue in contrast to the natural dim red of the room. Catra ran and grabbed that too.

“What’s that?” Adora said, presumably referring to the sword in Catra’s other hand.

“No time, c’mon!” She started running faster, still gripping Adora’s hand until they reached the exit of the Fright Zone that led straight into the Whispering Woods. They had barely made it past some Horde soldiers who had attempted to stop them as they charged through. Catra didn’t let them. They stepped outside and Adora spoke again.

“Where are we going? Catra, what did you do?"

Catra ignored her and started towards the forest. “The woods? We can’t go in there!” Adora argued. Catra continued pulling her along. “Yes we can, now stop talking and let’s *go* !” Catra responded, Adora shutting up for the next few minutes of sprinting through the dark, mysterious forest. Catra’s cat senses felt they had gotten far enough and were close but not too close to Bright Moon. She examined her surroundings and sufficed that the coast was clear, sitting on a rock and gesturing Adora to sit on another near her.

Adora took a seat and caught her breath before voicing her concerns again. “What is going on, Catra? And, why aren't you wearing your mask?”

Catra ignored her question and asked her own. “What’s the last thing you remember?” She demanded. “Have you been promoted to Force Captain yet?”

Adora chuckled and looked down at her hands on her lap. “I *wish* .”

“No, you-” she sighed, “we never went to the woods? You never saw this?” Catra raised the sword in her right hand.

“What are you talking about?” Adora went and sat beside Catra who was digging her claws into her palm. She turned her head up to Adora.

“This has to be a joke. Tell me you're joking.” Catra pleaded. Adora's face remained blank.

Catra let out a soft whimper and buried her head in her arms.

“Catra, are you okay?”

“I'm sorry, I was too late.” Catra said to no one in particular- Adora wouldn't know what she was talking about- without lifting her head from between her knees. Adora scooted closer and wrapped an arm around her. Classic Adora, though it was the Adora that hadn't experienced Catra's evil side; hadn't defected from the Horde; hadn't associated and become friends with the Princesses of Etheria. It wasn't the Adora that Catra had to get used to, it was just as it was before. It was almost nice. What if it could stay that way?

“Look, I don't know what's going on with you, but we'll get through it. We look out for each other.” Catra's eyes stung. This wasn't right, Adora had broken that promise long ago, she couldn't result back to it now. She needed to find a way for her to regain her memories before going back to Bright Moon. There had to be a way, there *had* to.

Catra lifted her head up, looking into Adora's eyes. “You don't understand,” she said, something happened to you. Something

not good, and… it's my fault.”

Adora put a hand on Catra's arm. “Nothing happened, nothing is your fault.” She put her other hand over her heart. “I'm fine, I promise.”

There it was again, *promise* . Promises that were made to be broken. Catra inhaled. “No, Adora-”

“Catra! Adora!” Glimmer's voice sounded from behind them. Catra stiffened, the color draining from her face. She tried to get Adora away from there but she had already jumped to her feet at the sight of Glimmer and Bow who were jogging up to them.

“Princess!” She shouted, about to lunge at Glimmer but Catra held her from behind to hold her back. The two Bright Moon-er’s smiles turned into frowns. Adora turned her head to her left to address Catra.

“Catra, what are you-?”

“Adora, let me explain, just *don't* attack her.” Catra insisted, Adora still struggling to get out of her grasp.

“Why *not?* ”

Catra hugged her tighter and pressed her head against her upper back leaning into her. “ *Just stop!* ” Her voice almost broke. She had failed to bring Adora back unharmed to yet another place she had begun calling home. She failed her new friends who she had started to trust, them supposedly trusting her back.

Adora had stopped trying to escape Catra's arms and relaxed finally upon Catra's urges to stop. She didn't bother to let go until Bow spoke up.

“Adora?”

Adora stepped forward, Catra's hand moving to grab her wrist before she got *too* upset.

“Who are you? How do you know my name?” She demanded. Both Bow and Glimmer looked at Catra whose eyes had filled with tears.

She looked down at the dark forest floor. “I'm sorry, this is all my fault.” She shook her head and grabbed her tail with both hands.

Adora looked back at Catra, then at Bow and Glimmer again. “Can someone *please* tell me what the *hell* is happening?!” She shouted up at the canopy and the sky.

Catra sighed and brought her eyes back to Glimmer and Bow. “I think… it’s better if you leave for a bit, I have to… talk to her.” With the last word she averted her gaze again. Bow and Glimmer looked at each other and silently agreed to walk away. Catra offered the Sword of Protection to Glimmer who took it and followed Bow through the dark forest.

Catra had to explain everything that happened the last few months as if she were writing a story. It’d probably make up about 13 episodes of an animated tv show. Of course Catra didn’t know everything to the exact that happened while she was with her new friends since Catra was, well, not there and she’d have to wait for Adora to trust the princesses again before learning everything. What Catra knew would have to make do for now.

She sat Adora down on the same set of rocks as earlier and began talking. She was surprisingly eager to listen and wasn’t as shocked at some of the details as Catra thought she’d be. This would take a while.

.

<u>Bow</u>

What happened to Adora? Glimmer had told Bow what almost happened the last time they were at the Fright Zone; did that actually happen? For real? This had to be a joke, but, the look Catra had given them… it was sincere.

Glimmer had collapsed on a tree root after they had gone about a kilometer away from Catra and Adora and dropped her head in her hands.

“This is just a prank… they're just, *really* , good at acting,” Glimmer breathed out. “Yeah, that's it.”

Bow silently stepped up and stood beside her. “This is… this is what almost happened last time, right?”

“No, what did I just say? It's a *joke! Obviously…* ” Glimmer's voice began to break. Bow placed a hand on his best friend's shoulder.

“Everything'll be alright. It's Adora, she could never forget us.”

“Well clearly, she has!” Glimmer shouted, then looked down at her hands, shaking her head. “Sorry.”

The two stayed silent as they stood up and walked home.

Time Skip

Bow needed his sleep, but he could not stop worrying about Adora; and Glimmer. Glimmer had gotten closer to Adora than Bow, (which seemed impossible because they were already such good friends) and she seemed to be taking this way worse than Bow was. He was trying to stay positive and optimistic about the whole situation, considering every option that could possibly end in a good way. Glimmer on the other hand was the complete opposite. She was extremely pessimistic, possibly because she was there the first time that Adora was almost brainwashed by Shadow Weaver. She felt guilty despite the fact that there was no way they’d’ve reached her in time if they had left immediately.

Glimmer was grieving on her bed, her face smashed into her pillow while Bow lay on her cushioned bench, staring at the beautiful sunrise outside the window, thinking on the bright side of everything that happened. For example, Catra and Adora seemed closer than ever again, neither of them on the Horde’s side of the war anymore (hopefully, if Catra explained everything

well enough to knock some sense into Adora). It seemed a little selfish, thinking about their relationship when all this was going on but Bow was a positive person, his brain was accustomed to thinking of anything that could bring the light out of any dark situation.

Gazing at the sky was mesmerizing, and Bow nearly fell asleep until he heard a knock on the door. He heard Glimmer sit up with a start, immediately teleporting over to the door to open it. “Adora?” She asked hopefully as she swung the doors open, seeing an awestruck Adora examining the details of the castle around her standing behind Catra who was holding her hand to prevent her from going anywhere. Upon seeing Glimmer open the door, Adora hid behind Catra, seeming almost… scared.

Bow stepped up beside Glimmer, seeing her eyes full of hope, silently asking Catra if anything had changed. The cat-like teen only shook her head and Glimmer’s face drooped. “But, uh, she wants to see the sword. I told her about She-Ra and she’s curious.” Catra explained. Then she dropped her voice to a whisper, as for Adora not to hear. “I’m not sure if it’s the best idea though considering she’s in a castle full of princesses whom she ‘hates’ and-”

Glimmer had teleported away and back within a second, beholding the sword for Catra to take. “Did you listen to a word I just said?” Catra asked, annoyed.

“Yes,” Glimmer said, “but the first time she touched the sword, it gave her images of She-Ra and what not. Maybe it'll do it again.” She leaned in close to Catra's face and menacingly looked into her eyes. “I. Want. Adora. Back.” She said, as if it were Catra's job alone to fix her.

She offered the sword to Catra again who took it in her left hand and beckoned Adora to enter the room. Said girl was still looking around at everything, occasionally evil-eyeing Glimmer, then looking away as soon as Bow or Glimmer noticed.

Catra still looked hesitant to let Adora have her sword and stalled. She brought Adora back to the present and introduced Glimmer and Bow emphasizing that they were friends and reminding her that the things the Horde had taught her were lies. Adora nodded but didn't say anything.

Bow made sure to stay silent. He didn't want any kind of conflict to occur before Adora could remember again.

After introductions, Catra attempted to have Adora to be independent; not hiding behind her all the time. Adora tried to fight back like a child who didn't want to go somewhere. It was strange. Adora seemed very mature when she met he and Glimmer the first time so why was she acting like this now? Maybe it was Catra. Adora always seemed to act different around Catra and vice versa. They were either teasing or complimenting each other, it was as if they needed each other to function… human. Bow remembered the story Glimmer had told him about the time when Adora had made a chart and a map as if she were about to go to war and studied before Princess Prom. Her Fright Zone instincts seemed much less powerful when she was around Catra.

Eventually, Catra gave up and turned to face Adora. "Are you ready to see the sword?"

Adora bit her lip. "Well, I still think you just made it up but… I guess? This feels like a really elaborate prank- are you pranking me?"

Catra groaned and rolled her eyes. She reached the hand holding the sword out towards Adora.

"Just take it."

.

<u>Adora</u>

Adora had no idea what was going on. Catra had said something about the sword that could turn her into a warrior princess. It

sounded like the fakest thing in the world. She'd also said that princesses weren't actually “a dangerous threat to everyone on Etheria”, nor were they “violent instigators who don’t know how to control their powers”. That they were… nice.

She'd explained how Adora had left the Horde willingly and never came back except once to save her “friend”, Glimmer. How she nearly got her memory wiped by Shadow Weaver… and, how she *actually* got her memory wiped by Shadow Weaver.

She told her about the beacon they'd gotten trapped in together and how Adora had convinced Catra to join *her* side, *The Rebellion* .

It was very hard to believe, and, Adora *didn't* fully believe it, but she wanted to look at the sword that could supposedly transform her into this *She-Ra* . She could only imagine what it'd be like if Catra was telling the truth, but it all sounded like the plot of some kids’ cartoon.

Catra had offered the sword to her, but even though Adora didn't believe anything, she was hesitant to take it. What if something *did* happen?

Ridiculous, Adora, it's just a sword.

She reached out and grabbed it but as soon as she did, a bright light blinded her and things started appearing in her vision; this Glimmer person trying to wrestle the sword away from her, a crystal room with an image of a girl with a sword, and a flash of golden hair blowing in the wind.

Not even a second later, Adora let go of the sword's handle and fell back away from it, surprised.

“What did you see?” The male one, Bow, asked.

Adora could hardly form words. “I-I saw you,” she gestured toward the small princess, Glimmer, “and uh, a girl-”

“With glowing blonde hair and a sword?” Glimmer interrupted. Adora nodded, still speechless. What Catra said was… *true* .

“That's She-Ra!” Glimmer exclaimed.

“Wait, you saw Glimmer?” Bow asked. Adora nodded again. “Do you know what this means?”

Everyone stared at him with blank faces, clearly not knowing the answer to his question. He sighed.

“It *means* that the sword is returning Adora's memories.” He explained, no one seeming to understand still. “Glimmer isn't a part of She-Ra, if you saw her- what was she doing?”

“She was trying to take this sword from me.” Adora answered quietly, still somewhat intimidated by this group of people who were supposedly her friends. Bow snapped his fingers and stood up straight. “That's a memory!” He extended his arms out to his sides.

Glimmer finally understood and smiled, snatching the sword from Catra who was still holding it. “Touch it again!” She jabbed the sword's handle toward Adora who flinched. She timidly reached her hand out and grabbed onto it. Nothing happened this time.

Adora turned the sword in her hand and examined it without saying a word. It was a pretty weapon; bright blue with circles and lines running along it. The golden hilt held a small glowing stone in it radiating some sort of power. Everything seemed slightly familiar but Adora just could not put her finger on it.

“Well?” Catra said after a few seconds, bringing Adora out of her silent admiration. She looked up and blinked. “What?”

“Anything?”

Adora shook her head. “I-I don't remember anything but, it's just- everything seems familiar somehow.”

“That's gotta be something, right?” Catra asked Glimmer and Bow.

“Maybe, but that's exactly what she said the first time we met. It could just be the same thing as before.” Glimmer thought aloud.

“Well, at least she's acting a little more like herself.” Bow said. He always seemed to find the good things in whatever was going on. Note taken. And he was right. As soon as she got ahold of that sword the second time, she felt a sudden rush of peace and calmness wash over her, like she didn't need to fear the princesses or anything and they didn't need to fear her. Adora trusted Catra and felt some sort of trust in the two rebels despite only meeting them now- or, not really- she'd met them before, just forgot. She finally believed that her memory had been tinkered with and *wanted* to have everything back; she just *knew* she'd be happier with it.

“Now,” Glimmer interrupted Adora's thoughts, “can you try something else?”

Adora looked up at her, welcoming whatever she was about to ask her of. “Can you stand up and say, ‘for the Honor of Grayskull’?”

“Glimmer, she's gonna freak out again-”

“I know but, I just wanna see something.” Glimmer cut Bow off. Adora was confused but agreed. She slowly stood up and reluctantly held the sword out in front of her with both hands.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!”

.

(Random Narration brought to you by me)

Meanwhile, at the Fright Zone

Shadow Weaver had awakened still very weak from her tragic loss to Catra. Hordak had been angry that, once again, they’d lost Adora, for like, the fourth time. Shadow Weaver had informed him

that she had been successful in her memory wipe of Adora so they wouldn't have to worry about She-Ra for the time being as she had to relearn everything she had experienced since before she ran away. She also considered the fact that she would probably never be the same because she never *actually* experienced anything personally, not that she could remember.

What they didn't know was that the sword would make whatever happened in the future different than they anticipated. While they were planning to have more time than they actually had, the Best Friend Squad plus Catra were making some serious breakthroughs concerning Adora's memory…

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Glimmer

Adora was transforming! Glimmer would have loved to see some sort of 26 second transformation sequence with some awesome music at this astonishing moment.

A flash of light later, She-Ra stood in her place. "Glimmer? Bow? What's going on?"

"Adora?" All three of the others said simultaneously. "Do you remember?" Glimmer added.

"Remember what? How did I get here? Last thing I remember was entering Plumeria with you guys, plus Scorpia and Entrapta." She looked around, scanning the room for the other two mentioned but they were not there.

"Are you *kidding me* ?!" Glimmer shouted and stamped her foot on the floor. "So Adora doesn't remember She-Ra and She-Ra doesn't remember Adora. *Great* ."

"What's happening?" She-Ra said. She was still Adora but not the Adora from the last day or two. It only made sense for her memory to be messed up too; Glimmer knew that Adora and She-Ra were almost different people (but like, not really) so she had

thought maybe they'd be able to have She-Ra bring Adora back to normal but if she didn't know anything that happened, she wouldn't be able to.

"What do you mean?" Adora asked. "I *am* Adora."

"Oh, really? Transform back."

She-Ra shrugged and she shrunk back to Adora who's eyes were wide as she stumbled backward. "Whoa, was I just possessed?"

"Are you back? How's your brain feeling?" Catra asked Adora who still had a shocked look frozen on her face.

"I know I remembered, but I don't remember remembering. Does that make sense?" She added the last question quietly as if she were talking to herself.

Super great. Now she's gone mad. Glimmer was starting to get frustrated. This wasn't their Adora and they all needed to get some shut-eye. She sighed.

"Okay, how about we all get some sleep. Maybe you'll feel better after that? We all just basically missed two nights of sleep." Glimmer suggested and everyone seemed to agree. Catra nodded and grabbed Adora's hand, leading her in the direction of their room and Bow went to find a place to sleep himself.

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<u>Catra</u>

Catra walked with Adora to their room and sleepily introduced her to her bed. Adora seemed awfully tired herself and fell asleep almost immediately.

Catra climbed into the bed and instead of sleeping on the foot, she crawled up right next to Adora's head and curled up there. She did not want to lose sight of Adora ever again.

Chapter End Notes

so i had this idea..... and i stuck with it,, like it gives me an actual plot and i cant write romance without a plot so here *throws this*. anyways, adora will be back to normal soon i promise. sorry again that this came out so late, i didnt have a computer for like a week and then i was dealing with some other shit along with a tON of hw so yeah. enjoy^-^

~A

Secrets

Chapter Notes

> Hi!!!! This came out really late!!!! I'm sorry!!!! This is a slightly shorter chapter but I wanted to post it before season 2 came out - y'all, I'm so excited, I've already had 3 different dreams about me watching it - but anyway!!!! Enjoy this:)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer

"WAKE UP SLEEPYHEADS!"

Both Adora and Catra bolted upright, Catra's eyes rolling when she saw Glimmer and Adora looking panicked. She jumped out of the bed with her fists up. "Where am I? What's happening?"

"Whoa whoa whoa!" Catra hopped up beside her and grabbed her arms. "Remember…"

Adora's eyes softened and she looked to Catra. "That… wasn't a dream?"

"Nope."

Glimmer had creeped into Adora's room while the two were still sleeping, cuddled together like a married couple and she had momentarily forgotten the events of the past few days and wanted to tease her like she always did, despite the fact she never understood any of it.

At her reaction, everything came crashing down again. Glimmer took a step back in surprise and drew her arms up to her chest as Catra calmed Adora down.

"Sorry." Adora said quietly after a moment.

“It's okay.” Glimmer exhaled. “Everything is just *fine.* ” She forced out and both Adora and Catra frowned.

“Imma get Bow.” She said finally, pointing her thumb behind her before walking off. She didn't feel like using teleportation so she just sluggishly moved through the hallways until running into Bow, literally; she hadn't been paying attention and the taller boy crashed into her.

“Oh, Bow!” Glimmer snapped back into reality. “I was just looking for you.” She said. “Sorry, I wasn't really paying attention.”

“It's all good, heh, neither was I. Is it because of Adora?”

“Probably, but, on the bright side, we still have She-Ra.” She grinned and grabbed onto Bow's arm and transported back to Adora's bedroom.

“Adora!” Glimmer explained upon her arrival and Adora flinched at the sudden noise. “Hi, could we possibly have She-Ra for a bit?”

Adora shrugged. “Why not?”

Bow walked over to the sword that was laying on the floor by the dresser and picked it up, offering it to Adora. She looked hesitant but reached out for it. As soon as her hand made contact, another blinding light appeared for several seconds before subsiding to show another shocked Adora.

Glimmer gasped. “Did you see something?” She asked excitedly. Adora nodded.

“What was it this time?” Bow asked, voicing Glimmer's exact question. Adora stayed silent for a few moments before answering.

“I saw myself, surrendering… to the enemy.”

“We're not the enemy though!” Glimmer interjected.

“Right,” Adora replied, “and… Madame Razz.”

“Who?” Catra asked.

“I met her after… escaping everyone who thought I was the enemy at Bright Moon.” Adora continued. “And… Perfuma! I saw Perfuma, and Plumeria…” She trailed off, but no one else spoke, listening intently in hope of more memories returning.

“Oh my God, the Horde really did all that?” She resumed. “I get it now, I get all of it.”

“You remember everything?” Catra asked hopefully.

“Not quite. There's still a lot I don't have but I definitely understand why I did all this, it's really been bugging me, but now I get it.”

Glimmer chuckled. “Well, that's great!” She exclaimed. “Is there anything else?”

“...No.” Adora replied.

“That’s fine! It’s so fine!” Bow reassured, then pursed his lips in thought. “Maybe, your memories will all be returned every time you touch the sword but there needs to be time in between them.”

“That’s it! That’s got to be it!” Glimmer beamed. “Welcome back, Adora.”

A smile tugged the edges of the blonde’s mouth. “Do you still want Princess me?”

“Uh, sure.” Glimmer responded and Adora raised the sword and said the usual phrase.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!”

A flash of light later, She-Ra stood in her place. “What the heck is happening? How long has it been?” was the first thing she said.

“Great, She-Ra’s still broken.” Catra murmured.

“Hey, what’s that supposed to mean?” She asked, defensive, but playful.

“Okay, so,” **(a/n: at the end of last night’s party (sorry i saw bmc last week so I had to))** Glimmer continued on to explain to She-Ra everything that had happened with Adora. She understood why her brain was all messed up and absolutely wanted to help fix it.

“Oh, what if I just stay as She-Ra, forever?” Adora suggested after discussing possible solutions to their problems.

“Please don’t.” Catra said quietly and Glimmer inhaled. “Yeah, I’m not sure if that’s the best idea.” She added.

“Why not?”

“I mean, sure, She-Ra’s cool and all, but I’d prefer Adora.” Catra said and Glimmer sniggered slightly. “And what if you… y’know, change.”

“She’s right,” Bow said, “sometimes, you don’t seem like the same person when you’re transformed. But! Who knows more about Adora than you do, Adora? Why don’t you write down a bunch of the things you don’t remember so that when you transform back, you can read it all?”

“I guess I could give that a shot.” Adora answered and Glimmer teleported to her room momentarily to grab one of her notebooks. When she came back, she handed She-Ra the book and a pen and she sat down on her bed, staring at it with everyone crowding around her.

“Start with why you left the Horde in the first place.” Glimmer suggested.

“No, start with being promoted to Force Captain because Adora you doesn’t seem to remember that.” Catra interrupted and Adora nodded, putting the pen to the right side of the page and began to write.

Wait.

The right side of the page?

Glimmer examined what she was writing to see something very wrong with it. “Whoa whoa whoa, stop. You’re not writing english.”

“I’m not?” She raised her hand to see.

“That’s… first ones.” Bow observed.

“What? No way.” Adora said but he was right. The words Adora was writing were simply lines and shapes organized in a specific way that none of them could read.

She crossed it out and restarted, only to write the exact same thing. “What?!” She exclaimed and groaned, starting again. The same illegible characters continued to emerge on the paper.

“What the heck!” Adora threw the pen down onto the bed. “I can't write english. Like, I *physically* can't. That's so… *dumb!* ” She sighed and dropped her head into her hands.

“Uh, Adora could read first ones before she even knew anything about She-Ra so… just keep going?” Glimmer tried.

“You mean, *I* could read it. I'm still Adora, and I remember that.”

“Right, sorry.”

Adora picked the pen up again and started writing. Since no one else could understand, they just watched silently. Lines, circles, squares, random squiggles; how could anyone learn to comprehend that? The only thing heard was the pen on paper and

the breathing of the four teens. It wasn't too surprising that they all jumped when the door to Adora and Catra's bedroom burst open.

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Catra

Catra was glad Adora hadn’t remembered anything about what she had done to her yet. Of course she wanted her back to normal but she didn’t want to see that look of betrayal on her face again. She wasn’t ready. Everything had gone back to almost normal when Catra had joined the Rebellion and she hadn’t had to worry about all that stuff. Now, whenever Adora remembers that experience before all the redeeming ones, it might just tear her apart. She needed ample time to prepare for that.

Catra was still learning new things about Adora every day. Finding out that she was fluent in an ancient language was one of those. Trapped in the ruins with her was the first indication of this; she said something in said language to open a door. She said it was a long story but never actually explained it. One day she'd have to.

Quietly watching her best friend for as long as she could remember sitting in a tall, strong, warrior princess’s form, writing in a strange indecipherable manner was strange but she had started to get used to things like this. Nearly hypnotized by the flowing of Adora's pen across the notebook page, she was startled out of her skin at the sudden noise of the door opening.

“Hey guys!”

It was Scorpia. She had been in her room this whole time, a day and a half straight; probably hadn't even gone out to eat. From the time they had spent together, it didn't seem like Scorpia ate a lot and it was surprising to see her eat so much at the Princess Ball.

Catra gathered herself and raised an eyebrow at Scorpia who just smiled and got ready to speak again.

“I have an idea!” She exclaimed. “It's good, I think, or not, I'm not sure. It's probably not, knowing me, my ideas aren't always the greatest and-”

“Spit it out!” Catra interrupted, not wanting to deal with Scorpia's babbling that always seemed to escape every time she spoke.

“Right! Okay, what it I, get this, *betray you all!* ”

Adora and Bow glanced at each other and Glimmer made a quizzical look. “Uhhh…”

“I won't actually of course, I'll just tell them that.”

“Tell who?” Bow asked.

“The Horde, obviously.” She raised her chin. “I'll go back to the Fright Zone, say that I betrayed all of you, and tell them false stuff!”

“...so you can get inside information from the Horde! That's brilliant, Scorpia!” Catra said, standing.

“It is?”

“Yeah, actually.” Said Bow and Adora looked mildly impressed.

Glimmer stood as well, crossing her arms. “How do we know you won't *actually* betray us though?” Scorpia put her clawed hand to her chin, contemplating this and Catra walked over to her, not too close, though.

“She won't, she likes me too much.” This was true, but it didn't mean Catra liked her as much.

Scorpia's eyes lit up and she stepped over and squeezed Catra as hard as possible in a hug but Catra climbed out and escaped. The only hugs she liked were Adora's.

She met said girl's eyes for a moment and she looked slightly upset, her lips pursed. She had stood up at some point and joined the others.

Catra took several steps away from Scorpia and her tail swung around slightly. “See?” She said through gritted teeth.

Scorpia cleared her throat. “So, what's with ‘Tall-Ra’?” She asked. “I'm not used to people being taller than me.”

Catra had never really paid any attention to the height of either of the two but as she said that, she was right. Adora, as She-Ra, was ever so slightly taller than Scorpia who was the tallest person in the Fright Zone. Such a comment didn't really matter but, it was Scorpia, what else did they expect?

Scorpia glanced to the notebook lying open on Adora's bed. “Ooh, is that first ones? Entrapta would love that.”

“Where is Entrapta anyway?” Adora asked.

“She ran off somewhere with Perfuma.” Glimmer said and Adora shrugged.

“Anyway,” she turned toward Scorpia, “you don't know, do you?”

“Adora lost her memory because of Shadow Weaver.” At ‘Shadow Weaver’, Catra snapped a clothing hanger, that she had picked up at some point, right in half, imagining it was the sorceress herself. She took a breath afterward and calmed down and Bow grimaced.

Before anyone else could say anything, Adora let out a pained shriek and dropped to her knees, detransforming and holding her head with both hands. Bow and Catra immediately ran to her sides as she writhed on the floor in what looked like agony.

“Adora! What's happening!?” Glimmer yelled, totally freaking out. Scorpia had backed into a corner with her arms raised to her chin.

Catra and Bow held onto Adora while she continued groaning. “Can't your mom do something?” Bow asked Glimmer. Right, the queen was an immortal goddess person with healing powers.

Glimmer wrung her hand through her hair. “I-I don't know? She can't do anything to help if it's not something physical!”

“This looks pretty physical to me!” Catra exclaimed, trying to comfort a trembling Adora who had curled up into a ball, her hands still pressing in on her head. What on Etheria was going on?

Glimmer turned her head to either side of her with a panicked look on her face. “Uh, you're right!” She said and disappeared, presumably to get her mother. She appeared seconds later with the queen at hand and she was able to subside Adora's pain, at least making her fall asleep.

“What's going on here?” Queen Angella asked once Adora was okay.

“We don't know! She just- she must have had some sort of sharp headache suddenly!” Glimmer exclaimed and Angella put her hands on Glimmer's shoulders.

“Calm down,” she said softly, “Adora will be alright.” Glimmer's eyes moved to the floor and then back up and she nodded.

“What were you all doing in here?”

“We were trying to help Adora get her memories back-”

“And then Scorpia came in to tell us some brilliant plan-”

“And Adora just suddenly collapsed and-”

“Adora will be fine.” Queen Angella interrupted the flurry of voices. “What's this ‘brilliant plan’ you speak of?”

“Oh, you're gonna love it.” Scorpia left from her corner and led Glimmer's mom out of the room, spouting the same things she told the rest of them.

As soon as they left, focus was back on Adora. Despite what the queen had said, everyone was still the same amount of worried for Adora. Catra was still kneeling by her best friend, her head now resting in Bow's lap across from her. She leaned closer to examine her face. She didn't look nearly as pained as she was before but didn't quite look peaceful. Maybe she was having a bad dream. Catra only hoped it was her memories returning but also dreaded the fact that she'd have to deal with the regret of the things she'd done again.

Catra sighed. “Adora? Please be okay... this is *all* my fault!” She sat up again and smacked the floor with her hand. Bow looked up to her; until now he'd kept his gaze downward.

“Catra, this isn't anybody's fault. You heard Glimmer's mom, Adora will-”

“Of course it's my fault! Adora asked me to go with her the day she met you guys! I should have! I could've protected her when you guys clearly can't and I wouldn't have this guilt constantly weighing me down every day!”

“I understand but-” Glimmer cut in.

“How could you possibly understand?” Catra said, her voice breaking. Then she stood up and walked out if the room without another word.

She wasn't sure where she was going, she just needed to be out of there. She couldn't bear staring at Adora when she was like this. She was always so lively and happy, even when she left the Fright Zone Catra had noticed these things.

She ended up walking straight out the doors of the castle and heading for the Whispering Woods, the place had started growing

on her, and she often snuck out to hang there when she needed to relax, something she never could have done back at the Horde.

The sun was hanging over the horizon, casting golden light on the shadows of the woods. It must have been late afternoon; Catra hadn't been paying attention to the time. She managed to get up on a tree and perched herself on a branch, watching the sunset. It was picture perfect.

But Adora wasn't there.

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<u>Bow</u>

“We need the other princesses!” Glimmer shouted momentarily after Catra had marched out, throwing her arms in the air.

Bow carefully lifted Adora and rested her on her bed, then walked over to Glimmer, smashing her cheeks in his hands. “Calm down, Glimmer!” He said as kindly as possible. He, too, was worried out of his mind but he tried to keep everything positive.

At his words, Glimmer stopped pacing and looked him in the face. “We can ask the other princesses for help but you need to stop panicking.” He said.

“No,” Glimmer said, Bow raising an eyebrow, “not we. I.”

“I'm sorry? Weren't we going to do that in the first place? That's why we left.”

“And that's where Adora got captured-”

“I can't let you go alone-”

“ *I can’t lose you, too, Bow* .”

Silence rang throughout the room until Bow finally sighed and led Glimmer to a bench in Adora's room.

“We're safer *together.* ” He said. “Now, let's go, the princesses will want to help, they love Adora as much as we do, and now that Entrapta's back, there's no reason for us to be apart. We'll get through this, I promise.”

Bow pulled Glimmer in for a hug and just as they pulled apart, Adora stirred on the bed beside them.

“Adora?” Glimmer immediately teleported to her side and Bow ran over too. Adora inhaled deeply and groaned as her eyes slowly opened.

“Glimmer?” She asked, eyeing both of them. “Bow? What's going on?”

“Do you remember?” Bow asked in a concerned voice. Adora just looked confused.

“Remember what?” She sat up in the bed and Bow and Glimmer sat on either side of her.

The two glanced toward each other and then Bow raised a pointer finger. “Uh, everything?” He shrugged.

“By everything, you mean…?”

“Everything from the last few months!?” Glimmer gestured out the window where Adora had a perfect view of Bright Moon's horizon.

“Yeah, why wouldn't I? Did something happen?” She looked around the room. “Last thing I knew was Shadow Weaver got me, or, I thought she did.”

Glimmer scoffed. “You mean she erased your memory while you were still unconscious? That is low.” She said and crossed her arms. Adora's eyebrows furrowed.

“She *what?* ”

“Shadow Weaver actually finished wiping your mind this time,” Adora's eyes widened, “but now you're fine! So don't worry about it!”

“You guys came to rescue me? How long was I at the Fright Zone?”

“Only for a couple of hours. And it was Catra who went to get you, otherwise you'd have been there for a lot more.” Bow explained.

“...Catra?..” Adora trailed off and both nodded. Adora began to gaze out the window not far from her own bed. After several moments, she sighed. “I'm sorry. I totally gave up back there, I could have prevented all this and I'm sure it was a lot of trouble for you and-”

Bow placed both hands on Adora's shoulders and she brought her eyes to his. “No, don't apologize. We should have gone for you as soon as the fight was over, but we left.” He gasped. “ *We were bad friends again.* ”

Adora smirked. “Quiet, you.”

Glimmer chuckled. “Remember, the both of us were captured, too, and it was a hell of a lot more trouble for you to save us and you had to make sacrifices; we lo- *nearly* lost Entrapta and I'm still sorry for that.”

Adora sighed again. “Alright, can we all agree that the past shouldn't matter?”

Glimmer smiled and nodded. “Yeah, we're together now, that's all that matters.”

The three hugged, still on Adora's bed.

“Best Friend Squad!” Bow squealed as they all pulled apart, smiling. He was so glad to have both of his closest friends, practically family by now, despite knowing Adora for only a few

months, back. Together, they could conquer anything. Next to him, Glimmer adjusted her position so that they were all sitting in a circle on the sturdy bed.

“So, Adora, would you do me a favor?” Glimmer asked and Adora blinked.

“Yeah, anything.”

Glimmer exhaled a giggle. “Could you… by chance act like you don't remember anything?”

Adora looked taken aback. Bow didn't understand either. “What?” She asked. Glimmer's eyes darted to her right.

“Well… I don't trust Scorpia, fully, and she wants to spy on the Horde for us.” She scratched the back of her head. “I just don't want her spilling that you got your memories back so quickly. I'm sure Shadow Weaver is counting on you *not* remembering certain things and having limited trust towards us, y'know?”

Adora thought about this for a minute, then pursed her lips. “I guess that makes sense. But what about everyone else? Catra?”

“Not Catra!” Glimmer blurted. Adora furrowed her brows. “Why not? We can trust Catra, I thought this was well known-”

“I know! It's just… she, well, uh,” she looked stuck.

“She's close with Scorpia, what if she tells her?” Bow added and Glimmer gave him a ‘thank you’ look. He wasn't quite sure what this was all about because Scorpia seemed okay and Catra *was* trustworthy but that seemed like a good enough reason and Glimmer was struggling.

Adora stayed silent again until she shrugged. “I mean, I guess? I'll do that. Um, what did I and what did I not know?”

“You *didn't* remember about Catra leading enemy attacks on us but you know everything that Catra does about your defect from

the Horde and your time you had here, mostly.”

“Um. Okay, I guess.” Adora said and rested her weight on her hands supporting her from behind.

“Great!” Glimmer jumped up and hugged Adora briefly from the side. “Thank you Adora! C'mon Bow!” She grabbed his arm.

“Wait!” Adora said. “Where are you-?” and they were gone. Glimmer had teleported the two to Glimmer's room and sat down on her bench. Bow crossed his arms.

“Why did you *really* want Adora to pretend she didn't have her memories?” He pressed.

“Thought you'd never ask!” She said and jumped up once again. “Partly, what I said was true; I *don't* trust Scorpia-”

“Why not?”

“She *kidnapped* us!”

“So did Catra.”

“Yeah, but she's had time to redeem herself. None of us, not even Adora knew Scorpia that well, who knows what she's *really* like.” Glimmer jabbed her pointer finger towards Bow's face. “Anyways,” She teleported to a different part of her room. “I really wanted to see how she interacts with Catra! You've noticed she's acting different now, right? She's glad that Adora never knew of her betrayal and their whole fight and being each other's *arch nemeses* and stuff.”

“Oh I see, you're being a chaotic shipper and stalking their relationship.” Bow said with a smirk.

“I am *not!* They're just so obvious yet oblivious! I need to see the difference between how Catra used to view their relationship and how she does now.”

“Alrighty then. Where did Catra go, anyway?” Bow asked.

“No idea. We'll find her eventually.”

Glimmer laid back to rest on the soft bench she had ended up back on and Bow sat cross-legged on the floor, adjusting the string on his bow. He hoped Glimmer's idea wasn't too much.

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Scorpia

The Queen had agreed to Scorpia's infiltration plan! She would start back first thing tomorrow morning. Meanwhile, she decided to surround herself in the fresh air of Bright Moon and the Woods. Going back to the Fright Zone meant musky skies and unhealthy air. She wanted to enjoy the weather while it lasted.

She walked out the front doors and took in a deep breath of the great outdoors. As she admired the sheer beauty of Bright Moon, Scorpia realized that she didn't remember much of her old kingdom and old family. It couldn't have been nearly as nice as here, this rebellion *is* called the *Bright Moon Rebellion.* This is the center of it all and it housed the Queen, Scorpia's sworn enemy up until about a week ago. Now they were trusted allies. How did this all happen so quickly.

She examined the entrance of the Whispering Woods and spotted Catra sitting on a high branch overlooking both the entire forest and the entirety of Bright Moon. Must've been a gorgeous view.

But Catra seemed to be staring off into space, lost in her thoughts. Her tail waved slowly beneath the branch it was hanging off and her ears had bent down. Something was wrong.

Scorpia walked up toward the tree she was perched upon and climbed up to a thicker branch a few feet below her. Catra looked over at Scorpia but paid her no mind, bringing her gaze right back to where it was before.

“What's up, Wildcat?”

She raised an arm up. “ *Don't*- call me that…” She said, not moving her eyes. Sighing, Catra swung her legs over the side of the branch so she was sitting on it like a chair, facing Scorpia. Her eyes were still downcast.

“It's nothing, I just- I always seem to do something wrong, something that messes up everything.”

“Don't say that. Name *one* time you've messed something up.” Scorpia said, attempting to cheer her up.

“Well,” Catra began to count off her fingers, “I followed the Horde even though I knew it was bad, I attacked the person I care the most about multiple times, I allowed her to be taken away and now she lost her memory and it's *my fault* !”

“Okay, I get your point, but where is it your fault?” Scorpia asked.

“It just… is.” Catra began to adjust her position on the branch as to jump off it. “Bye Scorpia.” She said and leaped to the forest floor, making her way into the Whispering Woods.

Scorpia awkwardly climbed down the tree, her large frame and the fact that she didn't really have hands made it difficult, and landed on an uplifted root, rolling her ankle and falling backwards. “Ow.” She said, then noticed the footsteps approaching her.

She couldn't be seen behind the tree. She peeked out to see Adora strolling past, spinning her sword in her right hand. She was going in the same direction Catra had. Was she following her?

To find out what the deal was, Scorpia decided to follow them herself. She waited until Adora had retreated into the shadows of the forest and Scorpia emerged from her hiding spot behind the trunk but nearly jumped out of her skin when Glimmer and Bow appeared next to her.

“Scorpia!” Glimmer exclaimed. “What are you doing?”

“I was just talking to Catra but she ran off into the woods.”

The small princess hummed in response and began to walk in the direction the others had gone. “Where are you going? Why is everyone going into the woods?” Scorpia asked. The second question was generally directed to nobody.

“No reason! C'mon Bow!” Glimmer dragged her friend along who shrugged at Scorpia as they entered the forest.

Scorpia was kind of confused, but decided to follow anyway. The woods were as dark and spooky as ever; she'd been in it only once before her initial journey to Bright Moon as part of a mission Hordak had sent her and a team on right after she was promoted to Force Captain. They'd gotten lost and couldn't find what they were looking for so it was a complete failure but since then, Scorpia hadn't stepped foot into it. Except to find Catra of course.

She managed to catch up to Glimmer and Bow who had stopped behind a large tree, peeking at something ahead of them. Getting a closer look, Scorpia saw Adora and Catra in a clearing, chopped rays of sunlight shining down on them. Adora was holding onto both of Catra's hands and the two were silent, seemingly lost in each other's eyes.

“Adora,” Catra finally said, “I'm sorry.” At this, she averted her gaze from Adora and turned her head down in the direction of where Glimmer was hiding. She crouched further behind the trunk.

Scorpia had taken several steps back so she was definitely not seen and Bow had sat back against a different tree. Glimmer was the only one who seemed interested in whatever was going on.

“Why are you spying on them?” Scorpia whispered and Glimmer only shushed her. With nothing else to do, she tuned into the conversation between the two girls in the forest.

“There's nothing for you to be sorry about.” Adora was saying.

“But there is!” Catra said. “I keep… letting you down. You don't remember all of it but there's just… so much I've done.

“I… really care about you, Adora, and once you remember everything, you'll doubt that, but I just want you to know now. I just wish everything could go back to the way it was before…”

“That's what I'd like more than anything in the world, but now I'm with the princesses. My purpose is to protect Etheria.”

“But you don't even remember half of that! What if you just forget the sword, we can just…” Catra sighed.

“Actually, Catra, I-”

“No, just… forget it.”

Adora stayed silent for a few moments. “I had no idea you felt that way.”

Catra chuckled. “Of course you didn't.”

.

<u>Adora</u>

It almost made sense, the way Catra was acting. She still thought Adora didn't know about Catra and her fighting on opposite sides. She didn't want to deal with the same experience of regret as she did before.

Adora was somewhat shocked though. Sure, they were the best of friends back at the Fright Zone for their entire lives, but she never knew that she felt like *that.* It must of been a raise in compassion caused by being away from the influences of Hordak and Shadow Weaver.

She wanted more than anything to agree with Catra but she couldn't abandon her purpose. She didn't have the heart to tell her that she had, in fact, gotten her memories back.

“That's just how you are, clueless.” Catra said, her eyes downcast. She looked up, her face considerably closer to Adora's than it when they first met up in the forest.

“Hey, Adora?-” She sighed again. “Oh, what the hell; you won't even know what this means either, but…”

Catra began to lean her face even closer. Adora didn't bother to move back, it was nice having her there again and she just wanted to make her happy. All the while saving Etheria from the Horde. There must've been a way to do both.

Adora watched as Catra managed to grow even nearer, her eyes had shut. Everything seemed to be going in slow motion. That is until they heard a twig break in the woods next to them, followed by Scorpia rolling down next to them, she seemingly had tripped over something.

At this, Catra jumped back, her face was beet red for some reason. “Scorpia?!”

“Noooo!” None other than Glimmer ran out to join them, Bow behind her.

“What's your deal?!” Catra shouted, rage full.

Adora was mildly annoyed Glimmer had been watching them again but Catra's reaction seemed too extreme.

Glimmer raised a hand and pointed at Catra. “You were about to kiss her!”

“I was *not!* ”

“What does that even mean?!” Adora contributed. She didn't understand anything that was going on, just that it seemed unsafe to ever talk to Catra alone in fear of being spied on.

Catra let out an exasperated groan and marched off into a darker section of the woods. “Catra, wait!” Adora gave Glimmer, Bow,

and Scorpia a look before chasing after Catra.

Chapter End Notes

Heyo so like I said this is a shorter chapter and I'm super sorry it took so long, I've had essays to write, a drama production to perform and rehearse for, homework to do, sports to play, sleep to catch up on, etc I hope you understand. Anyways,, season 2 is coming out and I'm so hype. Also I promise I'll be writing more often - 3 weeks on between chapters! If I don't, you are legally allowed to hunt me down and smack me. Anyways I hope you liked this!! ^-^

~ A

Learning New Things

Chapter Notes

> Another *slightly* shorter chapter (by slightly I mean it's still like 5.5k words but whatevs) than some of the others because at first I had actually planned for a lot of this stuff to happen last chapter but then I procrastinated and wrote about 3/4 of what I actually wanted to. So I guess this is more of a chapter 6 part 2 but were gonna call it 7 because that's easier. Anyways,, hope you like!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

a/n: small warning: this chapter contains a couple of minor spoilers from season 2 if you haven't seen it yet (nothing too big) ((you really should have seen it by now though))

Glimmer

"Scorpia!" Glimmer exclaimed after Adora ran after Catra. She, Bow, and Scorpia were now standing in the spot that the two others were standing, a certain cat girl spilling her heart out, just moments before. Scorpia just *had* to ruin it. "Didn't you see what was about to happen?!"

Scorpia crossed her arms and frowned, her eyebrows furrowing. "Yeah, I was just leaving, and I tripped. Not my fault." She raised her arms up in surrender.

"First of all, how do you *trip backwards* , and second of all, why did you have to leave?" Glimmer demanded. This had been the one thing she'd been waiting for in her adventures of observing Catra and Adora's relationship. Now that she thought about it, it was a bit weird, but it was all for the greater good! Right?

"I couldn't watch that!" Scorpia responded. "I don't want Catra to be with her anyway!" The anger in her face instantly turned to

shock as she realized what she just said.

Glimmer smirked and leaned away from the argument, putting an hand on her hip. “Who would you rather she be with?”

Scorpia didn't answer, only blushed and looked away from Glimmer.

“Wait.” Bow interjected, the first thing he'd said in a while. “Do you *like* Catra?”

“No!” Scorpia said defensively; she would have balked her fists if she had any. She drew back slightly. “Maybe…” She admitted in a quieter voice.

She sighed and continued. “Just- I wish she would see me as worth her time. No matter what I do, I can't seem to break down her walls.” She stepped back and sat on a large rock behind her. “Those two,” she gestured in the direction Adora and Catra just went, “even when they were trying to kill each other, you could tell there's a real bond there. I mean, they grew up together, I can't compete with that…”

Glimmer pondered this for a moment. “Well,” she said, “that's true, but! I feel you.

“Once upon a time, like, last year, I was dating this girl, whose name I don't speak of. Ever.” She paused. “Anyway, this person was totally in love with someone else, while she was with me, but, the both of us were too afraid to let go because we were a whole mess. I *knew* she liked someone else and so did she but nothing happened and then she ended up cheating and that's how my first relationship was a total disaster.

“So what I'm trying to say is, you might have to… get over it? Sorry Scorpia.” Glimmer shrunk into herself in apology.

“No, I understand. I already accepted it. No big deal.” Scorpia said and shrugged.

Here Glimmer began to really connect with Scorpia. She didn't tell many people that story, not that it was traumatic or anything, but she usually kept her past to herself; same with Bow. She completely understood one-sided feelings.

With Catra it was different. It may seem like it was one-sided but Adora was just oblivious. She still didn't understand completely what everything meant, for whatever reason.

“Let's go back to the castle.” Bow suggested and began to walk towards the thicker part of the forest. Scorpia and Glimmer followed and headed back in the direction they came from, unanimously agreeing to leave Adora and Catra be.

The sun was hanging just at cloud level, meaning the day had almost gone by already.

Once they returned to the final stretch of path leading to the doors of the castle, a guard called out to them.

“Princess Glimmer and Scorpia, the Queen requests your presence.” She said and the two girls nodded and started in the direction of the meeting hall.

When they reached the room, Glimmer's mother sat at the table but stood when she saw Glimmer and Scorpia.

“You two, wonderful.” She said and walked over to them. “Scorpia, I would like to send you on your first infiltration mission of the Horde. Can I trust that you will *not* reveal any details about the Rebellion that would be detrimental to our cause?”

“Absolutely!” Scorpia said assuredly. “I promise.”

“Good luck to you then. You leave as soon as you're ready. Glimmer,” Angella turned towards her daughter, “You are requested for dinner tonight, with me.” Glimmer smiled and nodded. This time she would happily have dinner with her mom; no secrets or anything bad to deal with. It was a good day.

“Alright! See you in…?”

“An hour.” Angella answered. “We can talk about everything that's been going on. You've spent so much time with your friends these past few days, and Adora is sick-”

“Oh-! Uh never mind.” Glimmer was about to tell her that Adora was back to normal but she had agreed to keep it a secret from Scorpia, who just so happened to be standing right next to her. The queen gave her a strange look but let it go right away.

“Alright. Scorpia, best of luck, and Glimmer, I'll see you soon.” Queen Angella said and the two left to their own bedrooms.

But Glimmer couldn't help but wonder what was going on in the woods at this very moment.

.

Adora

“Catra!”

It had been over ten minutes of searching and Adora still hadn't seen a trace of her best friend in the woods. She had ran off after Glimmer, Bow, and Scorpia interrupted their talk but, that wouldn't make her upset with Adora, would it? She had to be there somewhere, why not just come out?

Adora sighed and readied to call out the name again. “Catra..? Where did you go?” It was late afternoon and it would get dark soon. She didn't want to get stuck in those woods at night again.

Knowing Catra, she was probably hiding in a tree. Maybe it would be easier to find her from higher ground. Adora walked over to a tree that looked remotely climb-able and attempted to go up it. That failed. She could hardly climb 3 feet above the ground.

“She-Ra can climb trees, right?” Adora said aloud and pulled her sword out - she always kept it with her in case of an emergency.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!” She said and transformed into the warrior princess, whom she thought looked cooler than her actual self anyway. Once her glow subsided, she went back to the tree and scaled it easily.

Conveniently, she spotted Catra in the tree right next to the one she had climbed, her legs hanging off the branch she was sitting on, the rest of her leaning into the trunk. Her hair covered most of her face and she practically ignored Adora's presence as she hopped over and sat beside her, detransforming.

“Catra? Are you okay?” Adora said and tried to lean around and look at her face but it was completely hidden by her hair and hand that was supporting her weight.

She wouldn't turn to face Adora at all, not even the slightest attempt.

“What's wrong, Catra?” Adora tried again. This time, Catra stood up and jumped out of the tree onto the forest floor and began walking deeper in the woods, not saying a word. Adora grunted and followed suit, not having the same agility as the half-cat and rolling out of her landing. She sat for a moment and shook her head before standing to catch up to Catra.

She was walking very fast and Adora had to jog just to keep up with her. But everytime Adora would make it to her side, she just seemed to walk even faster, avoiding her at all costs.

“Catra!” Adora jogged back up to her again and grabbed her wrist, tugging her around to face her. Catra kept her head bowed with her hair covering her eyes. “Catra, I need to tell you something.”

Finally, Catra looked up. Her eyes were slightly red, as if she were crying. Adora gasped at her appearance and put her right hand against Catra's cheek. The flushed girl leaned into Adora's palm, her eyes downcast.

The two sat down on a nearby rock. This rock had an X carved into it; they were very near the beacon where they had been

trapped and where Catra had first agreed to join the Rebellion.

“Adora-”

“Catra, my memory is back. It's been back.” Adora interrupted, saying what she had wanted to tell Catra the moment it happened.

“What?” She said, turning her head to the left and blushing slightly. “Why didn't you tell me?” She looked back up to Adora.

Adora didn't want Catra to be upset with her so she anxiously explained herself. “You wouldn't let me, I tried-”

“It's okay, Adora, I get it.” Catra assured. Adora was relieved but still felt obligated to tell her the reasons.

“Glimmer told me not to.”

“What? Why?” Catra asked, tilting her head.

“She was afraid you'd tell Scorpia who'd tell the Horde or something.” Adora rambled.

“I doubt that's the reason, but, know I trust you more than I'll ever trust Scorpia.” She paused and exhaled. “I meant what I said… about you. I just can't figure out why you don't have any idea what any of us are talking about.”

There was a moment of silence before Adora spoke up. “I wish I did, Catra. The others tried to explain it to me. What's your take on it?”

“On what?”

“This ‘love’ thing.” Adora answered and Catra went red again, but only for a moment.

“Hmm, well…” She pursed her lips then made proper eye contact with Adora and placed a hand on hers. “Adora, I… want you to

be… my person, if that makes any sense."

"Am I not already 'your person'? I mean, we've been friends for so long." Adora asked, still oblivious to what was going on.

"Well, no." She sighed. "You wouldn't get it but… that's not enough for me. I wanna be *more* than best friends. That's what I think- *love* is."

"Okay, I kinda get it. What do *more than best friends* do? Does it have anything with what you were doing when Scorpia fell?"

Catra's face flushed again. "Uh, well… wait a second!" A lightbulb practically appeared over Catra's head. Her 'I figured it out' face quickly changed to a contorted one. She changed the topic instantly. "That witch! She wanted this to happen!"

Adora was confused. "Huh?"

Catra stood. "Glimmer! She *wants* us to…" She trailed off. Adora assumed it was because she was going to say something that Adora wouldn't understand.

Catra didn't succumb to Adora's incomprehension and just kept speaking, more to herself than anyone else. "Hah, she's not gonna get what she wants! Adora," Catra turned toward Adora, "let's go back! Forget I said *anything* !" She was still smiling as she said this though so it didn't seem like a threat at all. She grabbed Adora's hand and helped her up, starting back in the direction of Castle Bright Moon.

.

<u>Scorpia</u>

The trip back to the Fright Zone wasn't nearly as long as the trek to Bright Moon. Scorpia had left only minutes after the Queen requested her to. It wasn't that she wanted to leave the gorgeous kingdom but, to be honest, the Queen scared her a little. Back in the Horde, the queen of Bright Moon was portrayed as this

hideous beast made of pure evil, which wasn't true, she was actually quite nice, but, like Shadow Weaver and Hordak, she was in a position of great power and it didn't seem like a good idea to go against her.

So as soon as Scorpia gathered her things, she left on her mission. The Fright Zone was just as she remembered; dark, musty, but it felt like home. She was sure Adora and Catra felt the same way about the place. It was where they grew up, they'd grown accustomed. But that didn't mean it was good. The people inside were either oblivious of the harm they were causing Etheria or were the ones leading it.

Then again, Scorpia couldn't really care less about what happened to the planet; she just wanted to protect the people she loved.

She approached the entrance near the Whispering Woods and walked up to a soldier guarding the door. He didn't question her presence, and she walked right in. Clearly her absence wasn't as nearly a big of a deal as Adora's.

Scorpia began walking towards her old room as soon as she made it inside. Two minutes later, she was right outside the door when she felt a presence approaching her. A dark presence. She turned around to see Shadow Weaver floating over toward her. She did not look very happy, though you couldn't really tell with the mask and all.

“Force Captain.” She said eerily, darkness filling the space around her. “You are a traitor.” She grew, raising her arms up. Scorpia needed to do something now; right now.

“No no no!” She waved her hands in front of her and looked on either side. “The princesses don't know I'm here.” She cleared her throat and stood up straight. “I have information.”

“Do you, now?” Shadow Weaver shrunk back and retreated her shadows, her black hair still hovering above her head.

Scorpia let out a breath of relief. Her excuse worked like a charm.

“Come with me.” Shadow Weaver said and started in the direction she came from. There was only one thing in that direction. Lord Hordak's sanctum. Usually, Shadow Weaver would go to the Black Garnet Chamber but since Entrapta fried it, it must've still been out of commission. Scorpia couldn't even guess what the source of her powers were now without the runestone.

Once they reached the entrance, Scorpia realized that she would have to deal with Hordak himself, who is a lot different than Shadow Weaver. Hopefully he wouldn't catch her bluff. Scorpia inaudibly gulped as the doors to the sanctum opened.

However, when she stepped inside, Hordak was nowhere to be seen. The room had been rearranged too. There was at least a quarter of the place now dedicated to the works of Shadow Weaver. She'd moved in.

Scorpia was led to a spot where she and the sorceress could talk. The walls around were the same deep blood red color as the black garnet and there were long curtains strung from the high ceiling.

“So, uh, what's with this place?” Scorpia asked hesitantly.

“This is my living quarters while the Black Garnet is being repaired.” She said matter-of-factly.

“Who's fixing it? Now that, y'know…”

“Force Captain Lonnie. She's the only one who seems to have a brain around here.” Shadow Weaver stated, blatantly accusing everyone in the Fright Zone of being stupid.

Scorpia decided not to push any further in fear of accidentally spilling something she was not supposed to and waited for Shadow Weaver to settle herself. Finally she turned toward Scorpia.

“Force Captain Scorpia, tell me, what is the status of Adora?”

Scorpia brought her claws up near her face. “Ooh, not so well.” She put a hand up by her face as if she were telling a secret. “She still doesn't have her memory, let alone believes anything the princesses say.” She lied. “They practically have to keep her prisoner so she doesn't escape back to here.”

The eye slits in Shadow Weaver’s mask narrowed. “Is that so?” She began to pace away from Scorpia. “I would imagine the presence of you and Force Captain Catra would encourage her to affiliate once again with their type.” She turned to face her again. “With *your* type.”

Scorpia panicked briefly but tried her best not to show it. “I know, right?” She chuckled nervously. “That's what I was thinking but, y'know, she feels like Catra betrayed her which is kinda what happened but like, not really, but anyway yeah she-she’s not-”

“Force Captain.” Shadow Weaver interrupted Scorpia's babbling. The previous Horde princess snapped to attention at the title and the tone of Shadow Weaver’s voice.

“Do the princesses trust you?”

“I mean- I think, yeah.” Scorpia sweated and rubbed an arm behind her neck.

“And you say Adora is willing to return to the Fright Zone?”

“Oh yeah!” Scorpia managed to put a somewhat confident facade on.

“Prove your allegiance to the Horde by bringing her here, out of the grasps of those princesses.” Shadow Weaver suggested. “She will be an immense help to finally take down Bright Moon. And so will you; *do not disappoint me.* ”

“Yes, ma'am!” Scorpia saluted, and began back in the direction of the doors leading to the Whispering Woods where she came from.

Before leaving though, she stopped by her old room to reminisce in what used to be. She felt awfully nostalgic back in the place. Despite its evilness and the fact that it had only been some days since she was there last, Scorpia almost… missed it. She remembered hardly anything about her past life and always fit it more with the Horde than anyone else.

She grabbed a couple of personal items and left before she could consider staying.

.

Bow

Bow was resting on a signal tower on the roof of the palace, trying to figure out where the new First One's tech that had appeared on his tracker pad was located when he saw two figures emerge from the darkness of the whispering woods. The sun had just started setting so the two contrasted with the light of the sun and moons behind them.

It was Adora and Catra, Catra practically dragging her friend along towards the castle. Thinking back, Bow had always been curious of Catra. Where did she come from? Why isn't there anyone else like her? She seemed to be the only cat-person on Etheria. What was up with that? Bow was pretty sure even that lizard dude, Roger or whatever, had others of his species in the Horde. Catra was all by herself and a lot of other people were simply human.

He wanted answers. Maybe Catra knew something about her past and just hadn't told them? Adora would probably know too, since there's nothing that isn't shared between them. Although, ever since the ‘being archenemies’ thing, there might've been a decline.

He stood up and shot a grappling hook arrow to a tree near the two girls, amused when he saw Catra jump, startled by the sudden noise. Bow swung down beside them.

“Hey guys!”

Catra was still standing in a defensive position but adjusted herself casually and cleared her throat. “What are you doing?” She asked monotonously.

“Sorry for scaring you.” “I wasn't-!” “I just wanted to say hi.” Bow said.

“Okay, hi.” Catra said and crossed her arms.

“Catra,” Adora chided and stepped up to Bow. “Why were you in the woods earlier?” She asked calmly.

“Oh,” Bow chuckled and scratched the back of his neck, “that.” He sighed. “It was Glimmer's idea.”

“Of course it was. What's her problem?” Catra threw her arms in the air.

Bow was about to answer when he remembered the reason he came down there in the first place. “Oh, Catra, I wanted to talk to you.”

“You did? Why?” Adora elbowed Catra.

“By herself?” Adora asked and Bow nodded. “Oh, alright, I was thinking I should get back to my training with Light Hope anyway.” Catra looked slightly hesitant but agreed.

As Adora walked back into the forest, Bow led Catra to the spot he was sitting before. It was a nice day so being outside was probably better. He didn't want to pry, but one of the things that had been on his mind since Adora told them about Catra was her past. Why was she orphaned? What if she was in any way like Adora?

They reached the tower on the roof of the castle and Bow sat down, gesturing for Catra to do the same. She did.

“So what's this about? You going to interrogate me about Adora too?” She demanded.

“Nope!” Bow said. Catra looked surprised. “I wanted to know more about you.”

Catra stayed silent for a moment. “About… me?” Bow figured that she never really had anyone interested in her actual self before based on her reaction. Apart from Adora, of course, but this wasn't about her. Bow was truly curious about Catra and how she grew up; what her family was like. All he knew was that she, too, had been taken in by the Horde when she was young and bonded with Adora for a long time. Not a crazy amount of knowledge.

“Yeah.” He cleared his throat and adjusted his sitting position. “I'm just curious, but do you know *anything* about your past?”

“Nope, nothing.”

“So you're like Adora, then.”

“I'm nothing like Adora! But, y'know, opposites attract.” She paused. “No, wait.”

Bow smirked slightly.

“I didn't mean it like-” Catra sighed and crossed her arms. “Why do you want to know about my past?”

“Like I said, I'm only curious, but… have you ever considered the fact that you might be a princess, too? Like Adora?” Bow asked cautiously, knowing she had negative reactions to suggestions such as this before.

“No, absolutely not.” *Figures.* “I thought you said this *wasn't* going to be about Adora.”

“It's-it’s not. I'm just giving a comparison. Anyway, it's only because, well, Glimmer's mom is the queen of all princesses, so she knows pretty much everything there is to know, and, I'm pretty sure she's mentioned a feline-like princess in the past. But apparently that royal family was killed off. What if-”

“No, not possible. I'm done here.” Catra started to stand up as if she were about to walk away.

“Wait, Catra!” She paused and turned around. Bow stood and sighed. “Are you *sure* you don't know anything? Anything at all?”

Catra took a sharp breath in and sat back down. She began speaking, not looking at Bow at all.

“I… had a dream, a couple chapters ago.” Bow raised a quizzical eyebrow but she continued. “And… I saw my mother… or at least she said she was my mother. She told me that I needed to trust all the princesses, but was very vague on why. At first I thought that was it - just a dream, but she had told me to leave, to go back to Bright Moon because someone was waiting for me and avast, Scorpia was here. I have no idea what it means…”

“Have you told anyone about this?” Bow asked, having sat down as she began talking. Catra only shook her head.

Not even Adora? Bow thought. That was something rare. Especially since joining the Rebellion, those two never left each other’s sides, and anything that happened to one would be immediately shared with the other. It couldn’t be that different than it was at the Fright Zone either, just, both had a completely different mindset now.

“This could definitely mean something.” Bow said. “Did Shadow Weaver ever tell you anything about where you came from?”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Pshh, why would she? First of all, if what you’re saying is true, there’s no way she would ever, second of all, she hated my guts, so, no, I really don’t think so.” The last part of the sentence was said with a sarcastic tone.

“What’s your first memory?”

“The Horde. I have no idea what happened to me to bring me there, and I was taught never to wonder such things. So Adora and I were just forced to forget anything we may have known

about ourselves, though I doubt we would have, since both of us were brought when we were just babies." Catra explained. Bow noticed now that she was actually opening up. She had an open mind and was too becoming curious about her past, something she was never able to think about before.

"Were there other orphans in the Fright Zone?" Bow asked. He had a theory brewing.

"Yeah, plenty. The Horde *loved* to steal children away from families. No matter where they came from."

Bow took this into account. "Did Shadow Weaver raise all of them?"

"Hah, no, she despised everyone but Adora, for whatever reason."

"Then why did she choose to raise you?" *Why would she do that if there wasn't anything special about you?*

"I don't know? I guess Adora needed a friend?"

"But Shadow Weaver didn't care about friendships did she?"

Catra pursed her lips. She hesitated. "She sensed power in Adora as soon as she arrived. There was nothing about me, she must've just chosen a random child to bring up."

"What if she sensed power in you, too?" Bow suggested.

Catra just shook her head. She looked overwhelmed. "That can't be it. I'm just… nobody." She inhaled. "Why would she treat Adora so much better than she did me?"

A valid question. Maybe she knew all along that Adora was this all powerful princess, She-Ra, and wanted her to stay with the Horde so they treated her as nicely as possible. Though it was the complete opposite for Catra. For all he'd been told, Bow knew that Catra was practically Shadow Weaver's punching bag.

What if she needed an extra reason for Adora to stay. If there was someone she cared about who needed protecting, Adora would not defect as easily as she did. Though, now that Bow found out that Adora had no idea what love even was, such a feeling couldn't drive her not to leave Catra behind.

Yet it was so obvious that she did love Catra. Bow had seen several times that Adora tried so hard to bring Catra onto their side but she was just stubborn.

"I am *not!* No, you're right, I am." Catra said, surprising Bow because he hadn't the slightest clue he was verbalizing his thoughts. "And, Adora doesn't… love me."

Bow raised his eyebrows. "Are you *blind* ?"

Catra looked around her then back at Bow. "Hmm, no." She said sarcastically and crossed her arms.

"Okay, so you know what love is and clearly you are in love with Adora."

"That is false."

Bow ignored her. "But what I still don't get is why Adora is so clueless. Glimmer and I attempted to teach her but like, it's completely nonsensical to her."

Catra took a deep breath. "Well, the thing is, she wasn't always like that. It's like, as soon as she left, she became a completely different person. Her personality was generally still the same but it was almost like she didn't… know me like she used to. After we went into the woods for the first time, I realized that the Adora I knew would never break the rules like that, and then the next night, she snuck out? It was like something was controlling her."

The topic of Adora was now back to full effect. "Maybe Light Hope found a way to reach her and saw an opportunity to show her the sword. It's a stretch, I know, but-"

“No, it makes sense. Kind of.” Catra said. “I don't really want to talk about this anymore.”

She turned to stand up again. Bow understood, some of his theories were a bit farfetched but if he found out probably conslusions about a past he knew nothing about, he'd be overwhelmed too.

“Yeah, okay.” He said.

Bow silently decided to continue his research on his own later and Catra used her incredible agility to simply jump off the castle and swinging and hopping her way to the ground. The sun was finally setting and Bow hoped Adora was safe out in the woods for her training. He decided to take the stairs down into the castle and found a place to think on his own.

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<u>Adora</u>

“Hey Adora.” Catra's voice said as Light Hope's simulation training began. Adora froze.

“No, no! Catra's on our side now!” Adora yelled into the atmosphere. “I can't fight her!”

The forest simulation around her flickered out and again she stood in the crystal room where she could speak to Light Hope. Adora had gotten there about fifteen minutes before and asked to continue her training. She remembered the times she turned her sword into a shield and decided to test what else it could become. That would be helpful in battle. Light Hope had prepared a fight for her but just as it started, it was finished. There was no way Adora would fight Catra, not anymore.

Light Hope stood behind Adora, looking confused, or, as confused an artificial intelligence hologram could be.

“You knew this already!” Adora exclaimed.

“That is correct. My main frame must have been tampered with.” Light Hope's image glitched then returned to normal.

“What?” Adora asked. “By who?”

“I do not know. Please, continue.” Light Hope said and Adora furrowed her brows but turned around, getting ready to fight again. She quickly transformed into She-Ra.

He next opponent was hiding in the shadows of the trees, sitting on a branch. Adora couldn't tell who it was until an arrow flew right past her face.

“ *Bow?!* ” Adora motioned for the simulation to stop again. “Light Hope, what is going on?”

“Is Bow not and enemy of yours?”

“No!” Adora said, exasperated. “Did the Horde find you or something? This has never happened before.”

Light Hope began glitching again and the lights in the room flickered around her. A distorted version if the woman's voice filled Adora's head.

“Adora must balance Etheria.”

“Adora cannot be like Mara.”

“Adora must be alone.”

“ *Adora must not love.* ”

At that last word, the lights went out all together, Light Hope disappeared, and the word ‘love’ echoed throughout the room and inside Adora's head. She was trapped in darkness.

She suddenly felt a sharp pain in her skull and collapsed on her knees, a loud ringing almost drowning out the repeating sound of

Light Hope's broken voice. She clapped her hands over her ears and dropped her head to the floor, breathing heavily.

That's when everything stopped; the deafening ringing, the repetition of that one word, the lights turning on and off. Everything went back to normal and Adora was still on the floor, the strange occurrance triggering some sort of panic attack.

Light Hope was back. “Are you alright, Adora?” She asked, as if nothing had happened at all. Something was definitely wrong with her system. Adora just had no idea what.

She calmed down moments later and stood up. “Light Hope hadn't said another word. Adora took a deep breath and faced the hologram.

“Why don't I know what love is?” She asked, figuring Light Hope must have known something considering what had just went down.

“I do not know. Why such a question at this moment? Did something happen?”

In that moment, she flickered again and the lights turned blood red for a second and the same voice repeated the phrase again.

“ *Adora must not love.* ”

As soon as everything returned to as it was, Adora marched up to Light Hope, almost reaching her height as She-Ra, “What is happening?! Did *you* do something?”

“I do not know what you mean.”

“Why do you keep saying that I *can't love?* ”

“I do not know what you mean.”

The atmosphere went dark again.

" *Adora cannot be like Mara.* "

" *Adora must not love.* "

Back to the ordinary light blue, and Light Hope finally said something useful.

"My systems are malfunctioning. I apologize for any inconvenience." With the last word, her voice lowered in pitch and speed like she was powering off, but her image remained standing there, as static.

A voice rang out.

"Ooh."

It sounded awfully familiar.

"Fascinating!"

…

What did she do now?

Chapter End Notes

> So I'm really trying to have an actual story with this so it's not /just/ the gays and I'm trying to expand the catra princess theory and my mind was completely blown as I was coming up with these ideas bc otherwise I wouldn't think about it tbh. Also I had to sneak the title in there somewhere y'know? Another thing is an idea in here is based on a comment from @/RogueSilvarianDragon on wattpad so like thanks!! Anyways season 2 is a thing-!!! There were a couple minor spoilers in this chapter like the fact that scorpia has "intense crush on Catra" (noelle's words not mine) but in case anyone hasn't seen it yet I'm not gonna freak out or anything. So like I hope you enjoyed this chapter peeps I've officially decided my posting schedule will be every 3 Thursdays so like yeah. ^-^

~A

Planning

Chapter Notes

> O MY GOD I'M SORRY here have a half finished chapter-
> but seriously I've had writers block for like 5 months and added a single sentence to this in the last several months
> soooooo ehhhhh I'll just post this
> it's not done and it's only half the length of my normal chapters but I hope yall enjoy nonetheless

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

"Entrapta??" Adora said as a silhouette of the princess appeared from behind a computer simulated pillar.

"Hi Adora!"

"Wha- How are you in here? This system is specifically designed for She-Ra and her steed *only* !"

The princess shrugged. "Oh it wasn't so hard, all I had to do was shut off the AI controlling it."

Adora was absolutely bewildered. "But, Light Hope's been functioning for thousands of years!" She exclaimed. "That's- not possible!"

Entrapta shrugged again and Adora just decided to give up. She was starting to learn that it was easier to not ask questions. She sighed.

"How did you find this place anyway?" Adora asked.

"I saw you in the woods. This is First One's, I couldn't resist." Entrapta replied maniacally. "Oh and by the way-"

“What did you do, exactly? You messed with the tech, right? You better not have broken it, this is the only connection to my past - my true past - I have left.” Adora jabbed a pointer finger in Entrapta’s face. Adora had only just began her training with Light Hope and was far from the potential abilities she could have.

“Not to worry! Everything is fixable!” She said. “So what I was trying to say was-”

“Fix it.” Adora said sternly, interrupting again.

“Alright, alright, fine. I just need a minute.” Entrapta disappeared from the simulation and Adora followed. When she woke up, Entrapta was already busy rearranging wires and typing away at a keyboard that had appeared from the side of the platform that Adora was laying on. Perfuma was there too. She was rambling on about how she had gotten so worried suddenly when Entrapta had just collapsed once figuring out how to insert herself into Light Hope’s system and the purple haired girl just ignored her, busying herself with several things at once, at least 4 hands working on the computer.

After about two minutes of only occasional sparks and constant typing noises, Entrapta suddenly called out, “Fixed!” making both Adora and Perfuma jump where they stood.

“Is it?” Adora asked suspiciously, knowing Entrapta tended to do her own thing when working with technology.

“Yep! And as I was looking through the data, I found some interesting information that they had hidden away. I programmed this Light Hope person to tell you these things next time you go in there.”

Of course you did. “Okay… can I look at it?”

“Now's probably not the best time, the other princesses should be at Bright Moon by now.” Entrapta said casually as if the news that the princesses were going to Bright Moon wasn't a big deal at all.

“What!?”

“Oh yeah! We went and got all the princesses to join the Princess Alliance again. It wasn't so hard, considering it was *my* fault it broke up in the first place-”

“That's amazing!” Adora exclaimed, grabbing Entrapta by the shoulders. “Thank you so much!” She hugged the smaller princess, pulling Perfuma in with them.

“Everything's been messed up since I was captured by Shadow Weaver and we've had to push back this recruiting mission way way back and-”

“Wait, I'm sorry, you were captured?” Perfuma asked, Adora realizing that the two of them had gone elsewhere when they finished the second battle at Plumeria.

“Yeah, everything's fine now though.” She assured them, not bothering to talk about her memory loss because it would just cause too much wasted time. “But, shouldn't we catch up to the rest of them?”

“Yes!” Entrapta said, putting a pointer finger in the air and Adora led them out of the Beacon. But she couldn't help but wonder what the secrets Light Hope had hidden away were.

.

<u>Glimmer</u>

Bright Moon’s princess lie awake in her bed waiting for Adora to return. Bow had informed her that she had went training and Catra had escaped to the woods somewhere. Glimmer had heard Catra come back some time ago. It was dark out so she imagined she wouldn't want to stay in the forest at night. Adora however was still out there, and considering what recently happened to her, it was anyone's responsibility to worry.

Glimmer stared at the ceiling, unable to fall asleep, yet in some sort of trance. When there was a knock on the door, she snapped out of it and teleported over to the door, fixing her disheveled hair.

“Adora?” She asked as she swung the door open.

“Sorry Sparkles, it's just me.” Catra stood in the shadows of the hallway.

Glimmer opened the door wider and let her step in. “What's up? Can't sleep?”

“Yeah…” Catra murmured. “I've never slept without any other people around.”

“I get it. Adora was the same.” Glimmer said and teleported the two up onto her bed by the ceiling. Catra sat cross-legged, her back supported by a pillow and Glimmer across from her.

There were a couple moments of awkward silence between them until Glimmer figured out how to break it. “So… sorry for spying on you earlier. I don't know what's wrong with me.” She rested her chin in both palms.

Catra inhaled deeply and sighed. “It's fine. I'm honestly too tired to care.” She tried to stifle a yawn but failed.

“Uh, you can sleep here if you want.” Glimmer offered. “Adora did that the first day she came here. I woke up with her right where you're sitting. I got so scared I fell off the bed!”

Catra chuckled but declined. “No, but thanks. I'll just wait until Adora gets back.” Glimmer nodded.

“You know, you're a lot different than I imagined, now that I kinda got to know you more.” Glimmer said after a moment. Catra's gaze was down at her hands. She smirked.

“Really? What did you think I was like?”

Glimmer wasn't about to tell her that in her mind, Catra had been this femme evil queen. “Oh, I dunno. Just… different.” She said instead.

“Well-”

Catra was interrupted by the door bursting open. Scorpia stood there and scanned the room before spotting Glimmer and Catra sitting atop Glimmer's hanging bed.

“Scorpia?” Both said in unison. She seemed almost panicked.

“Catra, Glimmer!" Scorpia exclaimed and Glimmer brought the two back down to the floor where she stood. "Where's Adora?"

Glimmer and Catra looked at each other. "Uh, not here."

"Why? Did something happen?"

"How did your mission go?"

Before she could answer, there was another knock on the door. Glimmer opened it to see a guard standing there. "Princesses," she said, despite Catra, "you have visitors."

She moved out of the way to reveal Mermista and Frosta standing outside the door. An unlikely pair but Glimmer was more than surprised to see them.

Upon entering the room, Princess Frosta immediately gasped and pointed at Scorpia and Catra who were standing to Glimmer's left. "You tried to destroy my kingdom!"

"Yeah, what are *they* doing here?" Princess Mermista said, stepping back and whisking a ball of water between her hands. Frosta formed a hammer of ice on her fist.

"No no no wait!" Glimmer said, stepping between the former Horde officers and the princesses and waving her hands. "They're with us!"

Mermista let her water spill onto the floor and relaxed her stance. "Whatever." She said and yawned. "Why did we have to come here in the middle if the night again?"

"Why are you guys here?" Glimmer asked.

"Geeky princess and her girlfriend came and told us to come or whatever." Mermista explained halfheartedly.

"Yeah, but can you *please* tell us why the Horde is standing in your room?" Frosta said and crossed her arms.

Glimmer sighed and began to explain the whole story again, stopping in the middle to find Bow and have him join the conversation. Once everything was cleared up, the door to Glimmer's room started opening slowly.

Adora walked in, followed by Entrapta and Perfuma.

"Adora!" Both Glimmer and Catra said upon her arrival.

"Hey guys." She said before Scorpia walked up to her and stood in her way.

"I need to take you to the Fright Zone." She said flatly.

"I'm sorry?" Adora asked, clearly taken aback by this sudden demand.

Shadow Weaver doesn't fully trust me yet so I can only do so little and I gotta 'prove my allegiance to the horde' by bringing you and I also may have said you would willingly go because you never got any of your memories back and-"

"Whoa whoa," Adora said to Scorpia, "sorry Glimmer," to Glimmer, "I have all my memories now. They all came back."

Scorpia froze for a second. "Oh…" There was a long pause. "Okay." Bow stepped up and cut in.

"No, actually that's not okay, Scorpia-"

"Wait what happened I'm soooooo confused, not that I care but-"

Suddenly everyone in the room began talking at once. Glimmer couldn't take it. She inhaled deeply.

"OKAY EVERYBODY SHUT UP!" She shouted, silencing the group instantly. "That's better."

"Uh, anyways, welcome back to Bright Moon guys." Bow said to the princesses.

"Princess Adora," a voice said from within the crowd and Adora stepped up, the rest clearing the way for Frosta to be seen. "First things first, I would like to sincerely apologize for the way I acted back at the Princess Ball. I am now a devoted member of the Princess Alliance and my kingdom will do anything for Bright Moon in a time of need." She said and curtseyed.

"Thank you, Frosta, but I have to admit, I was quite rude to you as well. I hope we can put this all in the past." Adora replied.

Frosta nodded and smiled, putting an hand out for Adora to shake. Truce.

"Um, Scorpia?" Catra spoke up. "What exactly happened at the Fright Zone on your trip?"

"Oh, right!" She exclaimed. Glimmer wasn't sure if this story would be a good one or not.

.

<u>Scorpia</u>

Scorpia had to get this story out quick; Shadow Weaver expected a fully Horde-brained Adora back at the Fright Zone as soon as possible.

"Okay," she began, "I got there and they let me in no problem, as if no one even knew I left, which, I guess shows how important I am. Anyway, I figured I'd go to my old room, right? But then Shadow Weaver creepily snuck up on me and went all evil, y'know, so I had to convince her that you guys didn't know I was there.

"She believed me, I think, and took me to Hordak's place where she had basically moved in because y'know the Black Garnet is still out of commission, oh, but they're trying to fix it; Lonnie's been made Force Captain and is in charge of all that apparently-"

"Whoa whoa whoa wait." Glimmer stopped her. "Are they anywhere close to fully repairing it?"

"I don't know yet, that's why I want to go back there as soon as I can but not without Adora."

"Why do you need me to come?" Adora asked and Catra put a hand to block her.

"Adora's not going anywhere." She said.

"Okay, everybody, calm down." Bow cut in, stopping the conversation for a moment.

"Why did Scorpia go back to the Horde?" Frosta broke the brief silence, seemingly suspicious. She was probably still skepitcal because of what happened at Princess Prom. Scorpia would be too, if something like that happened while she was in charge.

Scorpia sighed. "Like I said, I managed to convince them I was still on their side to get information for the Rebellion.

"Anyway, they're trying to fix the Black Garnet and-"

"Wait-" Glimmer interrupted again. "Sorry, but, isn't that your runestone? Are you connected in any way to it?"

"Not anymore; it's been years since. When Shadow Weaver started using it for her own power, it kind of… faded away. But that was over ten years ago."

Glimmer hummed in response.

"What about you Entrapta?" Adora asked. "Where's your runestone?"

Entrapta put a hair hand up to her chin. "I'm not sure. I don't remember too much about my past; must've electrocuted myself one too many times." She said and shrugged, both real shoulders and her hair.

There was another couple seconds of silence. "Okay, Lobster Lady, you gonna continue?" Mermista spoke up.

"Yes!" Scorpia was called back to the reason they were all there. "So the runestone. I don't know what that progress is. But Shadow Weaver doesn't trust me fully, so I gotta bring Adora as proof of my Horde…-ness."

"But, I wouldn't just go, and, no offense, but I'd be able to beat you if you were to try by force." Adora explained.

"You don't know that… But! I kinda told Shadow Weaver that you never got any memories back and you don't believe anything the princesses say and that you're completely pro-Horde…"

"What?" Glimmer exclaimed.

"Why would you say that?" Catra added.

"I- panicked, okay? She was about to make my own shadow fight me to the death!" That wasn't 100% true but she couldn't tell them what the real reason was. "So I thought, maybe you could go and pretend you're on their side, like I am."

"They're not gonna buy that!" Glimmer said.

"Okay say, she does go, she would have to *not* be She-Ra, obviously." Bow said.

"And they are *not* getting the sword." Adora added. "But I can agree to that - we just have to plan first."

"Wait, no. Adora-" Catra outbursted.

"Catra, I'll be fine, but I can't go without a plan. Anyone got anything?" Adora asked. Catra still looked hesitant.

"I mean, you could just chill there, occasionally ruining stuff." Mermista suggested.

"Or, you could pretend to fight while actually helping us!" Said Perfuma.

"Ooh! Maybe you could create a distraction so we can get in and crush then all when they leave expect it!" Frosta inputted.

"We could make that work." Adora said, shrugging.

"I like all of those ideas!" Scorpia exclaimed.

"I don't!" Catra yelled, stopping the flow of thought in the room. It was like a record was scratched, and everyone went silent. Catra shrunk back at the sudden attention on her.

"I-... you could get hurt." She said quieter, to Adora, avoiding everyone's stare. Of course she would care about that. The only thing she was worried about was Adora, all the time, This plan would put the Rebellion at a much greater advantage, while the Horde would think they were the ones with the advantage.

Everyone collectively and unanimously took a step back to allow Adora to step up to a somewhat cowering Catra. She seemed super vulnerable, Scorpia had never seen her like this before.

“Catra, I will be okay, I can take care of myself. You don’t have to worry so much. This will all work out; it’s for the greater good.”

She said in a kind tone, placing a hand on Catra's shoulder. Scorpia mentally sighed. Catra beared a hesitant smile on her face until Bow broke the momentary silence by clearing his throat.

"Adora's right." He said and everyone's attention was restored. "This could *save Etheria.* We could finally beat them! I say do it! Who's in?" He put a hand facing down in the center of the circle they had all been standing in. Entrapta was the first to join, despite being quiet the whole conversation and Scorpia followed. One by one, everyone was putting their hands in - Adora, then Frosta, then Glimmer, then Perfuma, then Mermista. Finally, Catra joined as well.

"For Etheria!" Adora shouted as everyone raised their arms and cheered. "Except for first we have to plan!" She said with her hand still in the air. The group let out a less than eager cheer.

"To the meeting room!"

"Actually, I'd rather just sleep." Mermista said boredly.

"That is also a thing we need to do. To the beds!" Adora exclaimed and Glimmer quickly found the other princesses a place to sleep until the morning, Catra and Adora walked in the direction of their room, and Bow went wherever he went during the nights. Scorpia made her way to her room and went to sleep quickly, no longer as anxious about everything they had to do in the morning.

.

<u>Bow</u>

It was nearly 1 o'clock in the morning when everybody finally headed to bed as per Mermista's statement. It had been one heck of a day. He could hardly remember anything that happened before he spoke to Catra about herself. When he was finished with that, he was constructing new arrows as he was running somewhat low. When finished with the 10th arrow, Glimmer suddenly appeared, saying that he had to come with her

immediately. Upon arriving he saw Mermista and Frosta hanging out in Glimmer's room, which was very unexpected.

Glimmer had forced him to explain how Catra and Scorpia ended up at Bright Moon and why they were able to trust them. He started with the story of how Catra had run into Adora at the First One ruin and as they were trapped in there, they kind of made up and Catra agreed to join the Rebellion.

Then they all decided to take a trip to Mystacor so that Catra could absorb all the new stuff, like Adora had to, and they arrived back at Bright Moon to see they had captured Scorpia, who had just snuck in, looking for Catra. Scorpia had helped him with that story. He didn't tell them about exactly how Scorpia felt about Catra, since she didn't really bring anything related to that up at all. Bow respected that.

Continuing on, he told them about how the two had helped them several times in their advances against the Horde; Catra had a personal grudge since they banished her, and Scorpia was too loyal to Catra to do anything bad. Frosta was suspicious of this because of her actions at Princess Prom but didn't express it all that much except for a few offhand comments. Scorpia didn't seem to take it personally and Catra didn't seem to even be paying attention so there was no conflict.

So, the gist of it was: Catra banished; Adora meet Catra; Catra join Rebellion; Scorpia like Catra; Scorpia join Rebellion; other things happen. **(a\n: congration i just recapped the whole story)**

Once they were finished with all that, the planning began, yet there wasn't much of it. That's why they needed a whole period of time dedicated to just that before any action could take place. That was why Bow woke up at 9am that morning and headed toward the meeting room. Last night before they left on their own ways, they had agreed for the next meetup time would be at 9:15am the next day, and Glimmer had told someone to notify her mom of this, too. It probably wouldn't be the best idea to come

up with some elaborate plan to defeat Bright Moon’s biggest enemy without the Queen’s knowledge.

Bow rounded a corner to see Glimmer, Adora, and Catra walking towards the grand room in the opposite direction of him. The doors were right ahead.

“Hey,” “Morning,” “What’s up?”

Simple greetings. The author didn’t particularly want to write dialogue so that was all they said until all but one chair, Glimmer’s dad’s, were full.

Once everyone had settled, conversations started.

"Thank you for meeting here today, everyone." Angella said. "We are here to discuss final preparations for overthrowing the Horde once and for all."

Preparations began.

Chapter End Notes

> so like it's been like 28272627288239490 years since I updated and it's because I actually wanted to finish this before posting it but I guess not ,, I'll actually try to write a bit more with the new season coming out soon ?? hopefully ??

Planning (part 2)

Chapter Notes

> hahahahahahahahahahaahahahaahhahhaa im a terrible author. im sORRY. This isn't even a full chapter ffs this is just a continuation of the last one so its only 3k words. The next chapter will come out who knows when,,, im not even promising things anymore just accept slow updates. Theres only a few chapters left of this but one thing i will promise is that I WILL finish this. At some point or another, I WILL complete one story in my goddamn life. It's quarantine what better time to try. so anyways enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

"Thank you for meeting here today, everyone." Angella said. "We are here to discuss final preparations for overthrowing the Horde once and for all."

“As you all know, Scorpia has been sent to the Fright Zone as a rebel spy. I have yet to hear the outcome of this mission. Scorpia?” Angella gestured to Scorpia to talk.

“Oh! Well, uh, I went there and I *almost* got caught, but I didn’t! Thanks to my super fast thinking skills! Anyways, I kinda panicked and told Shadow Weaver I’d bring Adora back because she hadn’t gotten her memory back and still viewed the princesses as a threat and wanted to come back home more than anything. To be sure I was telling the truth, I promised I’d bring Adora in the next few days…”

There was a brief moment of silence before the Queen spoke up. “Oh. So we must hurry then.”

“You think it’s a good plan?” Glimmer asked hesitantly, eyeing Catra who was sitting slumped down in a chair with her arms

folded over her chest.

“Yes, I do.” Angella said. “It is the only plan we have gotten in a very long time and I do believe with the help of our newest recruits, we can make this work. We must.”

Adora and Glimmer looked at each other and half smiled. Catra hadn’t had any reaction. It was clear that she still didn’t fully agree with this idea.

“So, what will Adora be doing while at the Fright Zone?” Angella asked openly. No one answered at first, still not completely sure of themselves.

“Uhm, well, we were thinking that she could pretend to fight on their side until we could set up an ambush.” Perfuma started.

“Or she could just kinda mess stuff up, while not actually doing much.” Mermista continued, reiterating the plans they had come up with the night prior.

“She could mess with their tech!” Entrapta said excitedly.

“And stop the Black Garnet from being rebuilt!” Bow added.

“I could set a distraction to allow you all to come in without them realizing so that they would be completely unprepared for an attack.” Adora said.

“A sabotage mission. That might just work.” Glimmer’s mom said.

“Might?” Glimmer added. “It will work. We’ll make sure it works, right Adora?” The princess She-Ra nodded determinedly.

“Alright, dear. Now, what is our plan of attack?”

“Surprise attack!” Frosta shouted.

“Take down Shadow Weaver. For good.” Everyone looked over at the source of this idea. This was the first thing Catra had said the

whole time since the night before. She hadn’t even said a word to Adora after they had gone to their rooms to go to sleep.

Catra didn’t cower at the attention this time. “We take down Shadow Weaver, and Hordak, for good. That’s how we win.” She continued with a very serious tone. It was obvious she wanted revenge for everything that had happened to her while in the Horde. And right now, that was as good a reason as any to try and defeat them.

For good.

.

Catra

Catra’s motivation had stayed the same all her life. She wanted to win, and now she finally had the chance. There was nothing that would stop her now.

The meeting had finished with plans for Adora to leave Bright Moon that afternoon. That didn't leave all too much time to do anything beforehand. Catra followed closely behind Adora, Glimmer, and Bow, none of which had opted to say a word since they had left the meeting room.

Soon, the four of them ended up in Glimmer's bedroom. The sun was out of view from her large circular window, meaning it was at least noon, if not well past it. The mission would begin to take action in only a few hours. That left almost no time to spend with Adora and her friends before she was gone again. Until she left her, again.

"Adora," Catra said as soon as they all walked in, "can we talk? Alone?" she grabbed her hand and walked her outside of Glimmer's room, leaving her and Bow standing there. Catra could see their eyes meet before she closed the door behind her.

She led Adora around a corner and stopped, turning to face her.

"Adora, are you sure about this? Like, really sure?" She asked in a harsh whisper.

"Catra, I'm fine. Can't you just trust me?"

"Yeah, but what if you're caught? There's no reason to keep you around anymore if you're *just* some princess who *always* is able to foil Shadow Weaver's plans. She'll kill you!"

"I'm not gonna get caught, Catra. I can take care of myself! Didn't you *just* say you wanted to take down Shadow Weaver?"

"Not if it means losing you too!" Catra hesitated as Adora stared at her. "I- you can't just *leave me again.* I just got you back, Adora." She said quieter.

Adora's eyebrows furrowed. "I never *left you* , Catra. I asked you to come with me. And you refused. That's your own choice." She had her arms thrown out to her sides as she yelled. "I left the Horde. You're just- you're being selfish, Catra! This could save Etheria!"

"I'm not being selfish!" Catra retorted. "You're being reckless! You won't even have the sword. And- and if you *fail* ? There's no chance for the Rebellion without She-Ra. And there'd be no reason for me to stay here. Better go off to the winning side, don't you think?"

"Catra, how long did I keep myself out of trouble *without* She-Ra. I was raised as a soldier. I'm capable of protecting myself!"

"Adora-"

Adora put a hand up. "No. Save it!" She snapped. "This is going to work, *with or without* your approval, okay?" She turned her back. "I have something I need to do before I leave, so *bye.* " She began walking away.

Catra put an arm out to grab her but hesitated and chose to watch her disappear around another corner.

Once she knew Adora was out of range, Catra groaned loudly and covered her face with her hands while sliding down the wall behind her. All she wanted to do was keep her safe. She knew she made the wrong decision early on when she chose to stay at the Horde rather than going with Adora. She knew that she made mistakes, that she was a mistake.

Why *would* she care? It only made sense not to.

"Girlfriend troubles?" A voice said, knocking Catra out of her thoughts.

"She's not my girlfriend." Catra responded, not bothering to look up to see who the voice belonged to.

"Could've fooled me." She heard whoever it was sit down against the wall next to her. Catra felt a hand on her shoulder and she finally lifted her head from her knees. Sitting beside her was a darker skinned woman with short pale blue hair. She recognized her as one of the princesses that was always at the meetings, but didn't really talk much. She'd never seen her alone before, as she was practically attached at the hip to the pink one.

"Wanna talk about it?"

"Not really." Catra said. "Who are you again?"

The princess chuckled. "Oh, yeah. I guess we never formally met. I'm Netossa."

"Catra."

"Soooo, what's going on with you and Adora?" Netossa continued, ignoring the *not really* from just a few seconds ago.

"Absolutely nothing." She replied immediately, out of instinct, then sighed. "...A lot of things, actually…" Netossa stayed quiet, prompting Catra to keep going.

"Ugh she's not listening to me! And- and she's so overwhelmingly clueless it's hard to be around her sometimes. She doesn't even- It doesn't make any sense! How could a person *not* know what basic things in life are?"

A moment of silence passed before the older princess responded. "Well, I think she's listening to you loud and clear. I heard y'all arguing about the mission she's leaving for tonight, yeah?" Catra nodded. "I know I'd probably feel the same way if Spinnerella was going on a risky mission like that. Adora is listening, but she can't agree, not when what she's doing could save the world."

"But what if she doesn't?"

"Nothing can get done if you never leave your comfort zone. The chance of failure is always there but doing nothing could have worse consequences." Netossa explained. "She's doing this partly for you; so you two could live in a war free world. You want to beat the Horde, yeah?"

Catra nodded again. "Well, yeah, but there's got to be a better way." She urged.

"War is like that. This is our safest plan at the time being. There is a very high chance that it will go well."

"Nothing ever goes well for me." Catra murmured, putting her chin back on her knees.

"Listen, girl, I don't know Adora that well, but I do know that she is strong. She wouldn't let anything happen to her and we won't either. We're getting daily reports from Scorpia and Adora will have a direct communication method in case anything happens. She's strong, and hey, so are you. Now, I know *I'm* ready to kick Horde ass, how 'bout you?"

The corner of Catra's mouth twitched up in a small smile.

"'S what I thought. Y'know I bet I could take down more bots and soldiers than you." Netossa smirked as she stood up.

“Uh, no way!” Catra all but jumped to her feet, tail swishing behind her, but the smile on her face was completely evident now.

“Hmm, I don’t know…”

“Oh you’re *on* !”

“Bet.” Netossa said before she walked away. Catra bit her lip and ran in the opposite direction before leaping out a window onto a nearby tree, opting to hop through the trees for a while. She was certainly in a better mood and, she’d never admit it, but it was nice making new friends who she could *obliterate.* Not literally, of course.

Catra was reminded of the fun competitions she and Adora used to have back in the Fright Zone. Races, games, even arm wrestling. Those were good times. She just hoped she hadn’t ruined her chances of that again in the future.

.

Adora

Adora had been curious all day about these secrets Entrapta had told her about. Apparently there was something that Light Hope was hiding from her and she had no idea. It would have altered her trust if she wasn't just a computer, so she could have been programmed not to tell. Whatever Entrapta did hopefully didn't mess anything up.

She left for the Whispering Woods right after her fight with Catra, only given a short amount of time before she needed to go to the Fright Zone. She felt bad but there was nothing she could do now.

She stepped up to the Crystal Castle, anxiety bubbling in her. She shook her head. Whatever this secret was couldn't be too bad, right? It's not like she would've been told that she was to be used as a weapon to destroy other planets in the universe and all they needed was Scorpia to connect to her runestone before the

weapon was engaged and ended the world as they knew it. Yeah. It'll be fine.

"Eternia." The entrance opened and Adora walked in.

The writing on the walls lit up as she passed them and she continued until she reached the giant room where the hologram lived.

She stepped up onto the podium in the center and only hesitated for a moment.

"...Light Hope?"

The image of a tall woman appeared, her back facing Adora.

"Mara?" Light Hope turned around, a mildly confused look on her face.

Mara?

"No, you are not Mara, you are Adora. Hello, Adora." She said. Her features seemed softer; less… computer-like.

"Light Hope..?" Adora repeated. She was definitely different, not the usual stiff robotic artificial intelligence she had gotten used to. She seemed to have… *personality.* Was this something that Entrapta did?

"Adora, I must tell you something. I am not the Light Hope you know. I had been automatically reprogrammed to create the perfect She-Ra and prevent any distractions from stopping me. At whatever cost."

"Cost? What do you mean cost?"

"As a First One, you are different from the rest of the beings on Etheria today. The technology available to us allowed me to remove certain aspects of your personality. And I am sorry."

" *What?* Something's… missing." That's when she realized.

What was the one thing she wasn't able to understand, no matter how much it was explained to her? What was the one thing she couldn't feel? What was the one thing that everybody else knew about, except for her? That stupid word that everyone kept saying.

Love?

What is that?

People kept trying to explain it to me.

But I couldn't understand.

Both were silent for a few moments before Adora broke it. "...Can I do anything about it?"

"No," Light Hope began and Adora's face dropped, "but my program can." Adora's face lit up again.

"Once you walk out of this castle, your sensation of love will be returned."

"Really?... But wait, what happened to *you* ? Entrapta did something and you're… different." Adora said. She was curious.

"I have been restored to my previous update. To before Mara…" She didn't have to finish.

"You two were close, then?" The blonde asked.

"Close." Light Hope repeated. "Yes, I suppose we were. She had called me her… friend."

"Can you tell me what happened to her? Why did she strand us in the Despondos Dimension?"

"She was attempting to stop the Heart of Etheria Project from destroying the planets in the surrounding systems."

“The… Heart of Etheria Project?” Adora had heard something about this before but was never sure as to what it was.

“The Heart of Etheria is a project to bring peace throughout the universe assembled by the First Ones. She-Ra’s function was to carry out the project; as it was mine. But Mara saw through the initial plans and found out the First One’s had malicious intents and would try to stop it any way she could. I would have helped her had my systems not been updated at the time of her discovery. Mara sacrificed herself to save the universe. I will no longer allow the Heart of Etheria to be accessed.”

Adora could hardly believe anything the hologram was telling her. Whatever Entrapta had done must’ve been good if this Heart of Etheria Project is suddenly a huge concern of Light Hope. She couldn’t even imagine if Light Hope had let it continue and would set it off again, using She-Ra as a weapon. Good thing that didn’t happen, right? *Right* ?

It hadn’t even occurred to her how long she’d been talking with Light Hope. It almost seemed like she was catching up with an old friend. When she was finished, she was determined to only use She-Ra when necessary. If her original function was to be a weapon, Adora did not want to abuse that power. Light Hope had also told her where she’d come from; she had been pulled through a portal by the First One’s program to carry out that exact function in the future. She was glad all of that was over.

As she stepped foot out of the old castle ruin, she remembered why she came there in the first place. A rush of… she didn’t even know what, hit her as she started back to Bright Moon to tell her friends, and especially Catra, what had just happened.

The journey back seemed longer than usual but before she knew it, the Bright Moon Palace had come into view. She continued down the path until she saw a few people sitting out in front, one of which was Scorpia. Was it that time already?

She knew she needed to talk to Catra before she left for the Fright Zone so she started walking faster than she had been but there was no time. Catra, Glimmer, and Bow must have still been inside when some guards told her that she had to leave immediately to make it to the Fright Zone before dusk.

“But, can’t I go inside for one second?”

“No, miss, I’m sorry but you must leave now.”

It was dumb, but Adora decided to argue no further. With one last glance at the kingdom, she was whisked away toward the Fright Zone with Scorpia.

.

Scorpia

Scorpia sat on a skiff, the day’s moon hanging low in the sky **(a/n: Noelle said theres no sun so thats all i got lmao)** . She and Adora had been scheduled to leave five minutes ago. Where is she?

The moment that thought passed her mind, she saw Adora jog out of the Whispering Woods and head in her direction.

As she approached, a guard that was standing near Scorpia spoke up. “Princess Adora, there you are, you must leave immediately for your mission in order to arrive at the Fright Zone before dusk. The Sword of Protection will be safely escorted to your living quarters.”

Adora pulled the sword off her back and handed it to the guard. “But, can’t I go inside for one second?”

“No, miss, I’m sorry but you must leave now.”

Adora huffed but didn’t push further. She stepped onto the skiff that Scorpia had taken from the Fright Zone and leaned against

the back. Scorpia started the engine and the machine started moving in the direction of the Fright Zone.

One minute of awkward silence later, Scorpia decided to try some small talk. “So, nice weather out there today, right?”

“Scorpia, we’ll be okay, right?” Adora said in response. “I mean, the both of us have to act like we’re on the side we’re totally against. I’m pretty sure I can keep it up, but, to be honest, you don’t seem like the best liar or actor to me..”

“What? I’m a *fantastic* liar!” She said, sweat forming on her forehead.

“I hope so.”

Both didn’t speak for the next few moments. “Adora, are you alright?” Scorpia asked the blonde who was downcast and folding her arms over her chest. She wasn’t ever like that from what she’s seen of her, in Bright Moon and the Fright Zone, too. Her bubbly personality was one of her biggest traits aside from *hard-worker* and *confident* . She didn’t appear to have any of those right now.

“I’m… fine.” She said and stood up, looking ahead of her instead of to the side. “I just really needed to see Catra before I left but…”

“Did something happen?”

“It’s just- earlier we got in a fight and… if she’s right and I don’t make it back and this mission fails then that’s the last thing I would have said to her…” She looked like she wanted to say more but Scorpia didn’t push it.

“You’ll be okay.” She said. “You got this!”

“I hope so.” She said again and sighed.

The rest of the trip had no more conversation and Scorpia focused on getting them to where they were going before it got dark. She

really hoped everything would go right for her. She was counting on it.

Chapter End Notes

so thats uh that. yeah. uhhhhh,,, i put in some canon s4 stuff just for fun and I added some of the things Noelle was saying in the 15 questions thing like netossa being friends with catra. i hope she wasn't too out of character. I also know i didn't really put a real plan in there so i guess just see how it plays out in real time. and i know i literally left bow and glimmer standing in a room for the whole chapter so one of thems gonna have the first pov next chapter! ive had people tell me that there isn't enough catradora in this fic but like i physically have to write plot or else nothing will ever happen. i promise theres a bunch coming up! i feel evil for doing the whole 'their last conversation was a fight before she left' but i needed angst. yeah. ANYWAYS im SCARED for season 5 why can't may 15 come sooner???? ahhhh I hope you like this!!

~A

Too Perfect?

Chapter Notes

> wowie looks like I updated in less than 3 months this time, how exciting. Honestly, people yelling at me in the comments sometimes actually helps me get motivation to write lmao and I got several of those on wattpad. anyways, this is a full length chapter finally and i think the majority of it is just Adora's POV but like yeah. There is one chapter left of this story and I hope to get it out as soon as possible, but i also have to write 4 essays for school within the next month so idk how long it will take. anyways enjoy !! :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bow

A few hours earlier, Catra had left Glimmer's room dragging Adora with her. He was pretty sure he knew what they were going to talk about. He and Glimmer stood staring at the door for a few seconds after they had left. Neither of them had said a word since the meeting ended. The silence stretched on for a few more moments, which had felt a lot longer to Bow, until Glimmer sighed. Bow turned his attention to his best friend standing next to him.

"Catra's right, this is really dangerous." Glimmer said and Bow prepared a response.

"I'm worried about Scorpia."

"I'm worried about Adora."

The two said simultaneously, Glimmer looking up at Bow afterwards. "Scorpia?"

Bow put a hand to the back of his neck. "Well, yeah," he said, voice cracking, "from what she told us, she almost blew her cover

the first time she went, what's stopping her from accidentally doing it again? And, to be honest, she doesn't really seem like the best actress…"

Glimmer thought about this for a second before cringing. She sighed again. "Ugh, you're right." She groaned. "Well what I'm worried about is Shadow Weaver treating Adora like shit even if they don't get caught. Adora said Shadow Weaver wasn't the best to her or Catra when they were younger…"

Bow inhaled, not bothering to comment on Glimmer's choice of language considering the situation at hand. "That's true but…"

"But?"

He gathered his thoughts to form a sentence. "Adora is strong, she's dealt with it before, for her whole life. And now she's learned how to stand up for herself. Plus, Shadow Weaver tried so hard to get her back, I doubt she'd do anything to jeopardize that, and make Adora defect again." He explained.

"Ugh, you're right, again. Why are you always right?" She sighed a third time. "During the meeting, I was almost hoping my mom would disagree with this plan so we didn't have to go through with it, but I guess she and Adora have the same mindset."

"Honestly same." Bow said, sitting down on the bench by Glimmer's window. Glimmer followed suit. "Well, worrying about it isn't gonna do us any good, is it? Surely if Adora believes she can do it, we should too?"

"Yeah…" Glimmer said. "I believe she can do it, but the Fright Zone is like, a terrible place. I wouldn't ever want to go back there. And what about Scorpia, like you said?"

"We gotta believe in her, too." He encouraged both Glimmer and himself. "Yeah, they'll be fine! I don't doubt that for a second. This *will* work."

Glimmer ran her hands through her hair and stood up determinately. “Yes. It will.” She said, mostly to herself than to Bow, looking straight ahead of her. “We should talk to Adora before she leaves though.”

“Yeah, you’re right.” He paused. “Uh, where is she?” How long was this chat with Catra taking?

“She went with Catra, but they should be done by now, it’s been like 20 minutes.” She gasped and smiled evilly. “Maybe they’re making out!”

“Glimmer-”

“We should just wait for her here! It’ll be easier for her to find us that way.” Glimmer jabbed a pointer finger in the air and then shrugged, going back to her bench and laying on it, taking up the whole thing.

There she stayed for the next half hour without any sign of Adora. Bow had taken refuge on a plush chair near her as they talked about random things. The conversation had taken a turn to Bow’s family, whom he didn’t talk about that much, and he changed the subject.

“Um, shouldn’t Adora be back by now?”

“Oh, yeah,” Glimmer said as if she forgot about her, “we should probably go look for her? When does she leave for the Horde?”

Bow pulled out his tracker pad, which also displayed the time. 2:59 PM. “About an hour.” He said. “Yeah, let’s go find her.” He stood up and headed for the door, Glimmer following, when said door started creaking open. A certain cat girl’s head peeked in. She opened the door fully upon seeing the two and did a quick scan of the room.

“Where’s Adora?”

.

Catra

Catra's run through the forest lasted about an hour, twenty minutes of which were spent snoozing in a tree not far from Bright Moon. After successfully clearing her head, Catra was ready to go find Adora and talk. She hope she'd get it right this time so that their last conversation before Adora left for a week wouldn't end up being an argument.

She decided to walk the path and enter through the front doors instead of leaping into Glimmer's window like she usually did, maybe her unconscious self's way of saying *you need a little more time to think.* She fixed together a string of words in her head so she wouldn't accidentally lash out again and focused on calming her breathing.

She didn't really know why this was such a big deal for her. Sure, they had fights before. A lot of them. But this was different somehow. She couldn't quite place it.

As she walked up to the main entrance to the castle, she noticed one of the guards was staring her down. Wasn't too strange, as she'd been the Horde's second-in-command only a short time ago. She deserved the distrust, but secretly hoped she could win it from the people of the rebellion some day. How far she had come; the moment she left the Horde, *ahem, I'm sorry,* was kicked out of the Horde, she had vowed to never to be part of any side of the war again. But then, Adora, oh Adora, stepped in and managed to change her mind. She was always able to do that. Catra wondered why her flawless persuasion skills hadn't worked on her sooner. And now here she was, hoping to gain trust and make friends with the people who were once her enemies.

Of course it was Adora. She was the only reason Catra even considered it. Had anyone else been trapped in that place with her, well, she had no idea how that would've gone. Adora was special. She couldn't deny that any further. She's *the chosen one,* the born leader. Catra was always following in her footsteps. It wasn't until recently that she accepted the fact that she could

never live up to those standards, she just wasn't built like that. The only question that ever crossed her mind about that was, *why* does *Adora keep me around? It's not like I'm worth anything…*

Deep in thought, Catra had nearly walked past Glimmer's room, which was her destination in the first place. If Adora had gone anywhere, it was probably here. She slowly pushed one of the doors open and peeked inside, seeing Bow and Glimmer standing near her. Opening the door completely, she looked around. Adora wasn't here.

"Where's Adora?" She asked.

"I thought she was with you?" Glimmer replied.

"She was but- she left to go somewhere a while ago and- i need to talk to her…"

"Your guess is as good as mine." Sparkles said and shrugged.

"We were just about to go looking for her, if you want to come?" Bow asked.

Catra pursed her lips. "Yeah, sure." She said, following the two as they left the room.

First stop was the bedroom Adora and Catra shared. It was right down the hall from Glimmer's but Catra doubted she'd be in there. She wasn't one to hang out in her room, alone, but it didn't hurt to check. Obviously though, she wasn't there. The room was empty, lit only by the light from the window. Adora's bed sat against the back wall and Catra's, still ripped and mangled, it's not like anyone was sleeping in it, was against the wall to their left. With nothing left to see, the three closed the door and headed down the hall further towards the mess hall. As it was right in the middle of lunch and dinner, they found no one in there except for the kitchen staff. Moving along, they nearly passed the throne room before Glimmer disappeared in a flash of light, leaving her *glitter* behind.

“Huh?” Catra looked over at Bow who shrugged just before the doors behind them slammed open. Catra jumped, startled, but recovered as she turned around to see Glimmer standing in the open doorway.

“Ughhhhhh. Adora’s in the woods. Training probably.” She said and put a hand on Catra and Bow’s shoulders before they all disappeared and ended up back in Glimmer’s room. Catra shivered. She’d never get used to that.

“Training? Now?” Bow asked, continuing the conversation as if nothing had happened.

“I guess. My mom said she saw her leave like an hour ago.”

“Wait wait, in the woods? Can’t we just… go find her?” Catra asked.

“She trains in an old First One’s ruin that we can’t get into. It’s the place she found you in after you left the Horde.” Bow answered.

“ *I didn’t leave*- but, yeah okay.” She said, not sure why she was still defending the point about her being kicked out, though it may have been because it was the one thing that pushed her over the edge; the final reason that she wanted to get revenge for everything that had happened to her back there. “What do we do now?” She crossed her arms and shifted her weight onto one leg.

“Now,” Glimmer said, straight up dropping to the floor in a cross-legged position, “we wait.”

Catra looked down at her and then over at Bow who had started walking over to a chair to sit down, then back at Glimmer again. A choked sound came from her throat. “Are you serious?”

Glimmer moved her eyes to the right, and then back at Catra. “...Yeah?”

Catra groaned. “I’m going to the roof.” She said heading over to the window.

“No, stay!” Glimmer exclaimed.

“Huh?” She whipped her head around. Glimmer had gotten to her feet.

“I wanna talk.” She explained.

“Why?” Catra asked and Glimmer deadpanned. “Ughh, fine.” She leaned against a pillar that protruded through the wall on the right side of Glimmer’s window.

She stared at Glimmer, who was silent for a few moments, wordlessly telling her that she was not planning on starting the conversation. Glimmer briefly looked over at Bow, who was sat in a large armchair on the opposite side of the window that Catra was.

“What happened when you and Adora left?” She finally asked. Catra mentally groaned, figuring she’d done it out loud too many times in the last five minutes. Of course Glimmer wanted to know what happened. She was their professional stalker after all.

“Adora again?” Catra snarled. Big boy Bow came in and saved the day.

“Okay, how about we talk about you?” He said. It wasn’t much better than talking about Adora, but she reluctantly agreed.

“What about me?”

“I don’t know, anything? We still don’t know a lot about you.” Catra just glared at him. “Uh, how about your childhood?”

“Didn’t we already have this conversation?” Catra sighed.

“Well, yeah, but you didn’t really say much?”

“I didn’t? I remember otherwise.”

“So you really don’t know anything about where you came from?” Bow asked, ignoring her.

“No! We went over this.” Catra really didn’t like talking about her past; there were too many bad memories and also missing memories. She didn’t remember much from before she was 8 years old, only small things, like the one memory played in that building in the first chapter, when she and Adora were harassing Octavia for fun. And, of course, *every single time* that Shadow Weaver had abused her. Those were always super fun to look back on, *she said sarcastically.*

“Well, what about that dream? Anything new with that?” Bow asked, interrupting Catra’s flow of thought. The dream. She’d forgotten about that.

“Dream?” Glimmer asked, finally taking a part in the conversation that she wanted to start.

Catra rubbed her hands down her face. “I had a dream back in that magic place about some lady who said she was my mom or whatever. And no, nothing new, it’s probably not important.” She answered both their questions. It was true, there hadn’t been anything else related to that. All her dreams these days were playbacks of Fright Zone memories or something random with Adora involved, that is if she could remember them. “Can we stop talking about this?”

Catra saw Glimmer and Bow eye each other with a look she couldn’t identify. An aura of silence surrounded them until Glimmer cleared her throat.

“So what happened with Adora earlier?” She said, ever the stalker. Catra bit the inside of her cheek.

“If I tell you will you leave me alone?” She said looking anywhere but the practically glowing princess before her.

“Yep! Promise!” Catra nearly flinched at *the p word,* still somewhat buried in the past. She sighed for the hundredth time that day.

"...We got into this dumb argument and then she just… left." Catra said staring down at the floor.

" *So not making out then.* " She heard Glimmer whisper.

"What did you say?!"

"A-and that upset you?" Bow said over the two of them, bringing the conversation back to its purpose. Catra moved her gaze away from Glimmer after a few seconds and shifted her eyes back to the floor.

"...Yeah, obviously." She murmured.

Bow stood up and took a few steps toward her. "You really *do* love her, don't you." He said leaning over a little in an attempt to see Catra's face.

" *I do not*- I- I-" She immediately snapped her head up and got defensive, and awfully red-faced. She exhaled. What was the point anymore. She lowered her eyes again. "Yeah, you're right…" She said in a near whisper. She could *hear* the kingdom's princess light up.

" *Not. A. Word.* " She said sternly, still blushing, pointing straight into Glimmer's face.

Glimmer just hummed in response. Before anyone could say anything else, a loud beeping startled all three of them. Bow grabbed his tablet thing as it flashed and silenced the noise.

"That's Adora!" He said. "She is scheduled to leave… right now! Let's grab her before she goes!"

Glimmer grabbed onto the others and teleported right to the front doors of the castle. Catra could see Scorpia setting up a skiff for their ride with several guards waiting there to see them off, but Adora was nowhere to be seen.

She looked over and saw Bow and Glimmer coming to the same conclusion.

“She’s not here?” Glimmer said, voicing their thoughts.

“Obviously.” Catra mumbled.

“She’ll be here soon, we should just wait.” Bow suggested.

“I’m tired of waiting…” Catra rolled her eyes. That’s when Scorpia walked up to them.

“Hey, is Adora with you?” She asked.

“Nope, we were just looking for her.” Glimmer said.

“Welp.” Scorpia turned around and sat down on the skiff’s floor, presumably doing the same thing they were; waiting.

A minute passed. “Where the fuck is she?” Catra said, followed by a half-hearted, “language,” from Bow, who had sat down on the steps of the castle. He seemed tired.

Another minute later was enough for Catra. “Okay, that’s it.” She said and started walking back into the castle.

“Ever heard of patience?” Bow asked, looking up from his spot on the stairs.

“Nope!” Catra exclaimed and headed straight to her room. She could barely hear a grunt and some sparkles as Glimmer teleported her and Bow up to catch up with Catra.

“They’ll probably call us when she gets here, if she ever gets here…” Glimmer sighed out. “I’m gonna take a nap.”

“Sounds like a good plan to me.” Catra said.

“Mhm.”

They waited for a call in the safety of Adora and Catra's room that never came. The three were dead asleep when a guard had come in with the Sword of Protection and laid it on the table next to her bed. Guess they missed their chance. Oh well.

.

Scorpia

The familiarity of the Fright Zone began to appear along the horizon as the two former Horde soldiers exitted the edge of the Whispering Woods nearest to their destination. It didn't take long for the skiff to come shuddering to a stop right at the entrance at the vehicle's bay. With the skiff parked and ready for later use, Scorpia saw Adora take a deep breath before jumping off, Scorpia following.

The entrance door slid open with a metallic screech and the first thing they saw was a suspicious Force Captain Lonnie standing on the other side with her arms crossed.

"Heya, Scorpia." She said dryly and sent a glare in Adora's direction. "Adora."

Scorpia managed a smile and Adora stepped closer to Lonnie.

"Lonnie, good to see you." She said in a somewhat relieved tone.

"Is it?" Lonnie asked.

"Honestly, yeah. Princesses are *so annoying* . You have no idea." Adora lied. Scorpia just nodded.

Lonnie *mhm* 'ed and turned down the hallway behind her. "C'mon, Shadow Weaver wants to see you." She said and started walking, not even looking to see if they were following. Scorpia and Adora met eyes momentarily and followed after her in the direction of Hordak's sanctum.

When they got there, it looked the same as it was when Scorpia had gone before. A portion of the large room was sectioned off for Shadow Weaver to do her work, whatever that was, and the rest of it was just as dark and spooky as ever. Lonnie had left them there and there were a few moments of awkward silence.

“Shadow Weaver?” Adora called in a confident voice as the sorceress was nowhere to be seen. It didn’t take long for her chilling voice to echo from the shadows.

“ *Adora.* How nice of you to join us.” Shadow Weaver said and emerged from the darkness.

“Shadow Weaver.” Adora said again.

If Adora had any kind of fear, she didn’t show it. Scorpia actually hadn’t expected her to be this good of an actress. It almost seemed like she actually hadn’t regained her memories and was exactly like Scorpia had described her as when she returned to the Fright Zone the first time.

“Tell me, what happened while you were in rebel territory?”

Adora took no time at all to respond. “The princesses attempted to revert me to their side. They fed me lies and tried to convince me I was a princess. I didn’t listen to them, just like you taught me.” She paused and sighed. “I’m sorry I managed to get captured- it won’t happen again.” She said rigidly. It was believable, very much so. Scorpia nearly had to remind herself what had actually happened.

Shadow Weaver walked up to Adora and put her hand to Adora’s cheek. She stared at her for a few seconds, checking for sincerity, most likely. Adora’s act seemed to convince her. This almost seemed too easy.

“Very well.” Shadow Weaver said and turned to Scorpia. “Well done, Force Captain.”

Scorpia wasn’t as good at hiding her fear. She never had been, even when with the Horde so she hoped it wasn’t too suspicious. She saluted and tried for a small smile. She was the friendly one of the Fright Zone, she had to act a little bit like it, even if she was preparing for at any moment to be found out and attacked or imprisoned.

“Adora,” Shadow Weaver said, “you may return to the Force Captain barracks. Your room should be prepared for you.” Adora responded with what looked like a genuine smile and nodded before leaving for the barracks.

“Force Captain Scorpia, you have proven yourself. Is there any news of the Rebellion I should be made aware about?”

“Uh, no, not really. They’re kinda just in distress because they lost She-Ra.” She chuckled nervously and put her claw up to the back of her neck. She hoped this wasn’t too out of character for her. It’d really suck if she blew their cover right now after that apparent success by Adora.

Shadow Weaver nodded. "Remember that you are not to talk about Adora's true past with the princesses. An announcement has already been made to the entirety of the Fright Zone." She explained ominously.

"Of course! Yes!" Scorpia answered. “I should probably head back soon, though… wouldn’t want them to wonder why I’m gone for so long.” She explained, hoping to get out of there as quick as possible.

“Very well.” She said again. “I expect not to be disappointed, Force Captain.” The slits in her mask narrowed slightly.

“Oh no, do not worry, Shadow Weaver.” Scorpia said with obvious hesitation. Shadow Weaver looked at her for a few more moments, each second Scorpia’s anxiety doubling.

“Go on then.” Shadow Weaver said finally.

“Right!” Scorpia exclaimed way too loudly. “Okay, uh, bye!” She said as she exited the room, letting out a breath as soon as the large door closed behind her.

She elected to check in with Adora quickly before heading back to Bright Moon.

Adora was exactly where Shadow Weaver had sent her; a smart idea, to follow orders to gain trust. The old Adora would always follow orders unless it involved Catra, from what Scorpia knew of her.

She found her in her room at the Force Captain barracks laying on the bed and staring at the ceiling. She hardly even noticed when Scorpia looked into the room until she said something.

"Adora." The blonde shot up in the bed and looked in Scorpia's direction. Scorpia recoiled slightly from accidentally surprising her. "Uh, hi. I was just… checking in, y'know…" She laughed nervously. "Are you okay?" She whispered.

"Never better." Adora said flatly and collapsed back onto the bed.

"Okay! Just to let you know, everyone has been told to act as if you were never She-Ra, cool? Cool. Well, I'm leaving, so, uh, bye!" Scorpia said and practically ran out of the room back towards the vehicle bay.

Back to Bright Moon she went.

.

<u>Adora</u>

It was weird, being back at the Fright Zone, not as a prisoner or just sneaking in. Well, weird was an understatement. It’d been a very long time since she laid on a bed and looked at something other than the canopy of her bed in Bright Moon. The rusted greens of the ceiling above her brought her mind back to her

history with this place. Everything she'd been through; so many memories.

Scorpia had come and gone. She seemed jumpy, as usual, and again she hoped that everything would go as planned.

It was late already so curfew had already been called, and Adora hadn't seen anyone else that night. Even if she had, from Scorpia's news, it wouldn't have made a difference since everyone pretended she never left in the first place. It was weird to think about. If she hadn't gotten her memories back, would she have bought this charade from… everyone?

She sighed and turned over to her side, deciding to get some rest. It was going to be a long week.

**

The first night wasn't as hard as Adora imagined. She found it easy to fall asleep in a bed very similar to the ones she grew up with. The only thing different was Catra's absence. She had gotten used to sleeping in the same bed as her again, and now that was taken away again.

The blaring morning alarm surprised her slightly, however, because she had gotten used to waking up naturally. For a second upon waking up, she panicked and forgot where she was or why she was there. Otherwise, getting back into the routine of things wasn't all that hard.

On the first day, she didn't have too much to do. Just a lot of basic Force Captain duties that the author has no idea how to describe.

Midday, she went to go eat lunch. She definitely hadn't missed the tasteless ration bars that they had been forced to eat their entire lives. Food in Bright Moon was much better.

While she ate, she noticed people giving her suspicious looks, something she probably wouldn't have noticed had she actually

lost her memory. Not many people talked to her, but that wasn't too different from her childhood. The only person she really talked to was Catra.

Later on, she ended up doing something with her old team, Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio. All three were obviously acting strange around Adora, but she just pretended not to notice. She could be pretty dense, she knew, and had started realizing more and more after her experience with Light Hope.

They all still let her act as team leader, just because that's how it always had been. With Adora returning as Force Captain, she thought Lonnie might lose her rank, but with Force Captain Scorpia spending most of her time at Bright Moon. It still seemed as if Adora was the higher up around here.

Some awkward conversation happened between the four of them (well, three, and some dragon grunts from Rogelio) before Lonnie ended it.

"I have to go and do my work in the Black Garnet chamber. See you guys." She started to leave but Adora had an idea.

"Hey Lonnie?" She asked. "Do you think I could help you with the Black Garnet?"

She gave her another suspicious look. "Since when do you know anything about tech?" She asked and crossed her arms.

"Actually, I picked up a lot of random information on runestones from one of the princesses, Entrapta, who was being held in the same room as me." Adora cringed at the 'memory' for special effect. "She's this insane science geek and she wouldn't stop rambling into a recorder while working on something. Eventually I started listening in, in case any of what she was saying could be useful." She explained. If she had never been She-Ra, she wouldn't know Entrapta at all, let alone the fact that she stayed at the Horde for a period of time. She hoped her own rambling

wasn't too much a giveaway that something was up but Lonnie just pursed her lips in response.

"Huh." She said. "Okay, fine, you can help. Don't break anything." She ordered. Adora nodded and started following Lonnie to the Black Garnet chamber, giving a small wave to Kyle and Rogelio as she left.

The two didn't speak until they reached the runestone. There, Lonnie looked at it briefly before turning around to face Adora. "Did the princess say anything about the power source of this thing?"

Adora looked around. Cables and wires littered the ground around the runestone, several attached to the Black Garnet itself. The room was dark with only a dim red glow from the Black Garnet compared to when it had lit up the whole room for the entirety of Adora's childhood. Adora's eyes reached Lonnie again, who was looking at her expectantly.

"Um…" Adora thought back to anything she'd actually heard Entrapta say about runestones. It wasn't much. She didn't necessarily have to tell Lonnie the truth either. She thought up the first thing that came to mind. "I think she said something about the planet powering the runestones and magic and stuff?" She said. That may have been right, she had no idea.

Lonnie furrowed her brows. "That… actually makes a lot more sense than what I was thinking." Adora didn't even bother to ask what Lonnie had originally theorized. "But what about the planet? Do I need to do something? I just don't get it…" She continued to herself.

"So, this thing still doesn't work?" Adora asked.

"No, it works, but machines can only do so much. It has power, but it's way weaker than it used to be." She explained. Adora truthfully had no clue how anything worked so she wouldn't have been able to help even if she wanted to.

"Well, uh, what are you gonna do?" Adora asked as Lonnie squatted down at the base of the Garnet.

"I'm not sure…" She fiddled with a couple of wires connected at the bottom of the runestone. "But, I think I'd rather work on this myself for now." Adora could hear the edge in her voice, obviously she still didn't trust her, but the old Adora wouldn't have noticed.

"Oh, um, are you sure?" She tried. Now was as good a time as any to sabotage the progress of restoring full power.

" *Yes.* " Lonnie replied harshly. Adora pursed her lips.

"Okay, see you then." She said as cheerfully as a Horde soldier could be as she could and turned around and left. Maybe it was for the best. If Lonnie had caught her messing with things, it would have been game over. She still had a whole week to do her work.

Of course, not knowing anything about tech wasn't going to be very helpful because she had no idea what good and what was bad for it. She could accidentally fix something instead of ruining it knowing her. With nothing else in her schedule except dinner later that afternoon, Adora returned to her room.

**

After dinner and another dreamless night's sleep, Adora woke up and got ready for the next day. Everything was just the same as the day before. There weren't any attacks planned for that whole week much to Adora and the Rebellion's convenience. This meant all she had to worry about was continuing to convince everyone in the Fright Zone she was the same person she was before she had found the sword.

More of her time was spent with her old friends and it seemed even Lonnie was beginning to trust her a little. It wasn't much but on the third day back at the Fright Zone, Lonnie had allowed Adora to stay in the Black Garnet chamber while she worked, occasionally asking for her help in things that would be difficult to

do on her own. Every now and then, as discretely as possible, Adora would cut one wire, or burn out another, or undo a couple screws in case anything could actually stop the progress that Lonnie actually seemed to be making. It definitely didn't feel great knowing she was going to betray them all again at the end of the week. It almost led her to consider calling off their final attack.

But that would be a bad idea. Everyone had been counting on her and it seemed the only way to stop the Horde would be a fight. There was no peaceful negotiation with Shadow Weaver or Hordak.

Adora had spent a decent amount of time with Shadow Weaver for the majority of the week and it seemed she quickly became her favorite again. Adora wasn't 100% sure if she was being genuine or not (like, come on, its Shadow Weaver) but it did help with the plan she was set to follow. She tried her best not to be too obvious about messing with things, whether she knew if it was important or not, but if she was caught doing something she shouldn't, she could easily get away with it. It surprised Adora how much people were actually falling for her charade. Maybe it was the fact that the regular Adora would be too dumb to be such a good actor and it just would be impossible for someone like her to be faking all of this.

All she really hoped was that people weren't trying to fool her into thinking they trust her.

Scorpia checked in with her daily after meeting with Shadow Weaver to 'update' her on information about the Rebellion. With Adora, she would make sure everything was going to plan smoothly. For the time being, the mission was perfect. Everything was going exactly as they had wanted it to. Adora noted that there could be a chance that it was *too* perfect and the Horde was planning something in secret of her and Scorpia because they already knew what they were doing. Both really hoped that wasn't the case but Scorpia reminded Adora about her and her friends' talent of improvising. If anything were to happen, they would deal with it.

Scorpia also mentions that Lonnie had spoken to her. Scorpia and Entrapta had been working together on the Black Garnet before they joined the Rebellion, well, re-joined for Entrapta. Lonnie apparently had asked if Scorpia had known about anything that could help with her work. Knowing Scorpia, she'd have even less of a clue how that thing worked than Adora did and she confirmed this. Something they hadn't anticipated was the fact that she would ask Scorpia to ask Entrapta some questions about the runestone to get information when she returned to Bright Moon.

"Obviously she's gonna know what to do, and everyone knows that. What am I supposed to tell her?" Scorpia asked.

"Uhhh, maybe you can ask Entrapta to tell you how to mess it up in a way that it seemed like it was possibly being fixed?" Adora replied. She wasn't sure if her answer even made sense.

"Yeah, yeah she could probably do that…" Adora could tell there was something else she wanted to stay.

"But?"

"But what if they catch on? What if they've already caught on, like you said?" She whispered.

"Everything's gonna be fine." Adora said, more to convince herself than Scorpia.

After Scorpia had brought back the information, Adora noticed Lonnie doing something that looked really complicated while she was in the Black Garnet chamber with her the next day. Of course, Lonnie didn't say anything about getting any information from Scorpia because Adora wouldn't have had any idea that Scorpia and Entrapta had been the ones tinkering with the runestone in the first place.

At first, more progress was seemingly being made and Adora was afraid Entrapta had messed up and accidentally told Scorpia exactly how to fix everything but two days before the attack was planned, something went wrong. Not with Adora, everything was

still going perfect for her, but the Black Garnet seemed to lose even more power. Still having no idea how anything worked, Adora didn't understand where the power even came from, she would try to 'help' which always ended up making things worse. Eventually Lonnie got a bit fed up with the thing and told Adora to leave again.

That evening, Scorpia filled Adora in on what she had told Shadow Weaver that day. As per the plan, Scorpia had told her that the Rebellion was planning an attack on the Fright Zone in 4 weeks. Shadow Weaver seemed to believe her and thanked her again. Once again, Adora was counting on the fact that everything was actually going to plan and not just a ruse from the Horde.

She went to sleep anxiously that night, wishing Catra was there to comfort her.

On her final day, Adora sought to do as much damage as she could without being found out. Everything would end tomorrow.

It had to.

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(in Sea Hawk's voice:) Narration!

"Tomorrow. The rebels are planning to attack first thing tomorrow morning."

"Oh?" Shadow Weaver mused. "This information is most useful. Thank you, *Force Captain.* "

Chapter End Notes

> oooooh who spilled?? find out next time- anyways I really hope Adora's POV wasn't too boring or whatever and also i feel like scorpia was a bit out of character but uhhhh i tried. I also tried to add some more actual ship content lmao as much as i love writing plot that's also a thing i need to remember. catradora canon ahem. i hope you enjoyed

ahhhh,,,, there's a happy ending i promise :). thankies for reading!

Love and War

Chapter Notes

> ASGADJSHGAK ITS HERE. im done i finished this chapter im so sorry it took so long its literally been months im a horrible person anyways- pls pls enjoy!! This chapter is extremey unedited so apologies if there's a ton of mistakes here and there, I'm gonna try to go through the whole entire fic and fix some stuff at some point. Thx so much for reading, like seriously. Here we go-

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer

"Alright, everyone!" Commander Glimmer, as dubbed again by her mother, shouted at the gathered Princess Alliance.

It was early, so early that it was still dark outside, but everybody seemed alert and ready to win this war once and for all. There were around fifty volunteer fighters standing in the group with all the Princesses and Catra up front.

"This is our time!" Glimmer said. "We *will* win back Etheria!" A collection of cheers emitted from the crowd, from everyone except Catra. She had her arms crossed in front of her, staring off into space with a frown on her face. She was obviously still worried about Adora, they all were, but Scorpia had assured them that Adora was safe and everything was according to plan. Catra hadn't seemed to believe her, insisting that they would only know when they actually get there. She had been the most impatient during the week Adora had been gone and rushed everyone to get ready earlier that morning. This was understandable, though.

It wasn't a secret anymore that Catra loved Adora. She obviously wasn't yelling it from the rooftops, but the way she acted the last week and even before, along with the confirmation from the girl herself to Glimmer and Bow the week prior, it wasn't hard to put

two and two together. Catra still shot back at anyone who mentioned it but, of course, never denied. Not anymore. Glimmer had a feeling that this would be an advantage in battle because it seemed that Catra would do anything to keep Adora safe.

And also for revenge.

Revenge wasn't exactly the Rebellion's style but that didn't stop Catra from being increasingly adamant about getting payback for everything the Horde had done to her and to anyone she was ever close to, albeit that probably wasn't many.

Glimmer had kept a close eye on Catra ever since Adora had first brought her out of that ruin. She was an incredibly powerful and capable fighter (she was raised in the Horde, what do you expect?) even without her connections to Adora. This was one of the reasons why she was chosen to accompany Glimmer to the heart of the fight, taking on the Horde's leaders themselves.

Once Glimmer and Catra had teleported right to Hordak's sanctum, where Adora would be waiting for them, Adora would turn into She-Ra and the three would begin to fight Hordak and Shadow Weaver head-on until backup arrived. Said backup was a large portion of the small army they had put together after breaking through any lines of defense the Horde would've had time to set up, and after, being directed to the three's location by Scorpia. There was no chance the two leaders would be able to take them all, and with all of the Horde's army busy with the rest of the Rebellion's.

This plan was foolproof. It had to work. It had to.

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<u>Adora</u>

Adora didn't wake up in her bed.

At first she had to remind herself yet again that she wasn't in Bright Moon and tried to identify the strange feeling as a bed in

the Fright Zone but what she was laying on was harder than even those.

Something was wrong.

Without opening her eyes, she took in her surroundings the only way she could. Based on the hardness and coldness of the platform under her, she was on an inclined metal table, and from a subtle attempt to move her arm, she found that she had been restrained.

That's not good.

From the even-more-musty-and-metallic-and-machinery-smelling-than-the-rest-of-the-Horde scent filling her nostrils, she could only guess she was in Hordak's sanctum. And he was probably there right now. Even though she had no idea what time it was, she was sure she wasn't alone in there. She wasn't sure he ever left that place. She wasn't even sure if he slept at all.

Her suspicions were confirmed when she heard metal doors slide open and felt the all too familiar cold and dark sensation that Shadow Weaver carried around with her entered the room.

"Lord Hordak, the Fright Zone is prepared for attack." She said in her usual chilling voice.

Has the attack started already? Adora thought, still effectively pretending to be unconscious.

"Good." Hordak said. "Have the rebels arrived?"

Huh?

"Not yet, my Lord. Intel reports that they should be arriving shortly."

Intel? Had their cover been blown? Obviously, since she had woken up locked to a table. *There goes the element of surprise.*

Adora started to worry. The element of surprise was the core aspect of their plan of attack. What were they going to do now?

All of a sudden, a shock of electricity jolted through her and Adora's eyes shot open. She could see the sizzling outline of red around her signifying the use of dark magic. Her whole body was tensed up painfully and she saw Shadow Weaver staring directly at her. She had been hit with her magic.

"I *know* you are awake, Force Captain. Did you think you could fool *me* ?" She said threateningly and floated right up to where Adora was held in place. The closer she got, the more painful the spell got. Adora was powerless at this moment. She didn't know what to do. She didn't say anything, just tried a hard glare at Shadow Weaver.

After a couple more seconds of the staring contest between them, Shadow Weaver released her magic and turned back to Hordak, who hadn't said a word or moved at all since Adora had opened her eyes. Adora's body relaxed as much as it could in the restraints she was in once she was free of the magic and took a few deep breaths.

"What shall I do with this one, my Lord?" Shadow Weaver asked menacingly, throwing a weak gesture in Adora's direction.

"Kill her, before the rebels arrive. She has been nothing but a nuisance to us. She is of no use to us anymore." Hordak said plainly in his deep voice. He didn't even look once at Adora the entire time she had been there.

"Yes, my Lord." *My pleasure,* Adora heard hidden in the tone and the smile in Shadow Weaver's voice. The slits in her mask narrowed and she began to gather up a large amount of dark energy and electricity in her hands. Adora prepared for the worst.

"I think the fuck not!" A familiar voice shouted from somewhere, a voice she hadn't heard in over a week.

Catra swung into the room out of nowhere and planted a hard kick to the side of Shadow Weaver’s head, sending the sorceress flying halfway across the sanctum.

Glimmer appeared at Adora’s side a second later and teleported her out of the restraints holding her down.

“Dunno if you can tell ***(/s)*** , but they knew we were coming.” Glimmer yelled breathlessly and handed the Sword of Protection to Adora. “Doesn’t stop us though!” She smiled and nodded.

That was her cue.

“ *For the Honor of Grayskull!* ”

The magic she hadn't felt in a while flowed through her and then the familiar feeling of growth and power and strength finished her transformation.

It was great to be back, but there was no time for revelling in glory because as soon as she got sight of the already started battle, a beam (though she wasn't sure if she could even call it a beam since it was so dark) of shadow was shooting right at her face. She ducked under it and sent her own beam of light in the direction Shadow Weaver's attack came from.

She wasn't able to see if she'd hit her target as she heard a deadly battle cry from behind her. She spun around and saw Lonnie in the air, ready to attack with an electricity-crackling staff. Adora's sword was up to block the hit in an instant, she hadn't even thought about it.

Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Catra and Glimmer working together to take Shadow Weaver down. Hordak was nowhere to be seen.

After Lonnie was thrown backwards, she caught a glance of the door on the far wall sliding open. In the doorway stood Scorpia.

And there's backup, Adora thought. *No way we can lose.*

Then a realization hit her. Something was wrong. Very wrong. Scorpia was in the doorway.

But she was in the doorway alone.

Before Adora could even question it, the princess jumped straight at her, sharp pincers bearing. Adora blocked the attack again but Scorpia didn't stop.

"Scorpia! What are you doing?!" Adora shouted.

“What am I doing? What are *you* doing?” She responded with a grunt and pushed Adora away, the clang of claws against sword ringing in the room. She dared a glance over at Catra and Glimmer, who seemed to be fending for themselves quite well. Go figure.

The hairs on the back of She-Ra’s neck stood up and she turned fast and blocked another hit from Lonnie. Two against one? Like that was fair. Well, technically she *was* She-Ra and the abilities and strength that came with that was pretty much that of multiple people, so maybe it was fair? Anyways, no time to think about fairness, this is war. Gosh, author, time and a place.

Dodge. Block. Hit.

“Scorpia, wha-” Adora handspringed out of the way and felt eyes on her from behind. Chancing a turn of her head she found Shadow Weaver staring right at her, eyes narrowed. She swore she would see her smiling if not for the mask.

And then it hit her. Well, two things hit her. One was Lonnie’s electric staff which knocked her to the floor momentarily.

The other was what must have happened with Scorpia. It was the same thing that had happened to Adora.

Her memory was wiped.

Adora pushed up the blade of her sword with both hands to prevent being pincered in half by Scorpia.

Adora yelled in effort and shoved the princess off of her.

“Come on, Scorpia! You have to remember!” She pleaded as another attack came through.

All three opponents were back on their feet instantaneously. Scorpia took a preparing step back when they were all startled by an explosive sound and scream coming from somewhere else in the room.

Adora peeled her eyes off her attackers for a second and saw Glimmer being thrown across the sanctum. She gasped and swiped her sword in front of her, releasing a powerful wave of energy that knocked Scorpia and Lonnie several feet backwards and ran over to a recently hit-the-ground Glimmer.

“Glimmer! Are you oka-”

“Adora!” Glimmer shouted, her eyes wide and looking at something behind Adora’s head. She reached both arms out and the moment Adora looked around to see Scorpia and Lonnie right on top of her, about to attack, they all vanished into a flash of weak sparkles.

“Glimmer?!” She’d teleported them and herself away somewhere. Adora scanned the entire room only to see Catra, struggling against a somehow glowing red Shadow Weaver. Glimmer must have gone outside somewhere.

Before she could even stand up, an explosion sounded right above her head. In a flash, her sword transformed into a golden shield and she protected herself from the array of rocks and metal that came from the broken ceiling.

Dust settled and she stood up, trying to locate where that blast had come from.

Standing in the shadows was Lord Hordak himself, his right arm raised and pointing straight at her. A glow of red began emitting from something on his arm's armor and she quickly realized he was aiming a weapon at her. Some sort of powerful gun blaster.

She leaped out of the way of the shot just as it fired and it hit the spot on a machine behind her, right where her head had been moments earlier. Adora jumped away from the now sizzling machine as it too blew up.

The Horde's leader now had joined the battle. He took a step forward and lifted his weapon again. Adora could see his face now. He was *angry* angry.

The red light swirled around the tip of the gun and She-Ra stood her ground until it fired and she dodged. Adora groaned and looked around the room again. Glimmer still was nowhere to be found. Adora hoped she was okay.

Catra on the other hand, was right next to her, perched down close to the floor. She was breathing heavily, almost like a growl. With her out of harm's way for the moment, Adora heaved her sword so that the tip was pointing towards Hordak and summoned a greater amount of energy than normal in a blast of destructive blue light, squeezing her eyes shut. She grunted and swung the sword across the room midshot to target Shadow Weaver as well.

When she opened her eyes, Shadow Weaver had fallen to the floor, but Hordak had only been thrown off balance. Meanwhile the sanctum's wall had completely been blown off, exposing them all to the open air outside. It would've been nice to have the fresh air if they were anywhere but the Fright Zone, where the atmosphere was less than ideal and you'd be breathing more dust and musk than actual air.

The extra expense of magic was slightly more demanding than Adora had anticipated. She dropped to one knee for a moment and shook her head before standing up again.

And then it hit her. Again. This time, it wasn’t a thought, or a realization. It was something a lot worse than that. You know that thing that she'd been dodging for the last 30 seconds? Yeah, she had totally forgotten about it in her daze, and the red blast hit her straight on, flinging her against a metal wall. She hit her head, hard.

In all this chaos, her sword had fallen from her grip and clattered to the floor several feet away from where she inevitably landed. She felt herself… flicker; her power pulsed out, and she was dead exhausted.

"Adora!" Catra yelled from somewhere. Adora was still trying to clear her blurred vision, shaking her head. Her normally radiating hair had lost its glow and was hanging languid over her shoulders.

She didn't have much time to recover. When she looked up, seeing semi-clearly now, Catra was frozen in place, petrified by Shadow Weaver's lightning spell. Adora gasped.

"Catra!" She yelled. Probably not the best idea as Shadow Weaver turned her head in the direction of her voice and before she could even fully stand up, she was locked in the very same containment spell.

She'd never been caught in this before; it was a punishment reserved only for Catra back in the day (fuck Shadow Weaver amirite) so she didn't expect the jolt of pain that came with it. Her whole body was tingling and shaking, and it almost felt as if she were being electrocuted.

She immediately felt horrible that Catra had to endure this almost daily when the two of them would've been messing around together in the Fright Zone as kids. She couldn't believe that she'd ever considered this woman a good person and a valued teacher.

She cried out when she felt a heavy pressure pushing down on her, on top of the voltage feeling. She managed to lift her head a little bit and saw Shadow Weaver staring her down, all focus

turned on her. Adora felt as if she were being crushed, but there was nothing on top of her. It was all the sorceress's magic squeezing in on her.

Just then, in another corner, Adora saw a flash of light and Glimmer appeared, falling on her hands and knees. It didn't seem like Shadow Weaver had noticed.

It made no difference. As soon as the princess tried to stand up, and summon even the smallest bit of light, Glimmer collapsed entirely, having completely exhausted her magic.

Behind Shadow Weaver, Catra was still in the same situation Adora was in, minus the whole crushing weight part. But since Shadow Weaver has her main focus on keeping She-Ra at bay, Catra was able to get herself moving. Adora watched as she managed to escape the prison spell, even if only for a moment, and launched herself at Shadow Weaver, claws unsheathed.

Before she could do any damage, though, the same glowing red blast from Hordak's weapon that Adora had been hit by impacted her and sent her flying. She was dangerously close to the ledge to the outside created when She-Ra destroyed the wall. And she appeared to be unconscious.

Adora screamed and continued struggling to get out of Shadow Weaver’s hold, but with Catra down for the count, the sorceress’s power was even more focused on her and she could hardly move at all, let alone ease the horrible, strangling weight being pressed on top of her. It felt like her ribs were about to shatter, and her knees were digging too hard into the floor.

But she wouldn’t give up yet.

All this time, she had managed to keep herself from totally collapsing, staying on her hands and knees, using her arms and shoulder strength to remain somewhat upright and not lying flat on the floor. Her entire body strained from the effort but she still kept her gaze upward. This didn’t do wonders for her neck, which

felt like it was about to snap, but she needed to see what was happening around her.

And it's a good thing she did.

Next thing she knew, Hordak was walking over to an unconscious Catra on the ground. Glimmer was still passed out on the floor on the other side of the room, near where She-Ra's sword lay abandoned.

Catra was still breathing, Adora could see that from where she was, and her back was facing her. When the former Force Captain began moving, ever so slightly, evidence that she was now awake, Adora could see that too.

But before Catra could even comprehend what had happened to her, Hordak nudged her weak body with his foot, sending her straight over the ledge.

"No!" Adora yelled. With a newfound strength, she pushed herself further upright, making a sound she didn't even know she could make, a roar, almost, and picked herself off the ground. Her outburst released an explosive amount of magic energy that toppled Shadow Weaver's spell entirely. When she could discern the world around her again, she peeked over at where Catra had been knocked over the edge and saw two sets of clawed fingers gripping the broken wall and floor, greatly to Adora's relief.

Relief wasn't long lasting. After She-Ra's power eruption disoriented the two enemies she was still facing on, Hordak growled and took another step towards the ledge, and stomped hard right on one of Catra's hands.

Adora heard her cry out and the moment Hordak lifted his foot, one of her hands was missing from the edge of the wall.

What happened next was all a blur. Vaguely, Adora could tell that Glimmer had resurrected from her unconsciousness and shoved Adora's sword in her direction, the weapon skittering across the floor until Adora grabbed it. She didn't even think, it was if her

body moved on its own, and the next thing she knew was Shadow Weaver collapsed on the floor, bits of her mask and the red gemstone imbedded in it were strewn around her. She was powerless.

Less than a second later, she was at the ledge, where Catra and Hordak were. It felt like everything was going in slow motion. She-Ra jumped high in the air, and with all of her remaining strength, rammed the flat blade of her sword against Hordak's armor and weapon, shattering it. With no means of fighting back anymore, Hordak fell over too, now weak without his protective equipment holding him in place and supplying him with extra power. He was down, for real.

It was over.

The Horde had been defeated.

Etheria was finally at peace.

As Adora, still as She-Ra reached down to lift Catra up from her spot hanging over a cliff, she saw the rest of their small army looking in high spirits, with many Horde soldiers fleeing from the scene. They would be here soon.

Adora brought Catra off the end of the wall with ease and helped her to a safe spot back in the room where it had all started.

Adora sighed heavily, a smile creeping at her lips as she returned to her normal size and state. Tears sprung to her eyes as she collapsed onto Catra, squeezing her as tight as she could. Catra hugged her back with the same intensity.

Neither said a word for at least a minute until they finally pulled apart. Adora was breathing heavily, dangerously close to passing out from sheer exhaustion.

She looked Catra dead in the eyes and smiled, placing both hands on either of Catra's cheeks. She needed to tell her how she felt,

about everything that happened before she was sent on this mission. Now or never, I guess.

"Catra… I…" Her head spun and she blinked, and before she could get anything else out, everything went black.

.

Catra

Adora nearly took Catra down with her as she fell limply forward into her arms.

"Adora?!" Catra exclaimed, bringing her carefully down to the floor with the little strength she had left. "Adora!"

She was still breathing, which was a good sign, but her breaths were fairly shallow.

It was then that the rest of the princesses and Bow appeared in the opening doorway behind them. The rest except for Scorpia, of course…

"Glimmer!" Bow shouted the moment he saw his best friend lying nearly unconscious on the floor and ran over to her.

Catra looked over and saw Glimmer roll over and weakly said something to Bow, smiling. Bow smiled in return and said something back, Catra couldn't hear either of them because they were speaking so softly. Glimmer moved her gaze over to her and Adora with a worried look. Bow turned and mimicked her exact expression before standing up and jogging over to the two of them.

He knelt down beside Catra who had Adora's head lying in her lap.

"What happened?" He asked.

Catra looked down at the sleeping girl in her lap. "She overdid it," she said and looked back up to Bow, "a lot."

"But… we won." Bow said sympathetically and smiled at her. It was only then that Catra noticed what was going on in the rest of the sanctum. Princesses were exchanging hugs and smiles and exhausted cheers. A few were busy detaining the defeated Horde leaders. Catra began to zone out a bit, staring in the direction of the jaded celebration.

"She'll be okay." Catra spoke passively. "We all will."

"You better believe it!" Bow said, snapping her out of her daze. He put a hand on Catra's shoulder and smiled before walking back over to Glimmer who was sitting up now. Bow pulled out a device and pressed a few buttons and soon, a face appeared on the screen. They must have been contacting the Queen to alert her and the kingdom of their victory.

Catra sighed and brought her eyes back down to Adora. Her hair had fallen loose at some point and it spilled over Catra's lap. She absentmindedly played with it while staring down at the girl, deep in thought. She wasn't sure what she was even thinking about. All she knew was that Adora was alright. She looked so peaceful sleeping like that, not any hint that would indicate she was in any pain.

That's good.

Before long, the Queen herself showed up at the wreckage, having flown straight there after the call. She went around helping everyone who had physical injuries, including Adora and Glimmer, but those two were mostly magicked out and there wasn't much she could really do about that.

Healing only does so much, though. Everyone was still totally exhausted, and they were all just ready to go home.

Home. Catra wasn't sure when she had started thinking of Bright Moon as her home. It still hadn't been that long since she was thrown out of the Fright Zone that first time.

She let herself relax and shifted her focus to the movement of Adora's chest as she breathed. She matched her breaths with Adora's and her sense of time diminished. She was practically asleep while awake. She detached herself from reality for an unknown period of time, allowing herself to rest until a number of transport vehicles and methods arrived to take everyone to Bright Moon, because there was no way in hell they were *walking* all the way there.

Time Skip that was not nearly as long as I procrastinated to write this chapter =)))

Adora was still sleeping, she hadn't woken up since the final battle. But Catra wasn't worried; she was sure she would wake up, better than ever.

It was the day after, a lot of the fighters had gotten their rest, and festivities had started to celebrate the Horde's elimination. Everything was taking place here in Bright Moon, and Catra was confident it would last for a long time. It wasn't every day that you overthrow a malevolent destructive regime that had been at war for gods know how long.

Catra wasn't a party person. She didn't even know what a party even was until recently. She would much rather stay in her room with Adora. And she'd never give up the chance to take more naps.

She'd been on and off sleeping curled up at Adora's side, checking on how she was doing every now and then when she would wake up. Her dreams were vague and she hardly remembered any of them, allowing a proper restful sleep. Catra never slept well when she dreamed.

She had mostly recovered from being hit head on with a blaster and then knocked over the edge of a cliff while also trying to shake the feeling of Shadow Weaver's magic at the same time. Now she just wanted to sleep for the sole reason of sleeping and not having to deal with anything around her.

So here she was, sleeping peacefully, a nice and calm sensation rolling over her. She wasn't completely asleep yet, it hadn't been that long since she had woken up last and it was warm and comforting and she felt a purr rumbling in her chest without even realizing it. She snuggled into the warm pressure on her head and breathed deeply as it moved her hair around in a pleasant way. What was this? She hadn't felt anything like it the entire time she had been relaxing here. Could it be the daylight? No, it felt more like…

Catra jumped up and alert in an instant and saw Adora's hand raised above where Catra's head had just been.

"ADORA!" She shouted and stared at the awake and generally back to normal blonde in front of her. She couldn't help but admire the way her let down hair framed her face and the way her bright blue eyes crinkled when she smiled. Catra didn't know how long it had been since she'd seen Adora without her stupid ponytail and her stupid hair poof.

She ventured herself deep into those oceans of azure that were her eyes, which were gazing back into hers. She was astounded by her beauty as if she'd never seen her before in her life. There was something different now that they didn't have to worry about an army ready to attack them at any time, no matter which side of the war she was on.

Catra wasn't sure how long she had been captivated by Adora's eyes. Eventually she found the time and the place and blinked a couple of times.

"Adora-"

"Catra-"

The two tried to speak at the same time. Catra shook her head and gestured for Adora to continue.

Adora sighed. "Catra… I… I-"

“ADORA!” shouted a voice preceded by a shimmering flash. Glimmer and Bow had appeared in the room and practically leaped on top of Adora in her bed and gave her a crushing hug.

"Woah, hey!" Adora said and laughed as Bow and Glimmer jumped back.

"How are you feeling?" Glimmer asked way too loudly.

"Yeah, are you okay? I'm so glad you're awake!" Bow added.

Adora nodded. "Yeah, I'm… great!" She said. "A little sore I guess, but healing can only do so much, right? How are you doing?" She asked Glimmer. "Last I saw you were collapsed on the ground. Did you teleport both Scorpia and Lonnie out of there?"

Catra's tail flicked at the sound of Scorpia's name. She'd already figured that she'd had her memory erased, and that's why she was fighting them and totally sabotaged the plan, and she also figured she was the one who warned Shadow Weaver that they were coming. She pressed her lips together as she thought about Shadow Weaver again.

The old witch was locked away somewhere in Bright Moon - Catra wasn't sure where because from what she'd seen, Bright Moon did not have a prison - along with Hordak. She hoped she'd never have to see them again.

Glimmer had just finished talking about how she had ended up somewhere in the Fright Zone with the two assailants and had no idea where. It must've been pretty far away since Scorpia and Lonnie hadn't come back to Hordak's sanctum for the fight. Glimmer had teleported away from them, getting lost in the Fright Zone until she finally was back in the battlefield.

The initial teleport of two people had already taken a lot out of her, and the ones following were unfocused and blind; she was very lucky to get back in there at all.

"And then I resurrected and threw you your sword!" Glimmer exclaimed. Adora chuckled. "Then I just needed a recharge back here and I'm all better!... The same doesn't apply to you, you can't really recharge. Are you sure you're okay?" She asked the bedridden girl.

"Yeah, yeah, I just needed rest is all. We all did, I'm sure." Adora replied and smiled. She looked genuine and Catra believed that she was alright.

Glimmer jumped up and down. "Oh oh! I- How did you defeat Shadow Weaver and Hordak like that all in one go? That was *awesome* !"

Good question, Sparkles. Catra wasn't sure what had even happened at all. Last she knew was hanging by one hand off a cliff. What's with she and Adora and cliffs? She'd heard a loud crashing and suddenly She-Ra was standing over her, stretching a hand down to pull her up.

She hadn't asked anyone about it because she spent the last 24 hours here with Adora and honestly didn't care much about anything else. She hadn't even thought to ask at all.

Adora pondered this for a moment, like she didn't even know the answer herself.

"I… I'm not sure." She said. "I guess… I guess, I saw Catra in danger and…" She turned her gaze toward Catra who felt her face start to heat up.

"Pshh, wow, you like me?" Catra joked, trying but failing to be cool about it.

"Yeah," Adora said, "I do."

Her soft gaze bore into her soul. Once again, Catra found herself lost and speechless, her face probably as red as her shirt. Another unknown amount of time passed by, and Catra could see Bow and

Glimmer give each other a knowing look out of the corner of her eye.

"Okay! See you at the party, bye guys!!" Glimmer shouted suddenly, shocking Adora and Catra out of their trance, before disappearing into thin air with Bow.

Both girls were silent for a moment until Adora started laughing. Catra smiled and looked down at her lap and twiddled her fingers. She looked back up when Adora put a hand on top of hers.

"So I heard there's a party?" She said, her face inches away from Catra's. The feline froze for a couple of seconds. She blinked.

"Yeah, wanna go?" She replied and Adora leaned back again.

"Yeah."

Gods, when did this get so awkward?

Catra cleared her throat and stood up from the bed. "It's been going on for a long time. Everyone's celebrating your victory."

Adora sat up straighter and shuffled herself on top of the covers and playfully punched Catra's arm. "Hey, *our* victory." She said and smiled. Catra rolled her eyes.

"Whatever helps you sleep at night, princess. That was all you, just admit it."

"No," Adora said smugly, "if you didn't show up, I would've been dead so, there, you helped. Also, you like, fought Shadow Weaver off for a long time."

Catra pursed her lips and sighed.

"Ugh, whatever." She crossed her arms and shifted most of her weight onto her right leg. "Now are you gonna get up or not?" She reached out to help Adora stand, not that she needed it, Catra just wanted to hold her hand. No use in hiding that. Not

anymore. She didn't know what the heck was up with Adora and how she felt, but Catra knew one thing for sure. She was extremely in love with Adora.

But she didn't tell her that. She wouldn't have understood anyway. Instead, she lifted the hand that was holding Adora's and prompted her to twirl around under her arm like a ballroom dancer.

Adora giggled and sighed. "Isn't it nice to be free?"

"Free?"

"Yeah, of the Horde, of the war, everything. I just woke up like ten minutes ago and it all seems so different already. It's like the air is cleared, the atmosphere is just… different, better. Don't you feel it?"

Catra bit the inside of her cheek. “Yeah, I guess… Listen, I never got to apologize for the way I was acting before you left-”

“It’s alright.” Adora put both her arms over Catra’s shoulders and clasped them behind her neck. “It’s in the past. Look where we are now.”

She smiled and Catra’s heart skipped a beat. She couldn’t see her own face but she was sure it was pulled embarrassingly soft. Her eyes slid down to rest on Adora’s lips without realizing and she quickly turned them away. She swore she could see Adora blushing in her peripheral vision.

“Uh, well,” Adora cleared her throat and removed her arms from atop Catra’s shoulders; she missed the warmth almost immediately; “Um, party, right?” She asked. Catra blinked a couple of times.

“Uh, yeah, yeah, we should… get ready.”

Adora turned around and walked over to the other side of her bed. “So, whaddya wanna wear?”

“I dunno.” Catra replied and shrugged. “What do you want me to wear?”

“Oh, I don’t want to choose for you. That’s your decision.”

“Adora, I will wear whatever you tell me to wear and I will love it. C’mon, you know I’m not good at decision making.”

Adora pursed her lips. “Uh, alright… Y’know what, I think I have just the thing.” She rummaged around in a wardrobe against the wall. “Glimmer gave this to me a while ago, but it was a little too small. Plus, it’s not like I wear dresses often.” She turned around to reveal a maroon skin-tight dress with sleeves that would go to about halfway down her forearms. Catra had never worn a dress in her life, but she was willing to try. For Adora.

“Uh, sure.” She said.

“Wait, really?” Catra nodded. “O-okay, I really didn’t think you’d agree to that. Ahem, I think you will look absolutely gorgeous in this dress.”

Catra blushed a light pink and went to take the dress from Adora’s hands. “...You think?”

“Yep,” Adora smiled, “do you wanna try it on?” She gestured to the bathroom door.

“...Sure.” Catra said. *Geez, why is this so awkward?* “Uh, what are you gonna wear?”

“I think I’ve got something. I’ll change out here while you do. See you in a bit!” She said and chuckled. Catra raised her eyebrows but turned and headed towards the restroom to change into the dress she’d been given.

The author decided it was extremely unnecessary to describe the sequence of Catra changing clothes. She’d opted to wear black leggings underneath the dress, only because she hadn’t *not* worn pants for the last nineteen years of her life. Once she was done,

she waited a few minutes until Adora confirmed that she had finished changing too. It would've been quite the awkward encounter if Catra had walked out while Adora wasn't done yet.

Catra opened the door and did a double take as to what Adora had chosen to wear. She'd never seen her wear anything near like this before. She wore a very bright and very white full tuxedo with the front buttons of the blazer undone to reveal a cropped black top. She had left her hair down, something Catra still wasn't quite used to, but clipped her bangs up to the top of her head.

She nearly choked on her own spit. "Uh, wow, Adora, you look-great…" Catra said and cleared her throat, still frozen in the doorway she had been attempting to leave from.

Adora gasped giddily. "So do you! Oh my gosh I've never seen you in a dress before. Do you… like it?"

She hadn't even bothered to check her own appearance until now. Catra looked down at her view of the dress she was wearing, then turned again and looked in a mirror that stood by the wall. The dress wasn't anything big or special, good, that's not how Catra had wanted to look. It accented her curves and seemed to fit perfectly, not too tight or anything. She could freely move around in it for the most part, too. She hoped Adora didn't mind the hole she'd ripped in it to let her tail through.

And she… looked nice. "Yeah," she said, "I think I really do." She looked back up at her face. Her hair was a mess, she hadn't really done anything to it since they'd gotten back, so it was a little bit of a disaster. "Um, y'know," she began, "I might… put my hair up… What do you think?" Catra asked and turned toward Adora who had a grin plastered on her face.

"I think, you should do whatever you want with your hair." She said and Catra put a hand up to the tragedy that was her hair, thinking for a minute.

"You got a hair tie? I might need, like, sixty…" ***(/hyp)***

Time Skip, again

The party ballroom type setup wasn't all too different from the Princess Ball she'd gone to with…

There were fancy lights and music and food and people dancing and having a good time. Catra hoped she could too, since the last time she was at one of these things she kind of almost destroyed an entire kingdom.

The only difference was, there were a *lot* more people. It was only to be expected because princesses and civilians alike were joining, unlike the princess invite only back in the Kingdom of Snows. All the lands in Bright Moon were being used, so not everyone was crammed into one room, thankfully.

Catra trailed right beside Adora as they entered into the main ballroom, where they were hoping to find their friends, and just as they imagined, Glimmer, Bow, Perfuma, and Entrapta were standing and talking by a buffet table. Well, three of them were talking, Entrapta was closely examining a piece of tiny food, using her hair as a seat and muttering something into a recorder.

"Adora, Catra, hey!" Bow said upon seeing them.

"What's up?" Catra greeted and Adora smiled and waved. When they reached the table their friends were standing at, Adora immediately grabbed some of the food and scarfed it into her mouth. Oh, I guess she hasn't eaten in like two days, whoops.

Catra chuckled and turned her head to examine the large room again. All colored lights were shining all over from the tall ceiling and streamers hung on the walls. It wasn't particularly extravagant, probably since they set this up in a pretty short period of time after the news was spread. The music was just background noise and indecipherable voices bounced around the walls, someone yelling out an occasional cheer or something.

They'd won. They deserve it.

“Catra!” Glimmer shouted, pulling Catra out of her thoughts. She turned her head back forward and found Glimmer jumping up and down like a little kid. “Aaah! I *love* your dress!!” She yelled with way too much enthusiasm.

“You would, wouldn’t you. Adora said *you* gave it to her.” Catra snickered.

“Well, yeah, but it looks totally perfect on you!” She exclaimed. Catra blushed. She still was *not* used to receiving compliments from other people.

“Uh, thanks, I guess.” She said, avoiding eye contact and rubbing the back of her neck, which was actually exposed for once since her mass of hair was tied up into almost a high ponytail.

Glimmer squealed again and jumped over back to whatever conversation she’d been having with Bow. Catra felt an arm link around hers and turned to see Adora smiling at her.

As if on cue, the lights dimmed slightly and the music changed. Everyone started barreling onto the large open space of the dance floor, Adora and Catra following suit. It was no question for either of them who was going to dance with who.

It was a slower song, similar to the one Catra had shared a dance with Adora to back at Princess Prom. There wasn’t really any choreography or anything this time though, they just kind of did whatever felt natural and followed each other's steps like they were their own. At some point the two ended up facing each other with Adora’s hands gently gripping Catra’s. And then they just kind of stayed that way, swaying and side-stepping, not breaking eye contact a single time.

Adora sighed and looked down at their hands. “Catra, I *really* need to tell you something.” She said and ran her thumb across Catra’s fingers.

“What is it?” Catra asked as calmly as she could, but she could feel anxiety bubbling in her stomach already. Adora sighed again

and looked to the side, pursing her lips. She didn't say anything for a while, appearing to be thinking about what she should say. Catra wasn't sure what would happen next.

"This is- wow, this is gonna sound really stupid… Oh… no, I- *what* ? Ugh, how do I explain this?" She leaned her head back, still holding onto Catra's hands.

"Um, are you okay?" Catra asked.

Adora groaned. "Yes, yeah. I'm just- I'm just gonna start from the beginning.

Okay, so, after we… uh, before I left for the Fright Zone, I went to go see Light Hope, y'know, the hologram lady. Entrapta said she did something to her programming or whatever and that I needed to see her again at some point. I was afraid she messed something up but… I guess it was a good thing? Light Hope told me that she had been programmed to uh, to keep She-Ra from forming attractions, and that there was also some super weapon in the middle of the planet that apparently I was supposed to set off if Light Hope hadn't been restored to her previous settings, so, yeah, it definitely was a good thing…"

Catra wasn't completely sure where this was going but she listened intently.

"And then, and then, she said that she'd- or they'd messed with my brain or something? And I had no idea what she meant by that and then she told me that basically the comprehension of… of love, was stolen from me…"

Catra's heartbeat quickened but she remained silent, allowing Adora to continue.

"And- and she said she could give it back…" Adora swallowed and Catra just stared at her. "And- and then, she did, as soon as I left, but they wouldn't let me see you before going on my mission." Adora sounded like she was about to cry. She took a deep breath.

“So basically… what I’m trying to say is… I… love you.” Her voice broke. “And I’m pretty sure that’s what you were trying to tell me before, but I was too stupid to understand-”

“Adora. Shut up.” Catra stated sternly, and then smiled. “But… yeah, that’s what I meant…”

They stared into each other’s eyes for several moments before Adora said something again.

“Catra… Can I…”

Catra knew exactly what she meant, or at least she hoped she did. She nodded and started leaning forward.

Fireworks. She didn't even know what those were but that's what she felt as soon as their lips met. Harmony, synchrony, everything felt perfect, it was like Catra’s world had shifted back onto its axis after veering off for such a long time. Is this what Adora had meant by *free* ?

They were each other’s compliment, like this is how it was supposed to be.

They weren’t at a party anymore, Catra had ascended to someplace different. No one else was around them, the music had faded away and had been replaced with the sound of a waterfall rushing in her ears. Nothing could compare.

It didn’t last forever, much to Catra’s dismay, but she realized that she, too, would need to breathe at some point. Not much time had passed when Adora pulled her lips away from Catra’s, their foreheads leaning against each other. She couldn’t keep that dumb smile off her face, and found that Adora was having the same problem. Catra fell forward and buried her head in Adora’s shoulder, clinging onto her like she was the only thing keeping her alive.

And Adora had done the same, her face resting in Catra’s hair against her right ear.

And they stayed like that for a long time. Catra wished everything could just stay like that, she wanted this to last forever.

And she could tell Adora felt the same way.

Chapter End Notes

> There we have it boys, thats the end. Jesus christ this has been a trip. So basically I've been a terrible author and procrastinated on every single chapter in this fic since the very beginning but a whole 2 years later I'm finally finished with it. My god. This is the very first fanfic that I've finished in my entire life and I'm forever grateful for the folks who kept screaming at me to update because that's the only reason I actually finished this. Omg. So I actually had planned to make this chapter longer but then i was at 7500 words and was like,,,, I'd like to sincerely apologize to Scorpia because um well y'know, but that's been the plan since I started this two years ago and I really didn't want to or know how to change it so uh scorpia i love you skfshbdhf thank you thank you thank you for reading, this got way more reads than I ever thought it would so like shdfbkfhksjf. Seriously sorry im such a horrendous updater im making no promises that it won't happen again, but i will be trying to focus on my other she ra fic when im done (edit: so that was a fucking lie). So throughout this ive discovered that im actually not very good at writing romance, like, im just bad, but well i tried. I write plot over anything else so if I ever write something else it'll probably be more plot centered like this one ended up being but uh yeah ,,,,,,,, that's all folks

End Notes

This is the first story I'm posting on ao3 because I feel like this story is actually not shit and this site seems more popular than wattpad soooooooooooo
hi my names ren and i have problems

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!